how you besiege me (and feed me)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/22575673.

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Mature

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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side bow/glimmer, Future Fic, Post-War, 80s lore scrapped for spare parts, Lack of Communication, characters are bad at feelings, References to Depression, Mutual Pining, Self-Destructive Tendencies, Implied Sexual Content, Post-Season/Series 04, Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence

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by nuttyshake

Summary

It was natural, right? To want that for herself: someone to tell her who she was, in her entirety, in her truth, whenever she forgot. For her heart to lurch forward and go *God, give it to me, where do I start* and then fall flat when it came up empty, like expecting a three-course meal only to end up swallowing air.
Adora had always been good at self-control - one of the perks of a life spent in service of whatever she thought was the greater good. But now this *hunger* had started in her, and there was nothing preventing it from developing further.
And it was all Catra's fault.

A year after the war, Adora returns to Etheria. She finds everything has changed, except the thing that really should have.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Chapter 1

Eternia was beautiful this time of year.

Adora had always been one to enjoy the sunshine and all sorts of outdoor activities, even before finding out everything the world outside the Horde had to offer. But Eternia - it was designed like a literal wonderland, sky painted bright purple and streaked with golden lights. It was a summer for travelling to the Pink Cliffs at the edge of the known universe, for dancing around bonfires, for watching the stars fall on the beach - and she was spending it holed up in Castle Grayskull, listening to her people's complaints all day without so much as a snack break in-between.

This morning, the court had gathered in the throne room for the daily proceedings, involving, as they had for some time now, some villager from far away demanding the princess punish some no-good sorcerer who'd been caught trying to poison her and her wife. A scene which was the order of the day for everyone born and raised in (or, in Adora's case, abducted from) Eternia, but also combined the planet's two most interesting defining features, which were a penchant for gossip at any hour of the day and on any available subject (it had taken Adora a long time and quite a few shows of power to get her guards to stop commenting on her forehead) and the unbridled, wide-spread use of magic even in the most common everyday situations. Everyone had magic in themselves, to some degree, but some, more gifted than others, used their talents for evil - in this case, apparently, trying to make happily married women fall in love with them by slipping a potion in their drinking well.

Adora always hoped her subjects didn't notice how out of it she was - on her arrival, she'd promised to give all of herself to this planet, just as she'd given her all to Etheria - but given the hateful words the villager had thrown at her for not having found the culprit yet, she'd clearly failed this time.

Spinnerella and Netossa, invited by Adora for the occasion, were perched on two smaller thrones by her sides and followed the exchange closely. Their eyes were flickering back and forth between princess and subject, probably expecting the conflict to escalate some more, but Adora had to disappoint on that front, too. She was known all around the kingdom as a lenient princess, who encouraged her subjects to be honest and open with her, starting with the very way they addressed her, and she had neither the desire nor the necessary strength left to go on a power trip now. She *had* been weak, she *had* been tired, and she could freely admit she'd slowed down the investigations for her own personal gain.

So maybe a year of ruling alone on Eternia, away from all of her friends, had taken a toll on her. Maybe hearing about She-Ra's adventures in the Princess Alliance all the time made her long for simpler times. Maybe she had decided to take advantage of this particular case to summon some old friends and go on one last mission together, and everyone but Spinnerella and Netossa had been too busy to answer the call.

That was alright. She had written letters to everyone in a rare fit of excitement, already picturing how it would be to have Bow and Glimmer there with her, maybe even reuniting more of the gang back, if she was lucky. But the moment they were sent out, she had been filled with dread. It had been a year. Her longing to see her friends again battled with her need to stay blissfully unaware of what time and distance and obligations had done to all of them.

But she hadn't been close enough to Spinnerella and Netossa to notice that anything was amiss or for them to notice anything different about her - while still close enough that Adora was enjoying having them around. They'd brought cupcakes for her, and gifts from everyone who couldn't come, and they'd really helped liven up the place. Nothing had changed in the time she'd known them - they, at least, were safe.

Or so she'd thought. "So, Adora -" Netossa started, hesitant.

After holding court and promising to look more into the matter, they retired to Adora's chambers to catch up. Adora had really put in an effort to make them more hospitable - brought in poofy armchairs, flower vases, let the morning air in - but the truth was, her chambers had just as much personality to them than her single Force Captain room in the Horde would have. A solitary painting of her family was the only decoration: her parents, dead when the planet had been attacked by Horde Prime, nearly two decades before the Princess Alliance had managed to defeat him; her twin brother, who she still had no news from, but who was thought to be hiding away somewhere; and her, a baby still in her mother's arms. She'd helped save the universe with nothing but the power of friendship and pure force of will - including what, unbeknownst to her, was her homeland - and she'd been welcomed back to an empty room and empty castle and told it was her reward.

Adora moved her attention away from the portrait and to the two women, who were somewhat excitedly drinking their tea. "Yes?"

"We're not actually here… just to help with your investigation."

Adora didn't think she could still blush, so it was a relief to feel it coming onto her cheeks. "Oh! I'm sorry. I've been so rude, I've barely given you a tour of the place - and I imagine you'll want the rest of the day off-"

"No, Adora," snickered Spinnerella. "I mean, yes, we would love a tour. But we're here because we have very important news to tell you."

Adora stood still and waited for the news, giving her tea another swirl. No one spoke, but Spinnerella and Netossa both sported enigmatic smiles and had their hands intertwined on Spinnerella's lap - no, belly.

It dawned on her. "You're…?" She was afraid to finish her sentence in case she read it all wrong and accidentally offended

them, but they were smiling and nodding along like crazy, jumping at the chance to explain.

“Four months now!” Spinnerella said. “We’re still trying to wrap our heads around it, honestly.”

“Oh, don’t listen to her. I knew this would happen,” Netossa cut in.

“Uh-huh. That’s why you burst into tears when I gave you the news.”

“I was happy! We’re so, so happy, Adora.” And she grabbed Adora’s arm and shook it repeatedly to show just how much.

Adora was breathless. In a good way, sure - Spinnerella and Netossa were more in love than anyone else she knew, and while it was a little unexpected, she also believed they were ready for it - but one that also kind of hurt. “Congratulations. Wow, I… I can’t believe it.”

“We want everyone to be there before the birth,” Spinnerella said, “so we’ll be celebrating for the entire week leading up to it. Just a few dinner parties, I doubt I’ll be able to move much - but we’d really like it if you could join us.”

“Sure!” Adora yelled out before she could stop herself, pushing down all of her fears about going back home - no, but Eternia was her home, she forgot - before they closed off her throat. “Sure, of course, you didn’t even have to ask, I’m- wow.”

Still, while Spinnerella and Netossa rambled on about what they were planning and how excited they were for everyone to be back together again, Adora couldn’t help but glance at her desk. The letters she got in response to her summoning were still laid out there, and by now she almost had their contents memorized.

Glimmer wrote excitedly about the rebuilding of Bright Moon, how princesses and sorcerers from all over Etheria were coming in every day to help. Relationships between kingdoms were being re-

established, and so was trade. Former Horde soldiers who'd either defected or helped with the war against Horde Prime had been granted an official pardon and were slowly being integrated into society. She told Adora about Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio, who were currently serving as Bright Moon guards but would be allowed to switch careers whenever they figured out what they actually wanted to do.

Not much was said about Glimmer herself outside of her queenly duties, which wasn't out of the ordinary for her friend. Hints about her state of mind were related in Bow's letter, instead. He was worried about her never taking a break, but building Etheria back up brought her great satisfaction, and she did seem very happy. She spent a lot of downtime with Frosta and the other princesses, so he didn't see her as much anymore, and when he did, it was mostly so Glimmer could be updated on how his fathers were doing at the library, now that so much information had resurfaced about the First Ones and the history of the planet. Adora could guess he didn't feel too good about it, but by the measured, uncharacteristically put-together style of his writing you'd never know.

There was no letter from Catra, and Adora should've known better than to expect one by now. The two of them hadn't talked since Adora had left Etheria, and hadn't had a semi-friendly conversation since their day at the Crystal Castle, which had ended with Catra leaving Adora hanging off a cliff. Adora hadn't even gotten to say goodbye, because the new princess of the Magicats only ever showed up on official business and wouldn't have come to the send-off party even if anyone had thought to invite her.

At worst, Catra didn't even know she was gone. At best, she knew and just didn't care. They might have worked together to stop the Horde years before, but that was the extent to which their relationship had been fixed. They'd never seen each other again afterwards.

It wasn’t like Adora missed her. Missing someone, she found, was a more active feeling. She missed Bow and Glimmer, for example, because she thought of them often and wished she could be with them. She missed Etheria, as much as she didn’t want to, because she constantly compared it to Eternia and found the former better than the latter. *Missing* required periodical acknowledgment of the fact. But Adora never thought about Catra if she could help it; whatever had been between them, she’d grown out of, like an old pair of shoes she still admired but never wanted to wear again.

The real problem wasn’t missing her - it was, rather, that she permeated Adora. She inhabited all of Adora’s memories and flowed in her bloodstream; she was in the way Adora spoke and in the way she moved. She could no sooner cut Catra out of her life than she could cut off part of herself - all she could do was hide her away. Keep her locked up in some remote part of her brain, so that Catra wouldn’t cross her mind as often and Adora wouldn’t still expect to find her at the foot of her bed at night.

It had worked well enough during the war, but now that that distraction was gone, it was getting harder by the day. This person had been beside her through thick and thin, and now she was leading a completely different life, in a completely different place, with people who weren’t Adora to make her laugh. Thinking about it made her feel weird inside, and she should’ve been over it by now, and yet -

She watched Netossa rub her hands gently over Spinnerella’s baby bump like Adora wasn’t even in the room, Adora’s fingers inching towards Bow and Glimmer’s separate letters to read them once more. Being adamant to forget had never made Adora too good with change.

That night, her reflection mocked her. Her hair tied in a bun, eyes dry and sparkless, frame crumpling under the pressure of keeping her head high and back straight. It was hard to believe that this

was the same person who'd carried the sword of She-Ra not too long before.

Is this who you are now? The one who should've been removed from her mind long ago taunted her.

She tilted her head to the left, then to the right. Her mirror image did the same, but it was - unsettling. Her own self-perception hadn't shifted at all, mostly because she hadn't allowed herself to think about it, but she'd grown into a stranger while she wasn't looking. This pristine ghost of a girl, long-faced and tired and lonely; she didn't much like herself now.

Is this who you were meant to be?

She tried to call for She-Ra's powers, as she'd already done a thousand times after breaking the sword and stopping the Heart of Etheria from firing - but to no avail. The magic had vanished from her, leaving only a light thrumming behind, and none of her attempts to get it back had worked so far.

Still, Adora loved being useful; and so when Eternia had latched onto her for help, and given her an identity back, and expected her to fill those shoes immediately, she had. And because Adora was nothing if not dedicated to her task, she'd never taken them off.

Her friends must've realized she was different, but decided not to comment on it. Change was a part of life, after all. All of them would continue to change throughout their lives, year after year, and so would the world around them - and Adora would stay here, crystallized in her final form, and miss all of it. How could she ever catch up with the rest of them now? How could she catch up with herself? Where did she even start?

She heard a different voice in her head now. Older, kinder, fighting to make herself heard among the mess. *You need to go back to the beginning. The very beginning.*

The day before leaving for Etheria, her hair was back in a ponytail for the first time in years.

Catra had no idea what she was doing at a party for princesses, but she had been invited, and Scorpia had somehow managed to convince her that it would've been rude not to show up. Even though the net princess and the wind princess weren't connected in any way to the Magicat kingdom - or any kingdom at all, really - Catra could use all the allies she could get, since she'd been living on the other princesses' benevolence since the peace talks. She'd helped in the war, sure, and she'd been rewarded for it; but she'd also been a last-minute addition to their ranks, and no one ever passed the chance to point it out. If push ever came to shove, she'd either be isolated from the rest or the weakest link.

So she held her head high, her hands in place behind her back, as conversation stopped and the crowd parted around her. Not respectfully, no; all of her public appearances were still received with suspicion, at best, and downright spite at worst. But they still parted for her. She'd caught their attention, got them talking about her. That was all that mattered to Catra as she looked around, smirk in place, for the hosts.

She could make an effort for one night. Hang out with Scorpia and Entrapta, maybe, who she hadn't seen in a while. They were both so hyped for this event they'd probably just string Catra along the whole time and she would barely have to talk. She was pretty confident in her ability to get through the party unscathed.

She looked for them right away, eager to see some friendly faces - and found Adora instead.

It was weird; she seemed to fill space differently. If Catra hadn't been attuned to her every move, if she hadn't felt the distinct throbbing in the middle of her chest, she would've needed a moment to adjust her memory of Adora to this new version of her. She looked exactly the same; so much so, that she looked more

like someone trying very hard to give their best Adora impersonation, but failing to pick up on what exactly made her… her.

She curtsied in front of Spinnerella and Netossa, who were ecstatic to see her and immediately complimented her dress. She had perfected her curtsying technique, so that all that trying-too-hard, endearing Adora awkwardness was gone. Catra had flared up instinctively at the sight of her, as she always did - whether out of joy, fury or despair, because everything she felt about Adora, she always felt too much - but she was already deflating, sinking back into the familiar cold.

Adora's arms hung limp by her side while Netossa threw her arms around her, and then some of the other princesses. No one commented on it or seemed to notice anything was wrong. Catra was outraged on Adora's behalf, and even moreso on her own. It didn't matter that it had been a year since Adora had left Etheria, and even more since she'd left the Horde, and that she should've been out of Catra's mind by now: these were still the people who'd taken Adora away from her, and they didn't even notice it wasn't really Adora.

She wouldn't cause a scene, though. She still had so much to make up for that it would be a long time until she could ruin another planet-wide event again. She just waited until the princesses gave "Adora" some space to breathe, and then she snatched her away from the buffet table before anyone could follow her there, 'cause for being such terrible friends, they sure were *smothering*.

The small spark of surprise in Adora's eyes almost caught her off-guard, but Catra didn't let that stop her. She was tired of being messed with. Torturing her in private was one thing, but to do it in public, in front of everyone else, and while they were trying to keep the peace?

Catra shoved Adora and watched her regain her balance immediately. It only made her angrier.

“What game are you playing?”

Adora took a few seconds to register those words, blinking. Catra suddenly got a flash of Princess Prom - her dipping Adora, her leg firm between Catra’s, the soft little gasp in Catra’s ear, the flicker of Adora’s eyes to Catra’s lips.

Finally, Adora spoke. “I… what?”

It was the most unsatisfying response to anything ever, which, she had to admit, kind of threw a wrench in her suspicions. Still, because Catra was nothing if not prideful, and the alternative was still too unsettling to consider, she went on: “Drop it. This is your worst interpretation to date.”

Adora’s confusion only deepened in the next few seconds, before realization dawned in her eyes. “You think I’m Double Trouble?”

“I don’t think, I know.”

“Yeah, you really *don’t* think. That hasn’t changed.” And then she shoved her back, to Catra’s surprise. They hadn’t exactly parted on good terms - or any terms, really - but Adora had never been this flippant towards her, this - dismissive. She always either worked herself into an indignant rage until she was red in the cheeks, or… was that a smirk right there?

Catra really couldn’t be sure. It looked more like a grimace than anything, and the vicious spark that usually came with it was nowhere to be seen. Maybe she was just that desperate to find a connection between the Adora she knew and the Adora she now had in front of her - someone who she was *definitely* not an authority over.

She could’ve just told her all that. Apologized for never sending a letter, told her she’d missed her and that she still wished they could patch things up, but mostly that she was worried about her. Scorpia’s voice in her head told her it was the most constructive thing to do, but her pride warped her words so that it all came out as a low, breathy: “What the hell happened to you?”

"What happened, I come back after a year to support my friends and I get attacked, how should I feel-"

"You know what? Forget it. I don't know why I bother." *It's not worth it*, Catra told herself.

She hadn't planned to get up close and personal with Adora tonight, and now that she'd made sure there was no shapeshifting involved, it was no use to keep the conversation going. Catra was doing better, that's what everyone told her; but part of healing was letting go of what was too broken to fix. Scorpia and Entrapta had been nice enough to forgive her when they were under no obligation to, but the cut between her and Adora ran much, much deeper. She'd worked hard not to let her life revolve around her since Adora had been gone, and she wouldn't give up the second Adora showed up again.

She started to walk away - *it's not worth it, it's not* - and back to the party, which, at the moment, was just a bunch of people who struggled to tolerate her. But Adora didn't let it slide.

"Catra," was all she said, all it took. There Adora went, trying to keep her from going with just the sound of her name, knowing Catra would shake her off but eventually choose to stay put anyway. There they were, rehearsing the same, tired old script, and nothing ever changed. "Don't I even get a hello?"

As Catra looked her over again, a pain throbbed at her center. "Hello."

"Good. We're off to a good start. Next you should ask me how I am. That's how a conversation with someone you haven't seen in a long while is supposed to go."

Catra scoffed. "You've grown prissy. The Adora I knew would have accepted being slammed against a wall as the conversation starter that it was."

Now *that* was a smirk. Stiff and tentative, maybe, and betrayed by an air of superiority - but a smirk nonetheless. "My bad. Etherian

customs fly right past me sometimes."

"Stop being so dramatic, you've only been gone a year."

"A really long year." She frowned, and Catra got the distinct impression that Adora wanted her to ask about it, so she did what she did best and defied Adora's expectations by staying silent. Adora's shoulders dropped when she realized she'd have to lead the conversation herself. "I'm actually glad to be here again. Eternia is cool, but it's just not the same without Bow and Glimmer and -" she paused for a second and shrugged, "everyone."

And me? Catra wondered, but would never ask. *Have you missed me? Have you thought about me, even once?*

But that was a stupid question. This wasn't the first time Adora left her behind. If she hadn't spared a thought for her after leaving the Horde, she definitely hadn't spared a thought for her when she'd left to rule Eternia. Catra hadn't really tried to turn things around either: Adora had made it crystal clear she wanted nothing to do with her, and so the best reparation Catra could make to her former best friend was to respect that wish.

Only all of that had been for nothing, because Adora seemed determined to find entertainment in Catra's discomfort instead of keeping her distance as Catra had expected her to. Sure, it was just small talk - actively avoiding each other all night would have made things awkward for all parties involved - but faking disinterest, struggling for words, having to read into everything Adora did, was already taking a toll on her. She wanted to slip into easy, casual conversation with Adora that would make her feel half alive again or not bother at all.

"Well, things are not the same around here, too. We've been hard at work almost non-stop." With a cutting glare, Catra stared down a princess who was going to steal the last tuna sandwich from the table, sending the poor girl running. It was a painful reminder of how far she still had to go with them, but she did get to shove

that sandwich in her mouth, so it wasn't all bad. "I mean, not *me* specifically, because they don't trust me enough to let me do anything, but you know, everyone else."

"But you're doing your part, right? With the Magicats."

Catra laughed bitterly. "Sure. The princesses oversee things above ground, I oversee what goes down below. It's like being on fancy house arrest."

To her surprise, Adora chuckled too. "I'm starting to think that's just what ruling is. I don't know why we glorified the idea so much when we were kids."

She remembered nights spent up on the roof, picturing what it would be like when they had the world in their hands. Catra crying on her shoulder in bed as Adora held her closer, comforting her with promises of everything they'd build together. "Yeah," Catra felt the pain again and had to turn away from Adora, just in case it showed on her face, too. "The Horde propaganda was that strong, I guess."

She felt Adora reaching to turn her around again, and no matter how warm her hand was, she was determined to swat it away and focus on the buffet table - until Bow came to the rescue, grabbing Adora and wrapping her up in a bear hug. "Adora! There you are!" And without so much as a hello to Catra - seriously, it was like she wasn't even there - he dragged Adora away, blabbing on and on, "I've missed you so much - the Best Friend Squad is finally back together again - how was the journey here-"

Catra just watched her go. She didn't miss it, though, when Adora looked back towards her. She wished she had; now she'd be thinking about it all night.

She was eating a few tarts, still looking around for Scorpia and Entrapta, when Double Trouble sidled up to her. "You thought she was me?" They wore a fur coat over a purple tuxedo, and honestly, knowing them as well as she did, that checked out. "I

take my craft very seriously, you know. I could never give such a lousy performance."

Catra gave them the side-eye. "What do you mean lousy? People change. I would've thought you, of all people, would know."

"Something else I know," they drawled out, "is that they like to put on an act. I learned that from you."

"I don't put on an act," Catra said around a mouthful of food. "Doesn't mean I'm comfortable around everyone."

"Sure, sure, I guess you wouldn't get too personal with Adora," Double Trouble shrugged, "or your family, because you don't want to disappoint them now that you've finally found them. Or Entrapta, because she wouldn't understand. Or Scorpia, because you feel like you still need to make it up to her. Am I getting closer now?"

"Shut up," Catra seethed, looking around to make sure no one was overhearing them. "I'm not in the mood for one of your impromptu therapy sessions."

"Someday you will have to face it, you know. The emptiness."

"I said shut *up*," Catra snapped. "I have friends now, a family - a kingdom. I don't know what you think I should feel empty about."

"All that power," Double Trouble tut-tutted, almost pitifully, "all that unconditional love, self-love, familial love. And something's still missing, isn't it?"

And when she kept avoiding their gaze, wishing they could stop, just *stop* for one damn night, they lifted her chin up towards them with a single clawed finger. "Oh, kitten," they mumbled, "now that you finally got what you needed, I was hoping you'd figured out what it was that you wanted."

Adora had never felt so loved, so needed, and so unseen.

She really was ecstatic to be with her friends again, and she was having fun for the first time in a long while. Bow had painted his situation with Glimmer to be a lot more dramatic than it actually turned out to be, with them instantly jumping to making up for lost time like nothing ever happened. Sure, she sometimes had to be pulled from one end of the ballroom to the other, from Glimmer's princess group to… well, Bow, who pretty much just spent his time chasing Sea Hawk around, but if it meant she got to hang out with everyone, she wouldn't complain. It was kind of flattering, how they all wanted her attention.

She was the problem. She was the one who didn't fit in those dynamics anymore and was incapable of bringing anything new to them. She was trying so hard to be the Adora they knew, an Adora she could remember but no longer understand. It was like observing herself from a distance, mirroring the girl before her to the slightest mannerism without perceiving any of them as her own. She'd turned into this, survived her own murder by never looking back to reflect on it, just like before Eternia, before the Rebellion, she had left the Horde without a second thought as to what - who - she was leaving behind, in order to be She-Ra.

As she spun around the room for the first dance, partnered with Glimmer and then Mermista, she suddenly felt very tired. The thought of the last Princess Prom ignited a sort of longing at her core, a wish for things to be simple and quiet again - not these bright lights, this music booming in her ears, this constant awareness of her surroundings guiding her every move. She'd forgotten herself every time it was requested of her to serve this or that higher cause, with the promise of peace on the other side, and it was looking more and more like she might be the only one to never reap its benefits.

When do I stop, Adora asked whoever was listening as an incredibly strong Perfuma lifted her in the air and quickly set her back down with a smile. *When do I rest?*

Her turn with Spinnerella was incredibly quick, mostly because Netossa was wary of having her dance for too long when she was so close to the birth, and because she'd grown to be incredibly protective of her. Wherever Adora looked, there they were, engulfed in each other like the rest of the world had vanished around them. How liberating must it feel, to have someone know you that well. To not be able, nor need or want, to lie to yourself.

It was natural, right? To want that for herself: someone to tell her who she was, in her entirety, in her truth, whenever she forgot. For her heart to lurch forward and go *God, give it to me, where do I start* and fall flat when it came up empty, like expecting a three-course meal only to end up swallowing air.

Adora had always been good at self-control - one of the perks of a life spent in service of the greater good. But now this craving had started in her, and unlike on Eternia, there was nothing on Etheria preventing it from developing further.

And it was all Catra's fault.

She'd forgotten that shutting Catra out of her heart hadn't just been the morally righteous thing to do, but something meant for Adora's own protection. Catra had known her well enough to sneak inside her head and poison her mind, and Adora had happily let her if it meant keeping her - even if she only got to hold on to the worst parts, the ugly parts. Catra made Adora senseless and selfish and was a tangible reminder of a past that Adora had needed to leave behind to brave the road ahead, proof of what Adora had been and could be again. After all this time, Catra still saw her, could still reach into her and tear Adora's heart out and show it to her, and Adora kept inching closer and closer to Catra's side of the ballroom, switching partner after partner to reach her, begging *please tell me who to be*.

When she was finally passed off to Catra, the surge of desire that overcame her was expected. Adora welcomed it in, let it grow, let it fill her. She held her breath as their fingers brushed, touched,

went as far as to intertwine; but Catra, without ever meeting her gaze, only gave her one twirl and then spun out of sight.

What do you want, Catra?

Double Trouble didn't know anything.

They were excellent at reading people, Catra could give them that; but they also never liked to admit when they were wrong, and that was how Catra was left with cryptic, oracle-like statements about her still missing something she wanted. Odds were, either Double Trouble didn't even know what they were talking about, or they were referring to the one thing Catra had been advised for her own good not to want, and it was easier to believe the former than to face the latter.

She had worked to earn back the love she'd pushed away, had to learn how to deserve it. Being removed from Shadow Weaver's presence - she was also taught never to speak ill of the dead, but all she could say here was, good fucking riddance - had worked wonders, but like a virus, she'd infected so much of Catra's life that the only way any progress could be made was to distance herself from it all. And that included Adora. No matter how misguided Catra had been, how naive Adora had been, how everything had been against them from the start, how Catra didn't even blame Adora anymore, not really - Catra couldn't keep Adora in her life without hurting herself.

The feelings of inadequacy would kick in as soon as she saw Adora with anyone else - a reminder that if she couldn't be enough for the person she loved the most, then she wouldn't be enough for anyone - followed by such a terrible rush of self-hatred that Catra had to direct it towards Adora instead out of pure self-preservation.

She had been careful to build her own bubble, separate from Adora. She was her own person, with her own friends, her own

family, her own kingdom. Loving and being loved, that's what it was supposed to be all about. That should've been enough.

"Not avoiding me, are you?"

Catra fought the urge to groan. Adora clearly hadn't gotten the hint the first time, and had approached her to dance again. She realized the girl could be a bit thick, especially since she hadn't been on Etheria in a while - but she just had to keep making things more complicated for Catra. "Sorry, princess, looks like I'm a very busy woman tonight."

Which was partly true. Catra hadn't wanted to deal with Adora, yes; but she'd also promised Scorpia a dance, and then random guests she didn't want to let down, and then was invited to a discussion about Half Moon safety measures and possible political alliances by some of the princesses there. She prided herself on it, too. She could survive just fine without Adora, and now Adora was seeing it too.

But Adora just resumed the dance like Catra hadn't spoken at all. "I'm sure you could make time for an old friend."

"We're not friends."

Adora hummed under her breath and slid her arm down Catra's back, resting at her waist. "Well, whose fault is that?"

"I didn't say it was anyone's fault. Things just changed."

Adora didn't seem to like that reply very much. In fact, her grip on Catra tightened imperceptibly as she pulled their chests together. Catra could feel her breathing. "It's good to see you."

Catra noted that she didn't say *I missed you*. Adora was always going around telling everyone how much she missed them, whether it was true or not, making everybody feel more important than they actually were. But not this time. The alternative she'd chosen was just as cliché, with none of the emotional openness. "Yeah, I bet," she settled on, because like *hell* was she going to

reciprocate when she could just lean on sarcasm and come out on top. “So what kind of dump is Eternia, anyway? You look awful.”

“Oh, you’d love it, Catra,” Adora brightened up, too used to Catra’s deflecting to fall for it, leading Catra backwards. “It’s so different from Etheria. So beautiful. You haven’t truly lived until you’ve seen the meteor shower during Emerald season. That’s when the sky is gold during the day and green at night - and sometimes stars fall, and you’re supposed to wish upon them, it’s apparently an old Earth tradition -”

Catra could barely pay attention. It wasn’t that Adora was rambling, or that she wasn’t interested - although she sure did try to pretend otherwise. It was the way Adora’s body molded to hers, the way her hands occasionally brushed her lower back, how she carefully guided her into a turn or a spin, how Catra met her demands without question.

Adora had never had two left feet or anything like that, but her best feat had always been her strength, rather than her agility. While she still looked like she trained everyday - Catra had to dig her nails in Adora’s shoulders to keep them from sliding down her arms and pass it off as an accident - she also seemed to move more surely. She hadn’t been watching her dance with other girls on purpose, but at some point through one of her conveniently timed work discussions, she had dared to glance at the dance floor and seen Adora with Glimmer.

Even though she knew there was nothing going on there, the thought of them together had been enough to make her skin crawl for years, and the sight of them now was no different. It was the familiar way they interacted, the easy way Glimmer touched her without every brush of fingers being fraught with tension. And there were the other princesses, too, some of them getting a little too ahead of themselves - Catra really thought she’d have to pry Perfuma off Adora after the third song - and yet Adora was choosing to dance with Catra now.

What do you want, Catra?

She wanted to be happy. For all intents and purposes, she should've been. She had the support system she needed to survive anything life threw at her - even if it never brought her and Adora back together. But happiness wasn't really a thing to want, was it? That would imply it was also a thing you got once and for all, when actually it was a lot more like rain, ever elusive but ever returning. It was no use trying to catch it in your hands, but you'd feel it drizzle all over your face every once in a while and spend your life trying to recreate that experience. That was all that wanting was: a smokescreen for the real thing.

And all her life, Catra had wanted Adora. Wanted to be with her all the time; wanted to touch her; wanted to climb into her veins and make a home in her pulse and be one with her. That had been a lot for a kid to process: what had registered as a pleasant kind of pressure at first had only grown more unbearable with time, and stayed with her now as an ache.

She'd thought it was a weakness, then; she saw now that it was just a consequence of her longing for happiness. Maybe her system just hadn't gotten used to getting it from other sources yet. Maybe if she just acted on her desire, the pressure would go away. Maybe just once would satisfy her, and she could finally go on with her life.

That realization froze her on the spot, instead of pushing her into action. Adora noticed when Catra's hands went still, and her laugh sounded sincere for the first time that night. "You aren't listening to a word I say, are you?"

She squeezed Catra's hands again to bring her attention back to her - as if she needed to, as if she was ever out of Catra's mind - and Catra responded, squeezing back.

"No, I am. I just got a little lost there." She frowned, trying to remember the last thing Adora had been talking about. She vaguely recalled a comment about a public hearing. "What were you saying about the Eternian court?"

Adora beamed, clearly pleased with Catra keeping up with her. That was the first step, right? To please her. "They seemed nice at first. They'd be incredibly sweet and helpful to me when they needed something, and they convinced me I could trust them. But the moment I disagreed or did something wrong, there they'd be, conspiring behind my back. I should've expected that, I guess. But it seems I never learn."

Catra smirked, giving Adora a twirl. Once it was done, she didn't try to pull her back - Adora stepped forward on her own. "Court intrigues. Nice. Did they try to overthrow you? Poison you? Did the people rise in rebellion against you?"

"I think you're spending too much time with Double Trouble."

"Hey, it's not everyday that people see you as less than perfect. I've lived in a hole in the ground for the last year, this is all the entertainment I've got."

Adora stayed quiet for a long time. Catra didn't particularly care about it, but she did find the silence awkward, so she was about to ask if Adora was okay, if she'd gotten offended, somehow - before Adora finally spoke. "I never asked for it, you know. People treating me like I was perfect."

"No. You always just *were*. You didn't have to do anything."

"You're wrong," Adora said, a little too forcefully. Even her movements turned erratic, her feet missing a couple beats. Catra's eyes jumped up to hers. "And *you* clearly didn't think I was perfect."

Catra huffed. "You want me to be sorry?" *Don't be cruel*, some part of her begged, but the other part of her, the part that held all the anger, said instead *This is what she left you for.*

"No," Adora surprisingly replied, quietly but steadfastly. "I liked that about you - that you saw me. You saw me enough to hate me."

“Well, I hear there’s a line for that now.” She didn’t mean to sound bitter, but it was always like this, with Adora. Love her or hate her, you could never hold her attention for too long. Everyone wanted a piece of her, and Adora was always willing to comply; Catra wondered now, as she looked upon Adora’s tired lines, how much was actually left.

“It was different with you. I trusted you not to hurt me.”

“Guess your trust was misplaced.”

Adora paused for a second, humming softly to the music. Her lips hovered right over Catra’s cheek, where her breath hit. “Do you still? Hate me?”

Had the circumstances been different, Catra probably wouldn’t have thought much of it. It was just a simple, if naive, question. But since Adora had gotten uncomfortably close by now, Catra scrambled for a way to regain the upper hand in the conversation.

She gripped Adora’s wrist tight, stopping her in her tracks - and there it was, the feeling of control, of turning the power that Adora held against Catra against Adora, instead. It must’ve been the little hitch in Adora’s breath, the way Adora’s pulse sped up under her fingers.

“More than you know,” she murmured. She wanted to add more about why that was, how whatever affection she still felt for Adora was so inextricably tied to her resentment that it was impossible to untangle them. How she felt that she had to be the one to look Adora in the eyes and watch the life be drained from her, and yet how Catra would let herself die on the spot if that ever happened. How it always seemed to come down to this, in the end - a desire for self-destruction. But she didn’t.

Catra felt Adora smirk against her skin. “That’s okay. I’ll let you hold the knife, if you promise not to strike.”

She hadn’t realized they’d slowly come to a stop until people started bumping into them. The music was also slowing down,

true - but she could barely hear it over the rush of blood in her ears. Her tongue was tied for entirely different reasons than the prospect of being able to hold a knife to Adora's throat - namely, Adora's closeness, Adora's low voice, Adora's hand running up her side -

"No promises," Catra breathed out, "I'm sick of them."

Adora didn't make a sound, but her hand reached out for Catra's, and when she had it, she didn't just hold it - she traced every finger slowly, painstakingly, and the space in between, too, and it felt like she would never reach the tip of her pinkie, like she'd keep torturing Catra like this forever - and then Catra eyed Bow and Glimmer on the other side of the room, staring at them, and moved even closer to Adora, just because she knew it would piss them off.

"Your friends are watching," she murmured, making sure Adora felt every touch of her lips as she spoke. Sure enough, Adora did freeze under her, but whether that was due to Catra or the news itself, Catra couldn't say. "I really don't want to give them a show."

Adora nodded again, but she resumed her ministrations. "What do you want, Catra?"

A thrill passed through her. She could take the out and push Adora off of her, or -

"Come with me."

For the first time, Adora did.

Pulling on her hand, she led her through the chaos of dancing people, through the ballroom and the door and the corridor. It was scary, how much Catra felt in control of herself, of what was happening. That kind of power - not the cheap power she was given in the Horde as Force Commander, but the power that felt a lot like just freedom - she'd never felt anything like it.

They turned a corner and, figuring they were far enough away, Catra stopped and pulled Adora up against her, backing her against the nearest wall. The hallway was in complete darkness, until the moonlight from a window coming in, and she was pretty sure that Adora couldn't see much at all. Still, her eyes never left Catra's, not for one second - her pretty mouth opening on tense breaths, her chest rising and falling.

Something caught in Catra's throat - something she choked down before she could give voice to it, before she could embarrass herself. "Look at you."

Adora was playing with the tips of Catra's hair, clenching her fists at the nape. She didn't break eye contact. "What about me?"

"You're under my thumb," was what left Catra's mouth, her head a litany of *You're beautiful I want to have you I'm* going *to have you-*

"Am I, though?" Adora's grip suddenly tightened as she tipped Catra's head backwards. "You seem pretty eager, Catra. How long have you been thinking about this?"

"What, getting you to finally shut up? Been a lifelong dream of mine."

"You like me," Adora smiled; it looked so carefree on her, so far from the scorn Catra was expecting, that it almost broke the gravity of the moment - *almost,* because Adora's breath still hitched halfway through, but the way she laughed - the way she was suddenly reminded of *her* Adora, except she was now pulling at Catra's hair -

It was on pure impulse that Catra leaned forward and pressed her lips to Adora's skin - the spot between neck and collarbone, which was eye level with her. She'd gone in with the intention to tease, steal a quick peck to gain back control and then pull back, but then Adora sighed and she wanted to hear it again. And again. And again. "Arrogance is not a good look on you, Adora." She

mouthed lightly up the curve of her neck and beyond - not quite kissing, so much as letting her presence be felt. “But I’ll make do.”

Adora arched into Catra’s touch, her throat now fully exposed - Catra’s nails raking possessively down the tender skin she was offered. She was reaching dangerous territory now. Soon enough, she’d be hovering over Adora’s lips. Soon enough their noses would brush. She stayed there a while, taking her in, waiting for anyone to come out of the ballroom and stop her from doing this, but no one did.

“You said you wouldn’t break me.”

Catra looked down at where her nails were gripping too hard, already leaving marks on Adora’s neck.

Maybe Catra once would have rejoiced in Adora looking afraid of her. Maybe Catra once would have reminded that she’d actually made no promises, and proceeded to slash her throat and put an end to both of their miseries. She didn’t now. She wiped the first droplets of blood that were welling up with her thumb instead, rubbing the same spot over and over in way of an apology. “I’m not gonna break you,” she vowed, clawed fingers resting easy now. “I’m gonna kiss you. Like this.”

An unmistakable intake of breath on Adora’s part, and Catra brought Adora’s lips to hers.

Because here was the thing: despite her insistence otherwise, despite a life lived in order to prove everyone who thought this about her wrong, Catra was weak. She loved things and people way too much, and cried when they were taken away. And Adora, God, she was weakest for Adora. Nothing anyone else could do or say to her affected her the same way, and when Adora started responding, warm mouth engulfing hers, Catra drew back. Adora’s touch burned; it made her feel too large for her own skin, like she could just crawl out of it and be all the better for it.

Adora seemed mortified. Catra had barely kissed her, and yet - or maybe, for that exact reason - she already looked so wrecked. It was distracting. “I-I’m sorry. I’ve never done this before. Was that so bad?”

Catra raised an eyebrow. “Wait, what?”

“Am I a bad kisser? I can just let you handle it, if you want. What you were doing was really nice.”

What Catra had been doing was brush her lips against Adora’s, softly and fearfully. She didn’t have much experience, either. “No, I mean - have you really never kissed anyone?”

Adora seemed surprised. “Have you?”

Her own embarrassment battled with a stronger, more overwhelming feeling of possessiveness. Adora had never kissed anyone but her. For the rest of her life, when Adora thought about her first kiss or she was asked about it, this moment was what would come to mind. Power thrummed beneath her fingertips as she traced the lines of Adora’s face again. “No,” she whispered, enjoying Adora’s eyes on her. “No. It’s just you.” *It’s always been just you.*

Adora had carved a permanent place for herself in Catra’s mind when Catra had been too young to defend herself against it - and then she’d left and left her empty inside. It was only fair for Catra to do the same now.

She dived back in eagerly, pushing Adora far back into the wall, and didn’t pull away until Adora started gasping for breath, and the music in the ballroom stopped and the first people started filing out.

Glimmer didn’t touch her like Catra.

They were extremely similar in everything else - their feistiness, their devotion to the things and the people they loved, their need to prove themselves - but Glimmer's touch was casual and unrushed where Catra's, whether sweet or rough, was always filled with intent.

Glimmer wiped Adora's make-up off, their knees touching on the same Bright Moon bed, and it was easy enough and pleasant, but a hunger had started deep inside her that Glimmer couldn't sate - that she probably had no idea even existed within her - and if Adora trembled everytime Glimmer's fingers came too close to the marks on her neck, it was only because Adora imagined claws making contact with her skin instead.

Glimmer observed her carefully, flinching when she did. "What's wrong? Am I hurting you?"

"No." It sounded more like a question than an actual answer. "It just burns a little."

"Oh, okay. I'll be gentler." She resumed dabbing, but more slowly. "Sorry I don't have more specific wipes. I didn't even know you wore make-up now."

"I don't," Adora confirmed. "The royal tailors made me. They said their hard work couldn't be wasted on someone who didn't even bother looking good."

Glimmer scoffed. "You're a princess. Don't let them speak to you like that."

Adora waved Glimmer's hand away, tiredness suddenly seeping in and dragging her down onto the mattress. She could've had her old room back for the night, if she'd wanted to, and she would definitely ask if her stay ended up being longer than planned, but right now, she didn't mind sleeping with Glimmer. She'd never liked sleeping alone, and she liked it even less now in her empty palace, so this was a nice change. It almost felt like old times again, except Bow wasn't there. He'd just gone home after the

party, and Glimmer hadn't thought of inviting him to sleep over. "Apparently, they were appointed by my parents. Firing them would mean disrespecting their legacy, or something."

"I didn't say *fire them*, but you need to establish some boundaries, Adora." Glimmer leant over her, wiping at Adora's mouth for the last of the lipstick to come off. Her friend smelled good, having just taken a shower, and her pajamas felt so soft and warm it made Adora want to fall asleep right then and there. "Hey, come on, I'm almost done."

Adora groaned. "You know, at first I even thought it was kinda fun. But now? Doesn't matter how hot I look. I'm never doing it again."

Glimmer smirked, finally putting the wet wipes away. "If that makes you feel any better, though, you've really turned heads tonight."

"What are you talking about?" Her friends had fought for her attention all night, that was true, but she'd hardly call that "turning heads".

"You haven't noticed? Wait, of course you haven't," she sighed, dropping down next to Adora. "Some things really don't change."

"I was busy," Adora said, which wasn't really a lie. Also, she'd never been good at reading feelings, either her own or those of others.

She thought Glimmer would point it out to her again, that she'd suggest she needed to be less clueless, but instead she rolled her eyes and went, "Yeah, with Catra. What was that about, anyway?" and that was a little more difficult to answer.

"Catching up with an old friend?" she attempted.

"You two haven't had one conversation that didn't result in attempted murder in two, maybe three years."

Adora turned her face into the pillow, muffling a groan, because that was a fair point. A normal conversation with Catra was really all she wanted, but Catra had let her speak all the while, only interrupting for a sarcastic jab here and there, while volunteering nothing about her own life. And then Catra had just kissed her, a lot, and neither of them had been able to get any words in.

"That doesn't matter. We may not be friends anymore, but I still care about her happiness, more than-" *Anything* wasn't right. She clearly hadn't cared about her happiness the most when she'd left her behind, or when she'd looked past Shadow Weaver's mistreatment, or just been a terrible friend all around who never knew when to shut up and when to speak up. And now here she was again, using Catra to feel better about herself.

It's not like she didn't know what a kiss meant, how it could complicate things - but when the moment had come, she'd wanted to be kissed. Being close to Catra again, physically if not emotionally, had made her feel more like herself than she'd felt since - well, since she'd lost her powers.

Perhaps Catra had a point not wanting anything to do with her. "More than I realized."

Glimmer's eyes softened in the dim light. "There's nothing wrong in still caring about her, Adora, as long as that's all there is. I don't want you to get hurt."

"I won't," Adora said, deciding not to tell Glimmer about offering herself up to Catra's scorn and judgment and resentment like a sacrificial lamb.

Glimmer thought in silence for a while. "I wouldn't go as far as to say she's okay now," she mumbled eventually, "but she is so clearly trying."

Adora smiled at that. Something fuzzy was starting in her heart - something warm. Pride, maybe. She closed her eyes and thought

of Catra again, and the feeling grew almost to an ache. “I’m glad. I want that for her.”

“She’s trying,” Glimmer repeated, “and I don’t want that to be for nothing. I don’t want her to get hurt, either.”

Adora blinked, confused. “Are you saying that if she relapsed, it would be my fault?”

“I’m saying it could happen. You’ve always been her greatest weakness. You unravel her so easily.”

Unravel. That was such a pretty word - it turned ugly in Glimmer’s mouth. To unmake, to strip something down to its bare essentials. *She unravels me too*, she wanted to say, except Catra was not as strong as she pretended to be and for Adora to show up out of nowhere and follow Catra around all night while she was just trying to have a nice, quiet time now did sound so unnecessarily cruel, and made her ashamed of herself. When would she learn, when would she stop being this naive little girl, clearly unqualified to take care of any of her friends, let alone an entire planet?

Glimmer, however, must’ve seen Adora already berating herself. Unlike her, Glimmer always saw, and responded accordingly. “Maybe it’s better for some things to be left alone. Friends grow apart. That’s part of life.”

She heard that a lot. Catra was evil; she’d changed while Adora wasn’t looking or maybe right under her eyes, and she was just supposed to accept it. Even when they were in the Horde, it was no secret that Shadow Weaver hoped Adora would one day come to her senses and leave Catra behind, and if Adora hadn’t already done her job for her, Shadow Weaver would no doubt have tried to drive the wedge between them herself. But it made Adora wonder if any bond could stand the trials of time, if closeness was any guarantee of survival. So she asked Glimmer. “Is that what happened with you and Bow?”

Adora didn't notice a lot, but she could tell Glimmer didn't expect that question, because her close proximity made it impossible not to feel her muscles freeze. No surprise showed on her face, but her reply was cautious. "Quite the opposite. Bow and I… we were together for a while."

She gauged Adora's reaction, although Adora had no clue what she was hoping to find. She was having trouble processing that last bit of information. "Together, like-"

"Dating. In a relationship. You get the idea."

And she was having trouble because it was absolutely the last thing she would expect, and also somehow… not. She'd never thought of Bow and Glimmer together, but now that Glimmer brought it up, it made perfect sense. The idea glared at her from afar, scorning her for having missed it. It was digging yet another hole for her heart to be swallowed by. "But when - no, forget it. How did I not know about this?"

Glimmer grabbed her wrist to keep it still; she hadn't even realized she was waving her hands around like a maniac. "I swear we weren't trying to cut you out or anything, Adora. We just wanted to keep it to ourselves for a little while and then we'd tell everyone, but - well, that time never came. We broke up three months after."

And hell, she didn't want to be nosy, but her best friends had hidden a significant part of their lives from her, and now it carried over into their trio interactions. If things were going to be awkward between them from now on, if she had to get used to this too, now, to ties being cut, to secrets being kept, then at least she had a right to know why.

"Is it…" Adora hesitated. "Is it okay if I ask you what happened?"

Glimmer looked like she could use talking about it, as well. Adora wondered if she'd told anyone else at all. She could've deflected the first question, or simply lied, but she hadn't; she'd come clean

right away. Adora had given her another out right now, but she didn't take that, either.

"It felt so good, at first. Like that's how it was always meant to be. Have you ever felt like that, Adora?"

She shrugged. "I've never been with anyone. You know that."

"No, but that doesn't matter, it's - a kind of understanding. It dawns on you at the most random times. You could be hanging out with someone you've known your whole life, and then it just hits you, and your world tilts slightly to the side, and things… just make sense."

Adora had also heard that a lot - that everything would eventually make sense. She'd gotten some answers, eventually - about the Horde, about the Heart of Etheria - but they had never just *come* to her. All the knowledge Adora had, she had to fight for, had to demand.

And then there were things that she would never be able to explain, like why Catra had turned her back on her, what had made her hate Adora so much. Their world had always been a hopeless mess that no one had bothered to explain to them, but the day Adora had found Catra was also the day she'd started feeling less lost. As kids, she'd been the only thing that made sense.

Adora felt herself teetering on the edge of a realization, but one bound with thorns, that came with a red warning sign. So she pushed it down in some hidden drawer of her consciousness, where it found good company. Everything Adora was unwilling or unable to deal with, she'd learnt to dispose of. "I haven't," she confirmed.

Glimmer stared at her for a while, unconvinced, like she expected her to add a but in there. But she didn't. "Well, that's what it was like, for me. And it was just… a lot. It was too much. My queenly duties were entirely forgotten. I was no longer interested in the

world I was supposed to be ruling, but only in the world I was discovering. I had to break things off. I knew if I told him the real reason, he'd try to work things out, try to find a way to keep us together, because you know Bow, that's how he is - and I'd let him. So I told him to stay away from me, that this was a mistake."

"Glimmer." Adora meant to sound more scolding than that, but the truth is, she felt for her. She couldn't bring herself to show even the slightest disapproval when Glimmer was clearly hurting.

"If those feelings had stayed buried, if I hadn't acted on them, I wouldn't know. I'd be better off. Do you understand why I'm saying this, Adora? What I was trying to tell you before, about Catra?"

"What does Catra have to do with you and Bow?"

"When I said I didn't want you to get hurt," Glimmer said, "*this* is what I meant."

Oh.

Something inside her sparked to life again, kicking and screaming. *Hear me out*, it begged, *I've been trying to reach you*. Adora had to push that stubborn flicker of awareness down again. "Wait, you think I-"

"Adora, it's okay." Glimmer reached out to her, but Adora was suddenly feeling very overwhelmed, so she shook her off, though not unkindly. "I'm not going to pry or judge you. I just want what's best for you - both of you, surprisingly."

"I don't have feelings for Catra."

"You wouldn't tell me if you did. You wouldn't even tell yourself. But I've seen the way you look at each other, Adora. Nothing can come of it right now. I don't want you to have to return to Eternia with a broken heart."

“Glimmer, I’ve got it,” Adora insisted. Glimmer was looking at her worriedly, but she was making a bigger deal out of it than it needed to be. Catra had always just been Catra to her. Nothing with Catra had ever felt weird, or too strong, or too much. No feeling had ever overcome her all at once to make her reevaluate her entire life. It had always been sure, and steady, and safe - even in its broken, unspoken parts.

Which had to stay unspoken for a reason.

She used to think there would be a time for her to let it all out - everything that hurt, that bothered her, that kept her up at night, and everything that made her profoundly happy, too. After she led the Horde to victory. After Etheria was free again, and the war was done. After no one needed She-Ra anymore. She’d been a fool; everyone would always need her. She wasn’t sure if she could survive otherwise.

“Don’t worry,” Adora whispered in the dim light, finally laying back down to sleep. “My heart will be fine.”

It gave one last beat before following Adora into sleep, slowing down to match her breathing, as if to save its strength.

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

Catra struggles with actions. Adora struggles with words.

Chapter Notes

Fair warning that this chapter is a MESS. You'll see what I mean.
Also, fair warning that I'm upping the rating for implied sexual content and some suggestive language, just in case, but there's nothing explicit. I actually have no idea what rating this chapter would fall under, so let me know what you think about that.
Shout out to Becca (DeepBlueSkies) for helping me with this chapter, because writing it was an actual nightmare and something I'd never done before, so having a second opinion and someone to brainstorm with was key. Thank you so much :*

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Breaking the sword had been the beginning of the end.

Etheria had been forced to make the ultimate sacrifice to prevent an already bad situation from getting worse, but with Queen Glimmer's plan backfiring, the planet had been pushed right into Horde Prime's clutches. As a result, by the time of Horde Prime's arrival, their greatest asset - She-Ra - was gone, and a severely unstable amount of magic was still stored in the planet's core, waiting to be fired off at will. In light of a situation as hopeless as this one, many chose to retire from the fight to spend their last days with their loved ones or to tend to their kingdoms.

But there were others who kept fighting.

It was two weeks after the party, and the Whispering Woods was ablaze with magic.

Apparently, it was tradition for princesses, especially those with elemental powers, to present their newborn babies to the woods to be blessed. Something about it always having been neutral ground, preserving the magic of the land through the centuries and through the wars.

Adora was sitting on one of the many blankets spread out in the woods, Glimmer and Bow on either side of her. It was nice. It reminded her of them trying to sleep on the beach at Mystacor, and how miserably she'd failed at relaxing because no one had ever taught her how. Except it was slightly different, because Glimmer and Bow's banter lacked its usual bite and there were stars now.

They looked different on Etheria. The Eternian sky was packed full of stars, and their position in the sky changed every month. She'd long had a theory that Etheria's magic kept the planet still and floating into space while Eternia's moved it, but she'd never looked too much into it, lest anything she found disrupt her fantasies. It made sense, in a way. Every seasonal phenomenon - the comet shower, the lights, the eclipses - could be Eternia making its designated route through the galaxy. Maybe Eternia was travelling towards Etheria right now, coming to take her back, and she wouldn't even have to wait until the morning.

Would that just be it then, for as long as she lived? Her friends down here, slowly growing apart, and her up there, going through the motions day by day?

Spinnerella and Netossa had done a really moving speech, recalling their fights against the Horde, the friendships made, the trials overcome together - all while taking great care not to draw attention to the Horde officer standing among them. Unfortunately, the days when Catra would pass under the radar were still far away, so that everyone's eyes, at one point or

another, eventually found their way to her anyway. In that, at least, Adora felt less alone.

She couldn't really see her now, in the dark and on the other side of the clearing, but a firefly occasionally flew by her, lighting up her face. She was leaning heavily on Scorpia, not too far from the middle of the crowd, and they were giggling stupidly, like they had drunk too much cider before the night had even started. Also, Catra was holding a baby - or rather - Spinnerella and Netossa were holding their baby in front of her, letting her play with it while Scorpia held Catra close to her chest in a double show of caution and subtle affection.

Adora told herself it was worry for the baby that pushed her up and forward towards where they stood. Catra had never particularly liked public displays of affection with anyone but Adora herself; if she was giving in to it now, she must not be in her right mind.

But as it turned out, she was. Adora noticed by the way Catra focused in on her right away, biting back a grin. "Hey, Adora."

"Adora!" Spinnerella whipped around, the baby bouncing disorientedly in her arms. "Adora, do you want to hold her?"

"Uhhh…" Adora's eyes flicked to her. As much as she loved kids, she was already picturing herself dropping the baby to the ground. "I'd better not, really."

"Come on, I'll help you," Spinnerella insisted, pushing it in her arms. The baby cooed. "See? She likes you."

Catra scoffed. Adora's attention was entirely on the baby now, but she could almost see her rolling her eyes. "What a surprise."

"Don't worry, Catra," Netossa cut in, "between you and me, I think you're her favorite."

"You hear that, Adora?" This time, Adora saw her crystal clear, since Catra didn't allow herself to be ignored anymore. Suddenly

she was all up in her face, as close to her as it was possible to be without suffocating the baby. There was no alcohol on her breath, but still, Adora couldn't be sure she wasn't high on something. "I've finally got you beat at something."

"Adora, you're going to drop her," Spinnerella warned, taking back her daughter to readjust her. "You've got to hold her head up, like this."

She looked at the baby struggling in her arms, then back to Catra, expecting to be overwhelmed - Catra's closeness, the fragile baby in her arms, the tangible reminder of what she could never have even if she'd wanted it, her imminent departure, and then the feeling that she should enjoy this all, as long as she had it.

She searched herself for a response to any of those inputs, but she came up empty. All her senses were dulled like she wasn't even there, and in their place was a general, pervasive unease.

She probably shouldn't be holding a baby when she got like this. She pushed it back in her mother's arms, smiling shyly like she didn't want to take advantage of her kindness. "She's so beautiful."

And that wasn't a lie; she really was. With Netossa's dark skin and Spinnerella's purple hair, it was already impossible not to love her. But right now, Adora couldn't stand to look at her or anyone else.

Thankfully, before Netossa or Spinnerella could notice anything was wrong, Catra turned their attention elsewhere. "What powers will this baby have, anyway? What do wind and nets make? Kites?"

"Parachutes," Scorpia helpfully provided. Adora had almost forgotten she was there. "Hot air balloons. Either way, baby's gonna fly."

"You really think so?" Netossa piped up. "She does really like it when she's high."

"Oh, God," Spinnerella groaned, "she's gonna be a nightmare growing up."

And they went right back to fussing over the princess, picturing everything she would do and the adventures she would live, all of it resting on the prospect of her developing special powers in the first place. Nobody was paying attention to Adora anymore - nobody except Catra, though she pretended otherwise. She always paid attention, to a mortifying, self-destructive degree.

Adora excused herself.

Queen Glimmer of Bright Moon and Princess Catra of Half Moon, back then still known as Force Captain Catra, were in fact held hostage on Horde Prime's ship and managed to set aside their differences to send a message out to the ground, where it was picked up by Queen Glimmer's allies.

The rescue mission would have been successful, had the two not been forced, under mind control, to give up secrets regarding the Heart of Etheria, including She-Ra's (the ink was smudged here; Adora could only assume they meant something like "concurrence") *in the weapon's powering. Horde Prime was eager to employ it in his century-long conquest of the galaxy and, particularly, in his long-standing war with Eternia - the planet of the so-called "First Ones". As a result, Queen Glimmer was released as a show of good faith while the former She-Ra was captured and forced to comply with Horde Prime's requests, with Force Captain Catra also being kept as leverage.*

While a mixed group of Rebellion fighters and former Horde soldiers looked for an entrance to the planet's core, Horde Prime sent She-Ra with Force Captain Catra to fire off what was starting to look more and more like a ticking time bomb.

“Wow. You really don’t like kids,” Catra muttered against Adora’s lips as soon as Adora allowed her to breathe.

She hadn’t even flinched when Catra had approached. Catra had followed her in the woods at a safe distance, expecting to sneak up on her and play with her, maybe make her mad a little; but Adora had been standing with her back to a tree, just waiting for Catra to come into view to pull Catra’s body over her own.

Catra wasn’t sure whether to count that as a win or not. She’d gotten what she wanted, for sure, but she’d have to find other ways to make it fun now. Adora was giving in to her faster and faster these days, and Catra was indulging her too much.

Adora stared at her, mouth parted, eyes dark in the low light. They kept kissing in the shadows like the truth of it would have been unbearable otherwise. “What?”

“Don’t worry, I don’t think anyone noticed,” Catra said. “It’s just - you only kiss me when you’re upset.” Which, from what little she saw of Adora, was very, very often.

Adora was silent for a second, as if questioning her own motivations. Then: “It’s not about the baby. I’m sorry, I’m just - I guess I’m just tired.”

Catra scoffed. “You’re unable to handle other people being happy without you, is what you are.” And yes, maybe, in trying to prove to Adora that she still saw her better than anyone else, she was oversimplifying Adora’s issues. She tried not to feel too bad about it; it wasn’t like Adora had always taken hers seriously, anyway, and even now, she wasn’t exactly denying using Catra to feel better about herself.

Adora’s grip slackened - a small price to pay for knowing she’d gotten under Adora’s skin. “Don’t act like you still know me.”

“Oh, Adora, but I do. I know all about you. That’s why you keep coming back, isn’t it?” She waited to see if Adora would push her away completely, but Adora just stared as she pressed closer. “I

know that something happened back there that upset you, because you always need to feel like you fit into people's lives." She tested the waters carefully, drawing her claws back in before resting her fingers on Adora's pulse point, where a days-old bruise was fading. Adora hissed at first contact, but soon went pliant under Catra's hands, which spurred her to keep going. "I know you don't want to fit in mine, but you like it when I touch you like this."

Trailing her hand down Adora's arm, she forced herself to focus on the matter at hand. This was Adora. She'd grown up with her, fought with her several times over the last gray ration bar, slept at her feet every night for years. How did her closeness affect her so much?

"That doesn't mean I understand," she continued regardless, because this was about more than her; it was about Adora not feeling well, it was about - possibly providing Adora with someone to open up to. "But - I could try, if you wanted me to."

Adora's starstruck look dwindled, clarity slowly setting in. Catra rubbed up her arm again, encouraging, observing as a blush rose to her cheeks. Catra fought the urge to kiss her there; it felt too tender. Too vulnerable.

"These woods are where it all started years ago," Adora eventually said. "Do you remember?"

That had to be a rhetorical question. No one forgot the moment they started to lose their best friend. She remembered a stolen skiff, Adora holding on to her arm in fear - how she'd thought *I want to protect you* back then, how it had quickly turned into *I want you to have to be protected from me*. She remembered her falling. She remembered waking up that night to find Adora sneaking out of their bed - unbeknownst to her, never to come back.

"They called to me once, when they wanted me to find the sword. They led me to Bow and Glimmer, to the Crystal Castle - to my

destiny.” *Away from me*, Catra mused. “They used to speak to me, or - well, at least I used to hear them. They’re quiet now, but no one seems to know the difference.”

Catra shrugged. “I mean, you’ve saved the universe already, Adora. What else could they possibly need you for?”

She hadn’t meant to be brutal. Truly, she hadn’t. She had no desire to hurt Adora anymore. She wanted to *help* Adora, which most of the time, she’d learned, involved hurting herself instead.

Thankfully, Adora didn’t look offended, nor any more upset than she already was. She just looked lost. “Yeah. That’s the question, isn’t it?”

Extensive research brought Queen Glimmer and her allies to find an entrance to the forgotten underground kingdom of Half Moon that would allow them to reach the planet’s core. But before they could get there and prevent a galaxy-wide disaster, the sorceress Shadow Weaver, once known as Light Spinner, whose opinions had been disregarded at war meetings, decided to harness the magic at the Heart of Etheria, believing she could direct it against Prime’s armies. Unfortunately, without She-Ra’s power kicking in and serving as a counterbalance, which the sorceress had been counting on, the Heart’s power proved too much for her to handle, and she was consumed by it in a matter of minutes.

In trying to shield She-Ra from Shadow Weaver’s surge of power, Force Captain Catra was badly wounded. With Horde Prime’s armies now advancing and Queen Glimmer’s armies still far away, She-Ra made one last desperate stand to reconnect to her powers.

Catra’s hand dropped to Adora’s chest, poking slightly where she felt her heart pounding. “Do you still feel it?” Adora stared at her blankly. “The magic. You can’t access it, but do you still feel it?”

Adora didn’t really know how to answer. Logically, she’d lived with the powers of She-Ra all her life, but they hadn’t been unlocked until she’d found the sword; so now that the sword was gone, it stood to reason that they had just been buried deep inside her again. It drove her crazy, feeling the magic prodding at her without being able to reach for it back - and yet, it had to stay that way. She’d made a choice, when she’d broken the sword, to put the safety of everyone else before her personal feelings, and she wouldn’t go back on it now.

But sometimes - only sometimes - that simple thrum evolved into a rush. Sometimes, Adora chased it.

“It’s stronger when you’re near,” she confessed under her breath. “I don’t know why - maybe it remembers fighting you. But it reacts to you.”

Catra hummed, considering, and kissed her again. It was just a quick peck on the lips, which after all of Catra’s talk left Adora deeply unsatisfied, but she quickly made up for it by pressing wet kisses all over her neck. Wearing lipstick whenever they were scheduled to meet was only Catra’s latest ploy to torture Adora: it forced her to choose between going back to her friends looking ravished or having to remove Catra’s make-up herself from where she’d smudged it all over Adora’s face.

Only once had Adora walked back to her friends still covered in Catra’s lipstick, one night when they’d both been incredibly drunk and she’d made Adora too senseless to remember to rub it off - and she’d only gotten away with it because Glimmer had been drunk, as well. She’d spent the night crying about Bow having spent most of his time with Perfuma, and Adora had comforted her and hoped she’d ask no questions.

The rest of the time, she’d have to touch all the places Catra touched to clear her marks. She’d have to relive it all in her head. It was Catra’s way to make sure she never forgot.

“Catra,” she warned now, wincing when she felt Catra bite down, “I’m spending the night at Bow’s. Unlike Glimmer, he does *not* get drunk.”

Catra hushed her, kissing over that same spot right away. Her tail stroked gently down Adora's side, helping her relax. The outrage died on Adora’s lips as soon as it was voiced, and she fell silent. “Did you feel it at the Heart? When I was in danger?”

Adora froze in her tracks. They didn’t mention the Heart. They didn’t think about the Heart. She would have thought that was true of Catra, too. “Yes. But I couldn’t unlock it.”

She’d rehearsed that script a lot over the previous year. Believing otherwise, even for a second, meant falling down a rabbit hole she wasn’t prepared for. She hoped Catra wouldn’t push it.

“What about now?”

That was just a stupid question. Wherever Catra’s fingertips touched, her magic flocked. “I’m- I’m getting there.”

“Okay,” Catra muttered into Adora’s skin, but seconds later, when she felt Catra’s breath on her cheek, Adora was suddenly alert to the lips that hovered inches from her own. “Let me help.”

Adora often wondered what it was, about Catra, that kept pulling her back in. She’d thought it was their shared history, perhaps a childhood attachment she’d never fully let go of, but in truth, it was just this - that Catra had a way of laying Adora bare to herself. Her head was a mess most of the time, but Catra only had to pull on her thread to reveal all of her contradictions to be self-made and bring her true desires to light.

So Adora closed her eyes, baring her neck to the knife’s touch, and felt it. She couldn’t help but think of all the ancient spells, all the rituals that could’ve required a young woman to be lured into a magical forest at a time like this, when the stars were in the right position; except it had been Adora to draw Catra away from

the party, Adora who clung to her desperately now, Adora who forgot herself while Catra took her apart.

She felt it - the breath on her skin, the night air, the distant chatter; all the magic a single body could hold floating around them, and every being that held a particle of magic in themselves.

She felt Catra most of all, a clutter of pain and rage and something hot and burning that felt a lot like desperation, but lacked the same bite. Adora latched onto it - found it in herself, as well, quieter but insistent. Her power, maybe - it acted up when Catra touched her - but she couldn't put her finger on it before Catra pulled away and it slipped out of reach.

Adora's mouth closed around Catra's name a few more times before falling victim to silence. Adora wanted to speak - something was clawing at her throat, begging to be voiced - but Catra had pushed Adora to the edge of a realization and pulled her back before Adora could find words to describe what she'd glimpsed down below.

Did Catra know what Adora had felt? Was that why she refused to meet her eyes - because she'd done more than Adora had asked of her, unlocked more than just her magic, and thought it wise to reel it back before either of them took it too far?

And if so - why was that fear nowhere to be found in Adora herself?

Catra's hand rested on her heart, like she was still trying to draw power out of her. When she finally raised her head, to Adora's surprise, she spoke in a low rasp. "Was that what you wanted?" she said, which to Adora sounded more like *Was that* all *you wanted?*

Maybe that was the scary part, Adora reflected later, watching Catra go back to the others: that for all of her talks about how dangerous it would be to reconnect with her powers, for all that a

nagging, horrible suspicion was starting to take root in her mind, Adora looked at Catra and she was no longer sure.

Unfortunately, the attempt failed, and the Heart was rendered unstable due to the sorceress's tampering. Only the arrival of the first Rebellion soldiers prevented a planet-wide disaster: both She-Ra and Force Captain Catra were knocked out due to the multiple injuries sustained, and the Heart, having already destroyed Half Moon, had then succeeded in opening up the planet's core to the surface. Ironically enough, Horde Prime's fleet was also affected by the Heart's power, with his numbers decreasing drastically. Taking down Prime was a combined effort of figuring out how to permanently disable the Heart, battling Prime's armies, and facing Prime himself.

The chapter continued by delving a little into her friends' contributions, such as Entrapta's plans to cut off the Heart's source of power and a timetable recapping the war's most interesting developments - including the final peace talks.

Adora closed the book, frowning. Most of what was publically known about the end of the war had been faithfully recorded, but what had happened in the time between Adora passing out and reinforcements arriving had been her own guess: the last thing she remembered was the Heart going off, so when she'd woken up to her strength depleted and the planet's core devastated, she'd drawn her own conclusions that the Heart had to be responsible for that, as well. No one but Catra had been at the Heart with her, and since Catra had never contradicted Adora's official version - what with her having been twitching and in pain for the whole time - no one had had any reason to question it.

Adora was questioning it now. If there was anything tonight had taught her, it was that her powers being gone or irretrievable had been nothing but a fancy of hers. She'd never felt them as strongly as when Catra had touched her, except for when she'd seen her fall at the Heart.

“Adora?” Bow’s voice came from around the corner, his steps muffled by his slippers. He looked all ready for bed, wearing soft pajamas and a robe wrapped around him. It got really cold in the Whispering Woods at night. “Are you still up?”

She’d barely noticed how late it was, or that the fire was slowly dying down. She stoked it again, clutching her blanket closer, sinking deeper and deeper into the armchair. “Yeah, sorry. I was just reading.”

“Hey, no problem,” Bow beamed. “It’s nice to see someone appreciate what my dads do.”

“Well, they deserve it,” Adora said, sinking deeper into the armchair to get comfortable. “They’ve been hard at work since the war ended.”

“Yeah,” Bow nodded. “Having lived in a pocket dimension for thousands of years gives you a lot to catch up on.”

“The universe is so wide,” Adora observed, feeling an urge to look out the window. As always, she felt called to the stars. Not to Eternia, specifically, or any other planet - just the stars. The idea of being out, out and away. Of floating. Of eventually dissolving, so that her essence could reach the farthest corners of the universe, live there while she was gone. She imagined it would be peaceful. Her heart longed for it in ways she couldn’t explain. “And rich. I don’t even know where to start.”

“There’s so much new history to be recorded, and art, and literature - I hope more people will join us soon. No one really stops by anymore, and if I have to hear my parents argue one more time about the Vase of Erelandia-”

Adora had never really known where Bow lived when he wasn’t in Bright Moon or in his parents’ home, pretending to be on a break from the Academy. She knew he’d lived in Bright Moon since soon after the war, to oversee peace talks and repairs, but he’d eventually moved out and back with his parents after his fallout

with Glimmer. She understood it better now, how something between them had broken that not even a ten-year foundation could fix, but it hurt all the same.

"I'm sorry," Adora murmured, "about you and Glimmer."

Bow tensed up. "Yeah, well." He fidgeted with the belt of his robe for a while. "Me too. And I'm sorry for you too, because you came all this way, and you were probably hoping we could all be together again, and instead there's always this - weird tension between us."

Adora had seen Bow looking like this only once in her life, when she and Glimmer had been fighting and Bow's efforts to have them reconcile amounted to nothing. That had been the first time he'd doubted the power of friendship, or rather, other people's willingness to invest as much into it as he did. It had been the thing to send him over the edge in Beast Island, and it was clearly bothering him again now. Adora had witnessed Bow constantly trying to make peace with Glimmer and act normally, and Glimmer kept pulling away from him to cry about it in private. From his point of view, it made sense for him to believe that he was the only one trying to repair their friendship, when actually…

"Glimmer just needs time, you know." Maybe even a lot of time - but they'd been through worse and come out all the stronger for it. Adora recalled their fight before Beast Island, and how both Bow and Adora forgot all the reasons they were mad at Glimmer when they saw her in danger. How eventually those reasons came back to them, but how the love they felt for her encouraged them to work past it. How natural it had felt when they'd been with each other again, like friendship had been ingrained into them from the start. "Things will be back to normal soon enough."

That gave Bow pause - which worried Adora. She wanted - no, needed him to believe that some friendships didn't get tangled in the fabric of time. That not all of them, but some, were never too broken to be repaired. Because if Bow of all people doubted it, then what hope did Adora have that her friendships here would

last, that she wouldn't just look at her life on Eternia one day and realize she was truly alone? That she and Catra could fix what went wrong between them, eventually, when they stopped kissing and making things more complicated than they already were?

Bow couldn't give up on Glimmer yet. Adora was just about to tell him that, but Bow spoke first: "I don't… want things to go back to normal, though?"

Adora stared, confused and slightly heartbroken. "You don't want to be Glimmer's friend anymore?"

"No, Adora," Bow sighed and rubbed his forehead, which was his way of calling her a dumbass. Adora couldn't exactly help having grown up sheltered, thank you very much. "Of course I want us to be friends. But I don't want to act like nothing ever happened between us. I don't regret it."

"Even if it cost you your best friend?"

Bow shook his head and made a move to sit in the armchair next to Adora. It felt heavy, suddenly - recognizing that whatever he was about to say was important enough for him to postpone sleep for a little longer. "It cost me nothing. We became something else, but it didn't feel like I was losing anything because of it. On the contrary - it felt like more. Like I was suddenly more."

"But it ruined things between you two," Adora frowned.

Bow was somberly looking down at his knees. "Have you ever been in love, Adora?"

Something inside her snapped to attention. She didn't know the answer to that question, but it was the question itself - what it awakened in her - that enthralled her. They hadn't known about love in the Horde, except in the sense of liking something very much, and in the real world, though everyone was obsessed with it, no one had been able to explain it to her.

“I hear it has something of pain,” she eventually said, thinking of Glimmer.

"No,” Bow replied, clearly thinking of himself instead. “No, it has nothing to do with it.”

Adora looked at the fire crackling for a little while. Bow never elaborated; he stared at the fire, too.

“Are you okay, Adora?” he mumbled all of a sudden, so softly she barely even heard him. “I don’t think I’ve even asked. You’re much quieter now.”

Adora was almost taken aback by that revelation. In her head, she was screaming all the time, constantly aware of her body being too awkward, of her taking up too much space - and yet none of that showed. She’d learned how to hide it well, and had to keep hiding it now. “Yeah, I’m fine.”

“I just want you to know,” he continued, “that you can still count on me and Glimmer, even if we’re dealing with stuff of our own. And not just here, either - whenever you need. Write a letter and we’ll be there for you, okay?”

Adora threw her head back, feeling heat rise to her cheeks. The fire, maybe. “I’m fine,” she repeated.

Bow sighed, starting to get up. “You probably imagined your last night different.”

“Hey, no. I love being here and learning stuff I didn’t know. In another universe, I’d like the idea of working here.” Learning about what she couldn’t experience first-hand, living through the pages of these books. Would she understand, then? Would she *know* ? “Actually - would it be okay if I checked out some more books before going to bed?”

“Books about what?” Bow asked, yawning into his hand. He wouldn’t be keeping her company for much longer.

Adora turned her head towards the immense library. The night might still be young, but it was gonna be long. “I’m thinking,” she said carefully, “about love.”

Bow was able to convince her that she couldn’t consume the entirety of human literature in one sitting, no matter how motivated she was. So he picked the next best thing for her, which apparently were selected works from all over the galaxy.

Adora started with a book of fairytales from Earth. She’d never visited it, but it was where her mother had been born. Relations between Earth and Eternia were tight thanks to her, and the queen had been an avid reader, stocking the royal library full of books from whatever near or far away civilization she had come into contact with. Adora saw herself in her a lot, though she’d never met her - that constant drive to know, to learn, to improve. Adora had been more than happy to donate some of those books to George and Lance and even order official translations when needed, if only because her mother wouldn’t have hesitated to spread that knowledge across the universe.

One story in particular was about a princess born with magical powers, locked up in a tower by a witch who wanted to take advantage of her, and a handsome prince who, time and time again, scaled the walls of the tower to love and comfort her in secret. But when the witch found out, she cast them both into the desert - the princess lonely and desperate, searching for the only love she ever knew, and the prince blind, blood and tears clouding his vision day and night.

There was something seriously wrong with Adora, and Shadow Weaver was always telling everyone. She had the best doctors in the Horde looking after her, the finest uniforms made for her, and gray ration bars - they were much better than the brown kind - reserved for her at every meal. Yet the child was never happy. She

put all of herself into training, as Shadow Weaver wanted, never spoke to any of the other cadets, and went straight to bed after dinner to do it all over again the next morning. Adora didn't remember that time of her life - she was far too young - but Shadow Weaver had reminded her, sometimes, that the only reason she'd ever gotten better was because her guardian cared, and if she thought Adora was disregarding her kindness and, by extension, her wishes for her in any way, she could always take that happiness away.

One day, when Shadow Weaver was on the verge of losing all hope, she presented Adora with one of the newest cadets, and that, Adora remembered. Adora could never forget. Since the two would share sleeping spaces, Shadow Weaver suggested, in a peremptory tone that made it sound more like an order, that they get to know each other and be friends - a suggestion which, as it turned out, hadn't been necessary at all, because the other girl tried to cuddle up to Adora right away, holding on to her like a lifeline. It took days, or maybe weeks, but eventually Adora talked to her, and the first thing she asked her was her name, since Shadow Weaver had forgotten to introduce her.

The girl didn't know her name, either. No one had ever bothered to give her one - so Adora would.

And she called her Catra.

She didn't realize she had fallen asleep until a knock jolted her awake. In her hurry to get up, the book she was reading slid from her lap onto the floor, face down. George and Lance would never let her live it down if she broke the spine of one of the oldest books written in First Ones language, whether they themselves understood it or not; and so she bent down to pick it up.

The knock came again. It didn't come from the front door, or from the hallway where any of the other rooms could be accessed. It came from the library window, soft but insistent. Adora advanced

slowly, reaching for the sword on her back - and her hands came up empty.

The knocking got louder - actually, no, it just turned into scratching. Slow, deliberate scratching which hurt her ears. “Adora,” a muffled voice grunted from outside.

"Oh, my God," Adora groaned, and rushed to unlatch the window. She threw it open, squinting in the darkness, eyes still glazed over from sleep. “What?”

Catra blinked disorientedly on the other side, like she’d just been minding her business before Adora started screaming at her for no reason. “Let me in.”

Adora looked back to the clock hanging on the wall. “It’s 3 in the morning.”

“Adora, it’s freezing out here.”

She huffed, but figured letting Catra in right away would spare her some time. God knows she would have been capable of knocking on Bow’s door next, or worse - his dads’. She grabbed Catra by the lapels of her suit - she owned one in every shade of red, it seemed, and never matched the jacket with the correct pair of pants to piss Adora off specifically - and pulled her inside, letting her tumble to the floor. There was no need to worry about waking anyone up, because Catra was graceful in that, too.

“Well, someone’s groggy,” Catra rolled her eyes, wiping off specks of dust from her suit as she got up.

Adora crossed her arms in front of her chest, suddenly reminded of being too exhausted to argue. “Why are you here?”

“You’re leaving, aren’t you?”

Adora felt she was in danger, somehow, no matter what she replied. “Catra, you knew I was leaving.”

“And I have to find out from Scorpia.”

“What? We said goodbye earlier.”

“You were saying a lot of things earlier, Adora, and none of them was *goodbye*.”

Adora thought back to their rendez-vous in the woods. Catra had to have known she was leaving in the morning, right? Adora had never told her, but she’d figured she knew. When she’d told Catra goodnight, after a few more failed attempts at drawing out her powers - Catra engulfing her and overwhelming her and emptying her out - it had looked to her like Catra understood the weight of the situation.

“Don’t worry, though,” Catra walked past her, jumping up on one of the tables. “I’m not here to demand a proper send-off or anything. Actually, I’m here to give you a little parting gift.”

“A gift,” Adora repeated, more and more confused by the second. The late hour didn’t help.

“I think I know how to bring back She-Ra,” she said. Her hands were trembling, either because of the cold or out of nervousness, so she caught Adora’s and busied herself playing with them, as if working herself up for a challenge. “I’m gonna try to lure her out, but you need to trust me, okay?”

Adora had trusted Catra with several things in the past, and almost every time, Catra had defied those expectations, and not always in a good way. After tonight, trusting her not to awaken powers that should’ve stayed dormant sounded like indulging a death wish, and though Catra had broken down most of her walls, Adora wasn’t nearly there yet. “I can’t.”

“Give me some credit. I did help before, didn’t I?”

“No, I mean -” She had to rip the words out of her own mouth, more of a reminder to herself than an explanation for Catra’s

sake. “I almost set off a weapon of mass destruction twice. I’m not risking it again.”

“What would you be risking? The Heart has been deactivated,” Catra pointed out. Adora tried to take her hands back, but Catra held on to them. Her eyes burned into Adora’s, and though she tried, she found she couldn’t look away when Catra bowed her head gently to press a kiss to her knuckles. “I’ve seen your magic, Adora. It’s all but destructive.”

“But how can you tell? How can you know for sure-”

“Adora,” Catra held her gaze, “when Shadow Weaver used the Heart against me, that was a fatal wound she gave me. I didn’t recover easily.”

Adora didn’t want to remember. Flashes of Catra injured and bleeding on an infirmary bed came up anyway. “Yeah, of course. We had the best healers looking after you - you were in Bright Moon for weeks.”

“I wouldn’t have recovered at all,” she went on, “had it not been for you. You must’ve overworked yourself, because you passed out right afterwards, but -”

Adora heard the words without understanding them. Panic spiked in her chest, trying to keep her mind from wandering too far from her body. “What?”

“Here.” Catra guided their joined hands to the hem of her own shirt. Adora gaped, watching as Catra slipped their hands under the light fabric, over warm skin. She brought them up over her stomach, up over her ribcage, then further up still - and stopped.

There was her heart, beating steadily. It didn’t pound erratically like Adora’s, which was the first thing she noticed. The second was a scar in the middle of Catra’s chest, which she traced with her thumb. Her finger tingled at the touch.

A blast hitting Catra right in the chest. A feeling like burning.

When Adora still didn't say anything, Catra squeezed her hand. "It almost stopped. Do you remember?"

Adora blinked the memories away. All she could tell her was the truth. "I can't."

"Don't be afraid," Catra whispered.

Adora had been right to think her powers had kicked in - but not to power the Heart and destroy. To heal. To save. Catra had been on the brink of death, and Adora had pulled her back.

"Why didn't you say anything before? To anyone?"

That seemed to take Catra aback, but Adora paid it no mind. Her reply didn't matter anyway, and neither did Adora's question. The past year was still rearranging in her mind, and in the grand scheme of things, it was completely irrelevant. "I didn't know for sure until a few hours ago. People in Bright Moon were surprised I'd survived with a wound like that. They kept asking me questions I had no answer to, so I just considered myself lucky. But your magic earlier - I felt it. I recognized it."

"And you think you can bring back She-Ra?" Her head had just now caught up with the past few minutes. "Without the Sword?"

"If you'll let me."

She already knew she would. She'd let Catra do whatever she wanted to her. She was just buying time until she could accept it. "But what if that was an isolated incident, what if - what if I lose control?"

"Hey." Catra's hand left Adora's under her shirt - Adora hadn't even realized how tight she was holding on to it - leaving the fabric slightly askew, exposing part of her lower abdomen. Only Catra's fingers dancing on her jaw, beating a steady rhythm, reminded her that there was currently more than that going on. "I won't let you lose control for one second. I promise."

Adora kept staring. “I thought you said you were sick of promises.”

A look crossed Catra’s face too quickly for Adora to catch. With a pained sigh, she dropped her forehead to Adora’s, her breaths now messing up the stray hairs escaping her ponytail. “This will be my last one. I promise that, too.”

She tilted Adora’s head up and Adora let herself be kissed, then. What had she ever gained from resisting Catra, anyway? What part of herself that was not yet broken was she trying to preserve?

“Trust me,” Catra kept muttering against her mouth, “trust me on this, and I won’t ask anything else of you, ever again.”

She wondered why Catra cared so much. She wondered if the reason why her power went haywire whenever she was near was because it recognized her, too, and not because it remembered fighting her. That time by the Heart, fighting her had been the furthest thing from her mind; she’d wanted to protect Catra, and because she’d overexerted herself, the rest of the world had almost paid the price. Was it really wise to take that risk again?

But Catra didn’t need her protection now. Catra was the one who stood tall in front of her and offered her solace - whether she knew it or not. Adora would probably not even stay in Etheria for long enough to regret her decision. “What are you going to do?”

Catra blinked at her, considering, her gaze slowly trailing down to Adora’s pale, unblemished skin with pure, self-absorbed hunger. “I’m going to make you so obsessed with me you can’t stand it.” And she attacked Adora right there, her teeth digging in mercilessly, the burn soothed quickly by her tongue.

Adora’s grip on her clenched, one of her hands nearly tearing out Catra’s hair. “I’m already obsessed with you,” she confessed, feeling no shame. She was too far gone. What did it matter if she admitted this, too, what did it matter -

Catra raised her head, curious, and Adora met her gaze head on. She wasn't afraid of Catra. She wasn't running from her anymore. "Yeah?"

"You know the effect you have on me." But she mentally jotted down that Catra might need a reminder. Of what kind - she'd decide later. "You've used it to your advantage many times."

"Still wasn't enough to make you stay, was it?"

Adora regretted bringing up the past now. This was neither the time nor place to have this conversation. She hated hurting Catra, and she hated that she still couldn't help but justify it. "Nothing would've been enough. Not even you - no matter how much I wanted you. Even back then."

"Want." Catra licked the word off Adora's lips, tasted it on her own tongue. "No, I imagine it wouldn't."

Don't ask more of me, Adora silently begged. *Wanting you is all I can allow.*

"Don't worry, Adora," Catra sighed. "I know you'll put your destiny before everything else - even when that destiny has long been fulfilled. So I'm going to give it back to you, okay? It's just that this time -" She punctuated that sentence with another, harsher kiss, "I'm not giving you an easy choice."

Adora didn't know what happened to her then. Maybe it was Catra playing with the strap of her dress with no intention to pull it down; maybe it was Catra's use of the word "choice" that got to her, because she had to know Adora had no true choice in the matter at all. Whatever the reason, her insides lurched forward, refusing to be contained. Every reserve Adora might've had, every doubt about the technicalities of what she was about to do - they were pummeled to dust the moment she saw Catra smirking, easily perched on the table like her closeness was of no consequence to Adora, like it didn't have a world-ending power on her.

“Shut up,” she murmured, so low Catra had to twitch her ears at the sound. “I’m so sick of hearing you brag with nothing to show for it. I’m sick of it.”

Catra’s eyes looked darker in the firelight, her blue eye looking almost black with the gold one reflecting the glint of the flames. “Adora, I need you not to think.”

“Trust me. I’m not.”

And because Catra just stood with her mouth hanging open, her brow furrowed, Adora took that as an invitation to go on. “I love that stupid suit. I’m going to rip it off of you.” And she proceeded to do just that, tired of how slow Catra was being, of Catra showing up in the middle of the night to work her up and then refusing to do anything about it. Adora’s hands eagerly stroked up and down Catra’s skin again, paying close attention to her sensitive spots, and Catra’s breathless sighs of *Adora* in her ears almost drowned out her next words. “I love how you say my name.” One of her hands inched lower over Catra’s waist and hips to settle on her thigh, trying to nudge her legs apart so Adora could step in between.

Without objection, Catra did it for her. They fell open and engulfed Adora like a flower beckoning a bee. Adora advanced on her, or maybe was pulled closer, but she felt it again, that hunger deep inside, and she just wanted it to be quenched. She wanted Catra to stop smirking. She wanted to push her down and take what she needed, if it was what Catra wanted, too.

She fought every single one of those instincts to lay Catra down gently. She’d be soft with her; she would. She buried her face in the hollow of Catra’s neck, gathering herself, and breathed in. “I love that you still smell like me. Right here.”

Catra shuddered underneath her and clung tighter - all of her, limbs and tail and everything wrapped around Adora to keep her there. “You can’t just - say that to me.”

“I can tonight.” She pressed a messy kiss on Catra's neck and felt the skin there burning. Something sparked inside of her too - something crackled. “Tonight, you’re going to let me.”

Whatever thoughts she could still conjure after that came in the form and shape somebody else had given them. Adora had read well into the night, and every legend across the universe had seemed to her like a retelling of the same underlying story, an attempt to grasp the same indefinite feeling.

The musician that wanted to bring his love back to life, and promised *I’m going to lead you out of the darkness, but I can’t look back or you’ll be lost forever.*

(That story in particular seemed to have been one of Bow and Glimmer’s favorites. The pages were filled with handwritten notes and comments that Adora felt weren’t meant for her eyes. When Glimmer’s handwriting read *I think there’s a darkness inside me that only you know how to manage*, Adora had slammed the book closed and cried.)

The Eternian sorceress who had to sacrifice the one she loved the most to prevent a war, leaving Adora to wonder not what it felt like to be under the knife, but what it felt like to pierce someone open.

The fire princess who lost her mind when she lost her dearest friend, and burned her kingdom to the ground.

Adora was burning, too. So was the fire in the chimney, consuming the last of the firewood, and soon the house would be as wrecked as Half Moon after the Heart. She fought to maintain control, but it was slipping, slipping from her and dripping all over the room.

You’re not ready yet you must let go

Adora you must let go

“Let go, Adora.” Catra clawed at her back weakly. “It’s okay. I’ve got you.”

She stared into Catra’s eyes, fighting to stay open, and she felt suspended on the edge of that cliff again.

Adora jumped, and the fire dwindled to nothing.

Adora stared into the darkness. Catra felt her gaze on her, though she never looked over to check. She felt it running up her back, light as a feather; on the back of her head, piercing through her skull; on her shoulder, sometimes accompanied by a kiss.

She didn’t expect Adora to still want to kiss her. She didn’t expect Adora to be needy.

She’d been overly cuddly with her once upon a time, when they were young enough to still get away with it; but Catra hadn’t shared her bed in years, and she’d thought Adora had outgrown that side of her by now.

Catra wasn’t complaining. She’d had no one to hold her through the night for so long.

Adora’s arms around her middle tightened when she felt Catra move, only to slacken again when she realized Catra was just turning on her side. She was going nowhere - she felt boneless, and weightless, and herself for the first time since Adora had left.

She had her night vision to thank if she could see her better than Adora saw her. Adora must’ve relied on touch alone until her eyes got used to the darkness - tracing the shape of her lips, of her collarbones, the indents of her hips - but Catra could observe her closely. Her hair was down on her shoulders, longer than Catra remembered it, and some of it fell on Adora’s face, but she paid it no mind. She was smiling - stupidly, recklessly.

Catra brushed it away from her eyes for her, and Adora leaned into her hand right away, pressing a kiss right in the middle of the palm. “I like you better like this,” she confessed under her breath.

Adora’s eyelashes were longer than usual in the weak light. They’d moved to Adora’s room not too long after and hadn’t stopped to light a fire, but the morning moon wouldn’t take long to rise. “Like what?”

“I don’t know. Happy.” Catra touched Adora’s upturned lips like she could touch the extent of it. “It suits you.”

Adora laughed softly, as if wanting to prove Catra right one more time. “So you *do* like me.”

“Sometimes.” She shrugged, faking nonchalance, but she pushed down a laugh of her own. She couldn’t help how good she felt. “I’m guessing that worked?”

Catra waited for her to get it, then watched her smile widen even more. “Yeah. Couldn’t you feel it?”

“I definitely felt something there,” Catra mumbled, earning herself a shove. Fifteen years of memories of Adora elbowing her in the face, of them pushing each other on the way to the locker room, of fighting because Catra kept hogging all the blankets, rose kicking and screaming to the surface. The last time they’d done this had been in a fake portal reality.

“I mean - God, Catra. I may not turn into an eight-foot tall lady anymore, but the feeling is still there. Like all this power is inside me, and it’s connected to everything else.”

“The First Ones won’t know what hit them,” Catra cackled. “Watch them try to remove you now.”

“It’s so weird hearing you call them that, you know. They just call themselves Eternians. And honestly,” Adora sighed, “I kind of wish one of their attempts had succeeded. Anyone wants to take my throne, they can go right ahead.”

Catra's ears snapped to attention. Well, that didn't sound like Adora at all. "Are you sure you're not Double Trouble?"

Adora scoffed in fake outrage. Well, Catra figured it was fake, at least, because their legs were still tangled together. "Is it really that hard to believe that I don't want to spend the rest of my life alone on a hostile planet?"

"Hey, you were the one who tried to convince us otherwise," Catra reasoned. She and Adora were so close; it was only their breaths under the covers, flowing in and out of each other's lungs. Despite what they had just done, this seemed to Catra like the peak of intimacy. When she imagined having to slip away from that bed in a few hours, she felt cold all over. "You don't have to go back there if you hate it. I mean, you said it yourself - it's not like people aren't falling over themselves to replace you, anyway."

This time, the outrage seemed more real. Catra didn't fully understand what she'd said wrong, but she wished she could take it back, anyway. "Doesn't matter. It's not *their* responsibility. It's mine - I was born for this. Now that I have She-Ra's powers back-"

She never finished the sentence, probably expecting Catra to have a rebuttal ready before then; and when Catra didn't, she was left grasping for words.

Catra was confused. Adora talked of days spent in the throne room solving petty squabbles, of conflicts with her court, of a world outside her reach. The First Ones may have weaponized She-Ra to solve their intergalactic conflicts for them, but the war was over now, and what Adora might still need her powers for was beyond her. What was worse, Adora didn't seem to have a clue, either. She seemed convinced that Eternia needed her and no one else like the fate of the universe still depended on it, but was unable to explain why that was.

Adora was obviously uncomfortable under Catra's gaze, and felt the need to justify herself. "I'm allowed to be selfish sometimes,

and - wish for things I can't have. Just not for too long."

Catra decided not to push for more, because Adora having an existential crisis was the last thing she wanted right now. Instead, she rolled closer to her and buried her face in Adora's shoulder, feeling Adora's arms come up around her right away. "Am I one of those things?"

Adora didn't start, didn't stumble over her words. "Depends."

"On what?"

"Your answer."

Catra tried to pull back to look at her, but Adora kept her there, landing another kiss on her head. Catra wasn't sure she should allow Adora to be so affectionate with her - wasn't sure she should get used to this so fast.

"Catra," she spoke into her hair, breath brushing her ears, "my Catra. I want you to come with me."

Come with me, Adora said in another life, holding her hand while Thaymor burned around them, *you don't have to go back there, we can fix this* ; and in another life Catra pulled away from her, disbelieving, and refused to give her what she wanted, because Adora had already taken too much from her anyway.

In this life, however, Catra spent way too long reeling from Adora calling her hers. Not in a possessive way - not trying to stake her claim on Catra, but giving her somewhere to belong. *Catra. My Catra.*

It was one thing to convince herself she didn't need to let her happiness depend on one person living on another planet, with no way to be reached, and another thing entirely to reject that happiness when she had it in her hands.

Adora kept fondling her like a kitten, giving special attention to her ears. She rightfully took Catra's hesitation to mean she was

considering it, which made her relentless in both her cares and her words. “I want to take you to the Pink Cliffs,” she murmured, “over the edge of the universe. Wouldn’t you like that?”

“Adora-” It took all the self-respect she could muster to pull away from her in this life, too. “I can’t.”

Adora frowned, an uneasy smile making its way onto her face. “Hey, I don’t mean - forever. But a little while.”

“I can’t,” Catra repeated. “I’m needed here. There are things I have to make up for - I can’t just up and leave because you’re asking.”

That was a bit harsh, and she realized too late. It’s not like Adora was forcing her to come with her, but to Catra, who’d worked hard to learn to live without Adora, this felt like a dare. It felt like Adora trying to tear down all her carefully constructed defenses, to mess up all of her plans - to reveal how much Catra was lying to herself.

Adora was careful in her response, disentangling her legs from Catra’s to hold them to her own chest. It broke Catra’s heart to think that Adora felt the need to protect herself - from her. “I didn’t want that. I swear. I don’t even know how things are going for you right now, because, well - you won’t tell me.”

Catra scoffed at her, because what she really wanted was to pour her heart out to her. Everything she’d been feeling since Adora had first left - everything she’d seen and experienced, all of her fears and hopes. “Sorry. Guess I felt I didn’t need to, since you were going to assume whatever you wanted anyway.”

“Don’t,” Adora said coldly. “Okay? Don’t do that. Not when we’re like this.”

Catra grunted, turning on her other side, facing away from Adora. She couldn’t handle looking at her right now - couldn’t handle facing her anger again, like a misguided child being scolded by their parent. *You’ve made your choice. Now live with it.*

“We used to tell each other everything.” Adora’s voice sounded sadder then. “I tried opening up to you, and - well, if you don’t want to do the same, I respect that. But then don’t go blaming me for not knowing what’s going on in your life. I may have been naive in the past, but I’m still not a mind reader.”

Catra kind of hoped her pillow would smother her. “Okay.”

A peculiar kind of silence fell over them for so long that Catra started to think Adora had fallen asleep. Even the fire had stopped crackling and eventually died down. Catra tried to imagine that - their last conversation before Adora left again for God knows how long being a fight. It almost made her want to turn around and beg for her forgiveness - but then Adora spoke again, so softly that Catra could barely hear her, even in that deadly quiet.

“I just wanted more time with you.”

Nope. No, no, no, she couldn’t do this. She couldn’t just - lie there and take it without a word. She’d let Adora take anything, everything from her, so long as she never had to hear her say something like that again. “I can’t.”

She felt a rustling of sheets, probably Adora settling down to sleep properly. “Alright. I just needed you to know.”

Catra took a deep breath and got ready to curse herself. “But maybe-”

“Yes?” Adora piped up behind her, gently nudging Catra’s shoulder to get her to lie on her back again. “What were you saying?”

Catra hesitated some more. Was she really about to do this? Was she going to give Adora this, as well, like her life wasn’t already tied to Adora’s, like she didn’t already owe Adora her heartbeat and the breath in her lungs? She turned around to face her and winced. “It’s, ah, my birthday? In three months?”

Adora frowned, and Catra hated herself for how cute she found it. “You don’t have a birthday.”

“I mean - everyone has one, I just don’t know when it is. But birthdays are important to these people, so the Magicats kind of decided we’d celebrate it on the same day as my coronation?”

“Oh.” Adora nodded. She’d missed Catra’s official coronation, of course, being long gone by then - not that Catra would have invited her. “Cool.”

“Yeah, so, um - you don’t have to, but if you wanted to know more about my life right now, I guess you could… come visit?”

Catra caught the split second when that suggestion registered in Adora’s eyes, and she absolutely beamed above her. “Would that make you happy?”

Catra had never felt weaker than right now, never more exposed than this, and being vulnerable didn’t feel nearly as good as everyone kept telling her it was. Still, there was no going back. No more pretending. “Yes."

There was only hoping this thing, whatever it was, didn’t kill her.

Catra could remember only one time that Shadow Weaver had been truly nice to her.

That day, Catra had done well on her training. On Adora’s suggestion, she’d shown up on time, fought fiercely without overshadowing anyone, said please *and* thank you *and* yes ma’am *and* yes sir*. Catra knew now that nothing she would have ever done would’ve been enough for Shadow Weaver - that her treatment of Catra wasn’t justified by Catra’s shortcomings, or lack thereof. But back then, she’d wanted to impress her guardian so bad, and Shadow Weaver must’ve noticed. Just maybe, she had decided throwing her a bone would keep Catra satisfied for some time, keep her more in line, convince her this was how she got what she wanted. And so, for all of her troubles, Shadow Weaver gave Catra a new jacket.*

It was pink and ripped on the arms, to fit your style, *Shadow Weaver had said, and Catra had almost cried. Wearing anything other than a Horde uniform meant being slightly higher than anyone else in Shadow Weaver's regard, and while Adora had already gotten a few modifications done to her outfit, Catra had long since given up hope for herself. Until now.*

Unfortunately, Catra had also left the jacket on her and Adora's bed, and when Adora had come in, done with the day's activities, Catra hadn't had time to open her mouth before Adora threw herself on the bed, excitedly, and waved the jacket around victoriously, screaming: "Is this for me? Did Shadow Weaver leave it for me? Look at this, Catra, it's so pretty!"

Adora liked the jacket. Adora was already trying it on to find it fit perfectly. Adora didn't wait for Catra to explain that the jacket was actually hers, that it was the first ever token of Shadow Weaver's affection and probably the last she would ever have, and to beg her if she could please, please let her have just this one thing.

Catra didn't say anything - because Adora liked the jacket, and Adora got everything she wanted. That was just the way things went.

So she shrugged, pretending not to care, pushing down the boiling hatred and resentment and focusing on her best friend, instead - on how happy this was making her, how the jacket looked better on her, anyway.

"*Yeah," she said, forcing herself to smile, "of course it is."*

Chapter End Notes

So Italy is now under complete lockdown, I'm scared and anxious all the time, and I've been writing non-stop to feel productive and distract myself. I had a quarter of the chapter already written when the first one was posted, but I'm very slow at writing and I've had to rewrite some of these scenes like, five times to make sure I got them right and that

everything fit together (I set up so. much. stuff). I really hope you like it too. I know I'm not big on replying to comments, but I'll make an effort from now on. I even accept criticism, as long as it's constructive and respectful, so don't be afraid to speak out if there was something you DIDN'T like.
Anyway, right now it's looking like the fic will have 4-5 chapters. Maybe 4 + an epilogue. We'll see. Again, I'm very slow but I do want to finish this fic at all costs, so if you don't see me updating for a while, feel free to yell at me. Seriously. I HAVE TO FINISH THIS. I wanted to have it all out before the final season dropped, but writing at least 20k words in two months is an impossible feat for me. I'll try, though. Hopefully I can at least get chapter 3 out by then.

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

Welp. I have bad news and good news.

Bad news: This is only half of a chapter, which I know is not a good look after not posting anything for more than three months, but the actual chapter was growing too long (I was pushing 12k already and would definitely get to 14-15k at least) and I figured you guys had waited enough, so I decided to split it. I know I said I'd post at least the third chapter before s5 dropped, but I got too caught up in both the pre- and post- season hype, and being stuck home all the time with my family kinda made it impossible to write except at night, so. Here we are.

Good news: You probably won't have to wait long for the second half. I've only got a couple more scenes left to write and then the editing part, meaning I could probably get it out in the next one to two weeks. Like always, I appreciate your encouragement and even your constructive criticism, if you have any!
Enjoy!

P.S: Obviously, this is now Canon Divergent after s4, so be mindful of that, I guess. Almost all of this chapter was written before s5 aired.

Adora had paced back and forth in her chambers for days before a letter finally came.

That wasn’t to say the previous three months had gone like a breeze; in fact, they’d lasted twice as long to Adora as her one year of rule. It had gotten easier with time, for sure, but she still remembered the franticness of the first few days, of knowing she had still - but *only* - three months to get through.

Had she not known something was waiting for her on the other side to give her some reprieve soon, she would have eventually accustomed to her old life again without thinking too hard about it. Instead, prancing about court, she couldn't shake the feeling that this was *wrong*, like - like Frosta on the beach, was the only comparison that came to mind. Was anything actively forbidding her to have a beach day? Absolutely not, and in fact, it would probably do Frosta some good. Could she survive it no problem? Most likely - as long as someone regularly reminded her to put on sunscreen. Would people still do a double take at the sight of a teenage girl with ice powers quietly sunbathing? Well -

It had a lot to do with Adora missing Catra. When she'd woken up on the day of her departure, Catra had been gone, but her scent - *their* scent - had been all over the pillows. Adora hadn't been able to get it out of her mind; it had followed her all the way to Eternia and kept her up at night.

Adora liked to think she knew a little bit more about love now than she did before - knew, at the very least, that she'd held it inside her for as long as she'd known Catra, and all she needed to do was learn to identify it. But *desire* - that was new.

She'd only gotten a taste of it on her last night on Etheria, but it had been enough for her to understand what Glimmer had tried to tell her. It had felt like an exchange, the energy easily flowing in and out of her body and into Catra's - except at some point the cycle had stopped, and now the energy was stuck inside her, begging to be let out again.

That had been when she hadn't yet been apart from Catra for long enough to actually miss her - a shallow and purely physical need. The hardest part had come after, when the desire had faded and the actual longing had come in. She'd started missing Catra in the simplest, deepest ways - missed being kissed and held by her, but most of all, missed her hand in Catra's like when they were kids, her easy as well as her hard-won smiles, nights telling each other everything but what was really in their hearts. She'd gotten a taste of that too, before leaving, but it was the idea that they'd

actually work towards getting all of that back when they saw each other again that sustained her.

She'd sent Catra tons of letters - some extremely corny and inspired by Adora's latest read, some more serious and lengthy. Catra only replied sometimes, usually to make fun of her, but she had told her to expect a letter from her around this week to make plans.

And then a page burst through her door. They rarely knocked these days, more concerned with sharing and receiving whiffs of court gossip than with respecting anyone's privacy. The princess receiving a letter was probably the most excitement this page regularly came upon, which was why he'd taken such an interest to her correspondence with Catra. It had gotten to the point that Adora would know for sure it was her writing just by the sly look on his face.

"A letter for Your Highness," he announced proudly.

She didn't think he actually *read* her letters, because the sigil was always intact, and so far no rumors had spread around court that Princess Adora had a secret lover - though only thinking of Catra that way made her heart flutter in her chest. She still put on her blankest face before taking the letter from the page's hands. "Thank you. You may leave."

The page looked disappointed - he'd probably hoped for more fuel to his fantasies - but did as he was told.

As for Adora, she opened the letter as soon as he was out of sight.

Hey Adora,

celebrations for my birthday start next week. It will be a few days, though, until this letter reaches you. Entrapta promises she's still working on that interplanetary communication system, but she'd

need to look into your planet's weird magic some more to avoid interference with our own.

I'll be waiting for you, if you still want to come. Let me know for sure, so I can have a room ready for you. Also, wear light clothing - Half Moon is warm as hell at every time of year.

Catra

Double Trouble scoffed, peeking over Catra's shoulder at what she was writing. "You're sounding a little desperate there, kitten."

Catra frowned, because this time, she'd taken great care to sound as distant as possible. She'd taken out all the *I can't wait to see you* and *Let me know if you'd like a room of your own or if you just want to share mine* and *Love, Catra*. "I didn't ask for your opinion," she said, though she'd definitely called them hoping they'd be nosy enough to take a look at what she was doing.

"'Wear light clothing'? She's gonna think you want to jump her bones upon arrival."

"I added an explanation right there," Catra insisted, fighting the blush that was rising onto her face. "We're underground and near the planet's core. I don't want her to suffocate. Plus, Adora has the least dirty mind of anyone I've ever known."

"Is that why she wrote in her last letter-"

"Don't."

"I'm just saying, she's very fond of literary metaphors-"

"Maybe *you're* the one with a dirty mind, and she's just very naive about how she can come off," Catra murmured. "Either way, I'm not writing this again. Just take it to my sister to be sent."

Double Trouble sighed, getting up off the bed. "Which one?"

“Whichever one’s on duty right now. Anya, I think? I need to get ready for guests.”

“They just never stop coming.” They grabbed the sealed letter from Catra’s hands. “Who is it this time?”

They were right to be annoyed, partly. Half Moon really was having an inflow of visitors these days, all of them dropping by to wish her a happy birthday before things got too hectic. That, and Catra had deliberately instructed people to come before the actual celebrations started, so she wouldn’t have too many people around when Adora got there.

“A friend,” Catra replied, entirely unhelpfully, as she quickly started considering what to wear to dinner. “I know you remember her. You’ve betrayed me for her, after all.”

Double Trouble’s contrived smile almost reached their ears. “No hard feelings, though?”

Catra looked them up and down one last time. As long as the kingdoms kept their peace, there was no danger of Double Trouble switching sides again, and even then, she liked to think they’d be reluctant to the idea, given that they had a place at court and on the stage. You couldn’t be more loved, admired, and better paid than Double Trouble was right now.

It wasn’t exactly the most solid ground for a stable work relationship - but Catra still thought Double Trouble liked her, in their own way. And hell, where would *she* be without someone giving her a second chance and a place to stay?

"Nah,” Catra confirmed, waving them away. “No hard feelings.”

Glimmer looked about as good as you’d expect, meaning she was wearing a lot of pink, a lot of purple, and her face lit up annoyingly the moment she saw Catra. The fact that Catra’s heart

jolted a bit in happiness too, however, was the most annoying thing.

Catra braced herself for what was coming. Watched as Glimmer fought the urge to surge forward and just opened her arms. Squeezed her eyes shut waiting for the inevitable.

It came along with Glimmer's voice. "Permission to hug?"

"Ugh," Catra whined, but at this point, it was more performative than anything. She'd missed Glimmer. They weren't the kind of friends who saw each other all the time - actually, she wasn't even sure they could be considered friends at all - but being trapped on Horde Prime's spaceship together had still bonded them forever. "If you have to."

Beaming, Glimmer skipped a few steps and threw her arms around Catra's neck, her sickeningly sweet perfume engulfing Catra. "It's nice to see you."

Catra chuckled before burying her head in Glimmer's hair. It was getting longer by the day. "Nice to see you too, Sparkles."

The first surprise of the day came when Catra pulled away from the hug and, looking behind Glimmer, saw the king of Bright Moon himself, his luggage trailing behind. Almost as soon as he walked through the door, he was assisted by Catra's brother Hector, a bulky yet extremely shy Magicat who only smiled kindly at both guests before taking their bags and his leave.

"King Micah," Catra greeted. "It's an honor."

Micah looked at her like he couldn't say the same, but he still nodded. "We wouldn't miss it."

Catra glanced at Glimmer, confused. King Micah almost never showed up for public events, having spent almost two decades alone on a hostile island, but especially when Catra was involved. The man had never fully forgiven her for Angella's death, and it wasn't like Catra could blame him - but he'd lived through Shadow

Weaver's manipulation himself, and maybe him showing up now was a sign that he was willing to give her the benefit of the doubt.

Glimmer was about to open her mouth to explain, when Micah landed a hand on his daughter's shoulder. "I'm going to go get settled, dear. Just call when dinner's ready."

She nodded, tilting her head back slightly to accept the kiss her father dropped there.

Catra watched, ignoring the pang of envy in her gut. Or well, maybe not envy - she'd disliked Glimmer, once, thinking she had everything Catra didn't, only to realize her façade of happiness had come at a cost.

No, it was more like longing. It stayed with her even after she'd been lucky enough to find part of her family, because her heart wasn't used to having all its pieces into place and periodically recreated fractures to keep itself alive.

Micah bowed his head to Catra and followed Hector to his room, even offering to lighten his load. As Catra watched him go, the ache subsiding only minimally, Glimmer offered her her arm, and there they went, like old ladies, or aristocrats, or enemies-turned-friends enjoying each other's company. She didn't know if it had been intentional on Glimmer's part, if this was her way of offering comfort, but she'd come to know Glimmer was much smarter than she looked, and knowing someone out there had not only changed her mind about her, but convinced others to try and do the same - well, for now, it did the trick.

"How is he doing?" Catra asked, as a conversation starter. The halls to the newly rebuilt palace were conspicuously empty, everyone getting some needed rest after the work day before having to get ready for dinner.

"Better," Glimmer replied. "We're not staying too long, so I thought it would be a good chance for him to get out and start readjusting. I hope I'm not wrong."

“No, it was a good call. He’ll like it here.” Due to its underground location Half Moon had to be the most isolated kingdom - not even second to the Kingdom of Snows - and it had the added value of being a place King Micah was mostly familiar with, having fought there against Prime with everyone else. It had been one of the few times King Micah had been seen outside the Bright Moon walls in more than a year.

“And you?” Glimmer turned to face her. “How are you readjusting?”

Catra shrugged, because that was a more loaded question. “I’m doing the best I can. It’s not like I don’t know how to keep myself busy.”

“Yes, I’ve heard,” Glimmer said. “You got Half Moon rebuilt in record time.” About a year for a whole underground kingdom, using both magic (a little help from the princesses had gone a long way) and normal means. They’d only just finished the previous month.

“Well, I didn’t do it all by myself. I just led the operation and provided the means for reconstruction. I’ve also approved some structural changes to our buildings, to make them more durable in case the Heart acts up again.” Which, yeah, was still a lot. The Horde might have ruined her life, but it had also given her the leadership skills to make sure no one had to go through that again.

Glimmer’s smirk was extremely self-satisfied. “The Heart has been deactivated, and besides, you’ve set up a surveillance system, too.”

Catra looked down, at her bare feet pacing the hall. “I guess I did.”

It was unquestioning that Half Moon was making strides, and that it was mostly thanks to Catra. That every minute after Catra was identified by the Magicats as one of their own, she’d dedicated to

making the world she'd almost destroyed better and more functional. That she wasn't throwing away her second chance at life - that perhaps she'd even deserved it.

Except now, of course, she knew the only reason she'd been granted a second chance at all wasn't because she'd proven herself worthy of redemption to some higher force that may or may not exist, but because of Adora's magic pumping through her veins. If Catra had had even the faintest illusion before that her life mattered something in the grand scheme of things, she'd been proven wrong again.

"I've been talking to the rest of the princesses, you know," Glimmer continued after a beat, "to reconsider the terms of your freedom."

That had Catra's ears twitch in her direction. "Will I finally be allowed to leave the kingdom even without a fancy party going on?"

"Without supervision, yes. The Princess Alliance trusts you enough not to need to keep eyes on you all the time."

"I am touched." But it was a big deal, actually. Catra had been confined to her kingdom since the war had ended, save for public events - and that one night she'd snuck to Bow's house to be with Adora. Not that anyone knew about that.

Glimmer squeezed Catra's arm excitedly. "Come on. You can do better than that. Consider it an early birthday gift." And she inquired right away: "What are you going to do first?"

"I mean-" Catra shrugged, feeling the implications settle in bit by bit. "I guess I'm glad I can see Scorpia and Entrapta more often." She'd seen them last at Scorpia's birthday, which hadn't been too long after Netossa and Spinnerella's party, and then - nothing, though they'd promised her they would come visit her in time for her birthday. She was glad they'd managed to patch things up, but she realized now that maintaining relationships meant making

an effort on all ends, and she hadn't realized until now how bad she felt about not being able to reciprocate.

Glimmer nodded along. "What else?"

It was partly because the idea wouldn't leave her alone and partly because she wanted to get a reaction out of Glimmer that she spoke her next words. "I heard Eternia is also good this time of year. Any time of year, really."

Predictably, Glimmer froze in her tracks and pulled Catra back by the arm. Catra let her, pretending to be surprised. "Are you expecting Adora, too?"

Catra blinked. "Yeah? She's supposed to come next week."

"She never told me," Glimmer grumbled. "She probably knew I'd disapprove."

"Well, yeah, Sparkles, it's not exactly your business. But if you really need to know, we're just trying to mend our relationship."

Glimmer huffed, but resumed walking. Catra thought she could lead her to the garden - she'd renovated that, too, and she was extremely proud of it. "What *is* your relationship, anyway? I've always wondered. Adora never talks about it, but the only reason Horde Prime learnt about She-Ra was that she was all over your thoughts."

"And you're clearly never going to let me live that down."

"It almost caused the end of the world again, so no."

Catra scoffed. "Like *you* don't think about her."

Glimmer didn't stop this time, which Catra decided to take as a good thing. Still, she was really interested in Glimmer's reply. When she looked at her, Glimmer was furrowing her eyebrows. "I do. But she's my friend."

“Relax, I’m only sort of kidding. I won’t tell Bow you’re cheating on him or anything.”

Her head snapped in Catra’s direction. “ *What* ?” Glimmer shrieked in one of her ultrasensitive ears. “Did Adora tell you that?”

As soon as Catra could actually hear again, she had to sort out her own thoughts. “No? Was that supposed to be a secret? Because everyone knew.”

“No, they didn’t.”

“You literally didn’t even try to hide it.” Her head was going a mile a minute, trying to wrap around the fact that Adora’s new best friends were even dumber than she thought. “I was only above ground like twice and I still saw it. The most surprising thing there is that I’m actually happy for you.”

“Thanks,” Glimmer muttered under her breath, “although it’s a little late for that. I broke his heart a few months ago and I think he’s with Perfuma now, so -”

She didn’t elaborate. Catra didn’t ask her to, either.

They walked in silence for a few steps until they reached the garden. Catra had never had a green thumb, but she’d been adamant on making this place as comforting as possible after learning she’d have to be confined there. Half Moon wasn’t exactly like Bright Moon, or Salineas, or Plumeria - there were no woods to run through and no sky to look up to, just rock as far as the eye could see. So Catra had planted flowers. This was where she went when she needed a quiet place to think.

She dropped down on a bench by the underground river and was waiting for Glimmer to join her, but Glimmer stayed on the doorstep.

“And Adora?” she asked in the tiniest voice. “Are you going to break *her* heart?”

Catra had expected such a question, though she hadn't come up with an answer so far. She dipped one hand in the water, enjoying the heat while she thought. "Everyone's always so worried about Adora," she reflected out loud. "No one ever considers that she could break my heart instead."

Glimmer moved closer, maybe emboldened by the words, or maybe needing to make her point clearer. "If you're serious about this, work on fixing things between you - before it's too late." Her voice softened a bit there, but the rest of that sentence convinced Catra that it hadn't been intentional. "But if you ruin it - I swear, Catra, I'm not going to allow you twenty feet from each other again."

"I know," Catra said, still looking at the water. "I'd let her go myself if I could."

No one spoke for a few seconds, silence filled only by the rush of the river. Glimmer lay a hand on Catra's shoulder, which she didn't know whether to take as a comfort or a threat, and sat right by her.

"So," Glimmer chirped up, "I love what you've done with the place. Last time I was here, this was a pile of rubble."

Adora had insisted on no one accompanying her on her journey. First of all, because she didn't want to bother the royal pilot for what was essentially private business, and second of all - because she really wanted to fly Mara's ship herself. A very excited Entrapta had shown both her and Bow how to do it when they'd flown to Glimmer's rescue years before, and though they'd still had to rely on the autopilot system for anything beyond very simple maneuvers, Adora had liked it well enough to keep practicing after the war.

Sure, she could've let someone else take care of it, like the last time, while she stared longingly and dramatically out the window,

watching planets and stars go by - or she could enjoy the look on Catra's face when she landed the ship right in front of her.

Of course, she hadn't considered the fact that landing a spaceship wasn't an easy pursuit, and that it required much more focus than would have allowed her to show off; but while she might have missed Catra's very first reaction, she wasn't disappointed to raise her head from the commands to find Catra impressed.

She didn't have to take Adora all the way. Adora knew where the entrance to Half Moon was, had already explored those tunnels with a crazy space emperor's figurative gun to her head, and could've just met Catra at the palace. But she'd expected Catra to be there regardless, and she had been right.

There was a lilt to Adora's step as she opened the doors to the ship.

Catra, who'd stood at the spaceship's front when Adora had seen her, had clearly run up to the bottom of the few steps Adora was climbing down, so that the first thing Adora felt was a little jolt in her heart. The last few times she'd seen Catra she'd been in her formalwear, which had elicited a different kind of reaction. Now she stood in a simple maroon linen shirt and dark shorts and Adora's main preoccupation wasn't to throw herself in her arms and kiss her, though she counted on doing just that very soon. She wanted to soak her in and be with her and be with her for long enough that the sense of familiarity won over the rush of illicitness.

Adora had once been with Catra everyday, known her like the back of her hand. She never again wanted to be surprised by her hair having grown long, or by her different clothes, or by her excitement being toned down to cautiousness. She wanted, more than anything, for things to be easy again, and to wipe the confused look off Catra's face as she pulled out of reach of Adora's arms, already extended for a hug, to say:

"Adora, what the hell are you wearing?"

And there it was, the second thing Adora felt. Warmth. Scratch that - it was boiling hot. Adora's body felt like it was being slowly cooked inside its case, a sort of space gear that was the protocol for these long travels.

Adora looked down on herself and, instead of being suave as she'd imagined, could only puff out: "Oh."

Catra rolled her eyes, her hands already going to unbutton Adora's gear so she could get her out before she got a heat stroke. "I thought I told you to wear light clothes."

"I thought that was a euphemism," she whispered, though there was no one else listening. When Catra raised her head her cheeks were red, and Adora must've crossed a line or something, so she rushed to add: "I didn't remember it being that bad last time I was underground."

"Yeah, well, last time you were there, you were also She-Ra," Catra muttered, but she didn't look angry. That came as a relief to Adora, who was afraid she'd ruined everything already. "And trust me, the further down we go, the hotter it is."

"Well, it gets cold in space," Adora tried to defend herself as Catra finally got her out of the gear to reveal - a warm tunic with fleece pants.

Catra just stared at her, defeated, and pushed the space gear into her hands so Adora could go back in and leave it on the ship. "At least tell me you packed *some* light clothes," she called from outside.

"Uh-" Adora grabbed all of her stuff and poked her head back out. She had more than a few dresses, shirts and nightgowns that would fit the criteria - all extremely fine and elaborate, things she'd been advised to pack but hoped she'd never have to wear - which, to be fair, was the case for most of the clothes she owned.

"You can wear something of mine if not."

I can? Adora wanted to ask, but Catra started towards the entrance to the tunnel the second Adora came down again, bags and all.

"Check this out," Catra gestured excitedly in front of her, "I've had this built when relations between kingdoms were being re-established. Figured I should make it easier for everyone to get to Half Moon."

Adora followed her, her suitcase trailing behind her to see what Catra was talking about. She'd been expecting the same half-hour walk through twists and turns from when they were looking for the Heart, but at the entrance of the tunnel was something that looked a lot like a mine cart, on a track that got lost in the darkness and was clearly headed underground. Catra jumped in it without hesitation and glanced back at Adora.

Adora could tell Catra expected a compliment, and she definitely deserved one, but Adora couldn't shake off her worry. "Uh, Catra - is this safe? Will it hold my weight?"

Catra rolled her eyes. "Yeah, of course. It can carry up to four people. Jump on."

Adora assumed the track, too, had been tested extensively; Catra was thorough like that. Once she'd heaved the suitcase on the cart and got settled herself, Catra reached for a lever by the side of the track - and there they went.

The ride was quick and painless, though not without a few bumps. The tunnels they'd once had to find their way through went by in a blur, the air growing hotter and hotter as they barrelled down the road until they came to a stop, right in front of the royal palace.

A crowd of Magicats, which Adora could only assume were Catra's family, was gathered by the entrance, talking in hushed tones. They stopped the second Catra emerged from the cart, looking slightly murderous.

“Didn’t you all have places to be?”

“Not for a while,” the bravest one among them replied, a girl about Catra’s age but with much darker fur, “and we wanted to meet She-Ra.”

“You’re the one who saved the world,” another one said, looking at Adora with barely veiled admiration. “And saved Catra.”

Adora had thought it would be harder to see the place where the Heart used to be, thought it would unlock bad memories. It wasn’t the tunnels, though, or even seeing Half Moon and its houses. Somehow, it was those words.

You’ve saved the world.

“I wish I could’ve done more,” Adora replied. “Stopped the Heart from firing.”

“Not your fault. We’ve rebuilt Half Moon to be stronger, anyway.”

One of the Magicats, a short teenager with blonde fur, tugged on Adora’s suitcase to take it off her hands, and it distracted her enough for the feeling to be gone a second later.

“Adora, meet my brother Hector,” Catra announced. “Don’t worry, he doesn’t always work this hard. We take turns for pretty much everything, and this is just his week on room service.”

“It used to be Catra’s,” the brave one snickered, “but I guess she decided to focus all of her attention on you.”

Catra turned on the girl murderously. “It’s my coronation week. I’ve got guests coming from all over.”

“Sure. But some you care about more than others.”

“Mira, why don’t you go check on the kitchens and then bring Adora’s food up to her? I bet she’s hungry.”

Adora wasn't, really, but she didn't want to put Catra into a difficult situation, so she just extended her arm to the girl before she left: "Pleasure to meet you, Mira."

"That's Anya," Catra went on, "Sam, Cyrus, Xavier… I have no idea where Vee is-"

Adora could barely keep up with all the handshakes and forgot everyone's name the moment they were done introducing themselves.

"They're all my siblings," Catra further explained, "sort of. It's not even all of them."

Adora had to admit she had no idea how many children normal families usually had. All her life - or, well, since she'd figured out what a family was - nearly everyone she'd met had been an only child, siblings being extremely rare. Even with the excuse of a war going on, she couldn't help but think that eight children - not even all of them, Catra had said - seemed… excessive.

Catra didn't wait for her to voice that thought. As soon as introductions were done, she rushed Adora in to start giving her a tour of the palace as some of the Magicats started filing out, telling Adora they'd see her in the morning. It was probably good that she'd landed this late, so she had more time to learn everyone's names before having to make conversation with them.

Some of Catra's siblings followed them on their tour, however - including Cyrus, who was curious to know more about She-Ra - and dispersed bit by bit when they got to their rooms, or wherever they were supposed to be after dinner. Soon enough, Catra and Adora were left alone, with Catra still illustrating how they'd rebuilt the palace together from scratch. It looked less like Castle Grayskull on Eternia, or even Bright Moon, and more like a really nice household, the kind Bow and his fathers would probably like living in.

“They don’t look like you,” she said to Catra as the last of her siblings left. “They don’t even look like each other, really.”

Catra chuckled and, to Adora’s surprise, grabbed her hand. “You really let me drone on about the history of this place for twenty minutes before asking.”

“I didn’t want to seem rude.”

“It’s fine,” Catra promised. “We have no way of knowing if they’re actually my siblings.”

Adora eyed her sceptically, and her eyes fell on the curve of Catra’s shoulder. She wondered if she could lay her head there - if it was allowed, to walk hand in hand in Catra’s home like that. Adora wanted it so bad the conversation slipped from her before it even started. “Uh?”

“I mean, they’re definitely from my same royal cluster. We recognize our own. But everyone here is free to marry who they want - and by that I mean, as many people as they want, too. So children of the same cluster just grow up together, regardless of who their two birth parents are.”

Adora had never really thought about a system like that, one that hinged on the idea of people having multiple partners - but she supposed it couldn’t be that uncommon, even outside of Half Moon. When she tried to sleep, back in the Horde, and closed her eyes against the urge to touch the person at the end of her bed, she heard Kyle and Rogelio whispering, sometimes, and Lonnie leaving her bunk to join in, her voice slightly softer with them than it was during the day.

“So are the royal clusters still around?”

“Most of them, yeah. Not enough room in the palace for all of them, so they’re scattered everywhere in the kingdom, but you’ll meet them tomorrow.”

“Are they nice to you?”

For some reason, Adora felt her hand being squeezed. She glanced at Catra to find her expression had darkened slightly, though her reply was positive. “They love me a lot.”

Adora wanted to be happy for her, but the complicated expression across Catra’s face wouldn’t fully let her. So Adora stopped wondering what was allowed and what wasn’t, and lay her head down on Catra’s shoulder, hoping Catra would feel the affection coming off of her in waves. “I’m glad.”

They stopped in front of a closed door which, Adora assumed, was to be her room. It opened with a simple key, which came as a surprise to Adora, who’d lived for years with fingerprint scanners and facial recognition softwares. It was interesting how Half Moon didn’t seem to rely on either technology or magic half as much as the other kingdoms and definitely less than Eternia, despite how close it stood to the magic source for the entire planet and despite the fact that they were called *Magicats*.

Catra opened the door to a large room, everything perfectly clean and tidied up and - sandal-scented, the fragrance freshening up the whole place. It looked and smelled like Adora expected a cabin in the woods or a mountain shelter would, except a ventilation system was on that made it more bearable for her to be near the planet’s core.

Which reminded her.

Her bag had gotten to her room before she had, thanks to Hector, and she heaved it on the neatly made canopy bed to rifle through it, looking for a lighter shirt, a tank top, some shorts. She also eyed the dinner that was served on the bedside table, meat and some rice.

“Right,” Catra was suddenly reminded as well, “I’d promised you a change of clothes. Hold on.”

“It’s fine, Catra,” Adora called, pulling out her usual nightgown - long and sheer and pretty, she supposed, though not exactly her

style. The royal tailors had insisted a princess couldn't just sleep in a tank top and shorts, even when there was no one to see her, and she'd figured they knew better.

The look on Catra's face quickly made her rethink things. "They actually make you dress like that all the time? God, just - wait here."

The door closed behind her again, and Adora was left alone. She'd told the truth - she wasn't hungry, but the long trip and what little socialization she'd had was already weighing down on her. She sat on the bed, feeling how soft it was - pleased to find it not *too* soft - and shoved some chunks of meat in her mouth, just to do something with her hands. Then some more. And some more.

When Catra came back, she found her slouched on the bed, head held up by two cushions, the plate in her lap half empty. She smirked at the sight, dropping a pile of clothes by her. "Here. I'm down the hall if you need anything - the red door, not the maroon one."

"Aren't we eating together?" Adora mumbled, a forkful of rice falling from her mouth. That wasn't the question she meant to ask, but it was close enough to it. Truthfully, Adora hadn't expected to be given her own room - and to actually have to sleep in it.

Catra was trying hard to hold back her laughter, but her eyes grew serious. "You've travelled all day, and we've got a bigger day ahead of us tomorrow. Get some rest."

"Wait, Catra-" Adora called the second Catra turned her back, only to find herself at a loss of what to say. "Goodnight."

Catra looked at her for a while - so long that Adora thought she would say something, like *I missed you* or *I'm glad you're here*. She didn't. "Goodnight, Adora."

Catra couldn’t sleep.

It had a lot to do with Adora only being a few doors away - not on another planet, not in another kingdom, but close enough that the only thing standing between them was Catra’s stubbornness.

She could have gone to her, if she wanted to. She could have spent the night with her, as Adora clearly wanted her to do. She could kiss Adora until her blood stopped singing for her.

But sometimes, she thought she needed Adora more than she loved her. Like all of her efforts to be a person would be vanified if she couldn’t reach out every once in a while to find Adora next to her. She wasn’t looking forward to finding out if that was the truth.

A knock came on the door.

She’d just wait in the dark, breath abated, for the truth to come to her. “Come in.”

Adora had never been in this room before, and she had never opened this door. And yet, Catra still knew it was her by the door’s creak. Her suspicions were confirmed - but who else would come to her room at night - by Adora’s shadow being cast on the wall, framed in a square of light.

“I can’t sleep,” was all Adora said. Catra didn’t turn on her other side to look, but she knew what was coming.

“Why?”

There was a small pause and the sound of feet scuffling as Adora tried to find her words. “I’m wearing your clothes,” she whispered, eventually, “and they smell like you.”

That. Catra wasn’t expecting *that*.

Adora wasn’t a big talker. For all that she should’ve been the one to inspire the masses and make big heroic speeches about the

power of friendship before every battle, Adora usually let her actions speak for themselves - and not-so-effectively, too. Her somehow managing to grasp the exact combination of words that would *ruin* Catra wasn't only rare - it was unprecedented.

Catra scooted forward, making room for Adora on the bed. She waited to hear the door creak closed, and footsteps drawing near. She waited to feel the bed dip under Adora's weight.

Adora snaked her arms around Catra's waist and molded her form to hers, her head buried in the nook of Catra's neck. All of Adora was flush against her, all the way to her nails, to the tip of her toes.

"It was making me crazy," Adora muttered, her lips kissing Catra's skin when they so much as moved. "Feeling you all around me, and you weren't there."

Her hand went up to tangle in Catra's hair, threading through it as she did when they were little kids. Catra had always had an aversion to hairbrushes - they mostly just wasted her time, and did nothing for the unruly mess on her head - but she'd fallen asleep to Adora brushing her fingers through her hair almost every night for the first ten years of her life. She was nowhere near falling asleep now.

"I missed this," Adora confessed, her breath now tickling Catra's ear. When it quirked up, Adora's fingers quickly worked to smooth it over, stroking the tufts of fur there too. "I missed cuddling you."

Catra should probably say something already. She couldn't just stop speaking because she was afraid of her voice dying in her throat. "Mmh. But we didn't do all that other stuff in the Horde."

Adora was silent for a while. Catra wondered if she was thinking about the night at Bow's house, too, or just the many times they'd kissed at parties, when no one was looking. Then: "Maybe we should have."

Catra frowned. She tugged at the hand that was still on her waist, silently asking for Adora's grip to loosen, and she turned in Adora's arms so that she was finally facing her, the tips of their noses close enough to touch.

"Do you think we would have?" Catra asked. "If you hadn't left the Horde?"

"I think so. Eventually." Adora nuzzled closer to her, humming her contentment - or maybe she was just tired. "You were my lifeline. I dreamt of coming home to you at night and shutting the rest of the world out."

Catra didn't like thinking about the Horde. It had arguably been the darkest, most traumatic time of her life, and she'd been told that accepting it was the first step to making peace with it. But sometimes, at least when it came to Adora, she found herself thinking that there had been good among the bad.

She didn't know what was worse; to think she'd never actually been happy in her life, and at this rate would never be, or to miss what everyone told her she had to banish out of her mind. "Even if home was just a Force Captain room?"

Because would it have been that bad, really, if things had gone just a little differently? If Adora had held on just a little longer, like Catra had been, until she became Force Captain and eventually took over the Horde? Wouldn't they have been together, then - wouldn't Adora have driven Shadow Weaver and Hordak away, sucked bruises into Catra's neck at night, wouldn't Catra have had a place to put down all of that wanting without it turning ugly and wretched?

"Yes," Adora nodded into her skin. "So long as it was all we could have."

Catra still wasn't sure that wasn't the case. "And then?"

"And then I wanted us to be safe."

But that wasn't it, Catra knew. Adora hadn't left to keep Catra safe, but despite the fact that she wouldn't be. Adora had put the safety of people she'd never met above Catra's, and Catra had been supposed to be okay with it and recognize it as the morally sound choice, even though doing the right thing had brought Adora nothing but pain, in the end.

"Do you feel safe now?" Catra asked, genuinely curious. Part of her thought safety without happiness was overrated, but then again, Adora had always been one to conflate the two.

Yet Adora stayed quiet for a while, and when she did speak, she just turned the question on Catra. "Do you?"

She probably expected Catra to say yes, so she could rejoice in the fact that she'd made the right choice, once upon a time. That Catra had been fine without her, and had eventually arrived where she was meant to be regardless. But it would be too long and too disappointing a conversation to have now. "Ask me tomorrow."

"Catra," Adora whispered one more time. Catra squeezed her eyes shut, hoping she wouldn't push it, that it could just stay the two of them for one night, without the pain that came from trying to understand each other. But she just pushed her knee between Catra's legs, wrapping her other leg up around them in a cocoon. "Don't leave before I wake up."

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

> Well thank GOD I split up this chapter, because this second half turned out to be longer than I thought. While I had this (half) chapter already plotted out, keep in mind that I only got to writing it after s5 had already aired, unlike the previous one. So there might be some influences there I hadn't accounted for.
> One day I'll write something that isn't ham-fisted and unnecessarily dramatic but TODAY'S NOT THAT DAY, BITCH. Shit's going down.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

In the morning, Catra took her to the baths.

The underground river had carved its path in the rock over thousands of years, creating the complicated cave network that would eventually become Half Moon, and while most Magicats didn’t mind the communal baths, royal clusters also had access to private baths inside the palace. The only true difference, according to Catra, was slightly better architecture.

Adora had enjoyed the modesty of the palace the night before, and wasn’t expecting much more in terms of grandeur when it came to the baths. It turned out, however, that while the place might not have been excessively large or sumptuous, the ceiling was high enough to make her dizzy. Light entered the cave from a hole farther up than she could see, making it more akin to a well, and though they weren’t too deep underground, the room was colder than anywhere else in Half Moon, far enough from both the heat of the underground geysers and the heat of the sun above.

What had really surprised her, however, was Catra suggesting it to her first thing in the morning. It wasn’t just waking up to the darkness of their - *Catra*’s - room, still tangled up together, to find

that Catra had stayed with her after all; it was that Catra, well - had never seemed to like water very much.

But she saw, now, why Catra would make an exception for this. Now that she was soaked to the neck in hot, bubbling water, she understood. Head laid back on the rock ledge, mouth gaping in wonder, Adora felt muscles relax that she didn't even know she had.

Soft laughter and water splashing not too far ahead brought her back to reality only for long enough to realize Catra had joined her, and plunge back into reverie. She was wearing a black bathing suit that wasn't too dissimilar from her normal pajamas, in terms of how much skin was covered, but she'd tied her hair up in a high ponytail, so that her curls barely touched her shoulders. There were new freckles there that Adora had never seen, and had presumably only appeared on Catra's skin in the past few months. Adora, who'd known every inch of Catra's body since they were kids, every scar and stripe and bruise and mark, had missed it.

Don't get her wrong - she'd been responsible for potentially life-ending decisions more than a couple times, and crumbled under the weight of all of them. The feeling of reality pressing in on her, falling apart thread by thread, wasn't new. The quiet resolution that burned through her, however, as her heart beat *want, want, want*, Adora had only known once before.

It was weird, how straightforward that desire was. It popped into her head, unprompted and unmediated, and immediately took up all of her brainspace. Catra was looking at her now, forehead crinkled in worry, so Adora sputtered the first coherent thought that came to mind: "Does the water have magical properties?"

Catra giggled, sinking further down into the pool. Her ankle brushed Adora's shin for the span of a breath, then settled down by her. "What kind of properties?"

Adora didn’t know it was possible for half of her to feel so soothed, when the other half was on fire. “I don’t know. Is magic involved at all?”

“Don’t think so. The magic we had was connected to the planet’s core, but then the First Ones took control of our runestone and used it to store all the power they could for themselves.”

Adora blinked, pieces suddenly fitting together that she hadn’t even considered to be related. “Wait. The Heart of Etheria was your runestone?”

“Uh, yeah. Did you think it was just another piece of First Ones tech?”

“Yes?” Duty towards her people compelled her to defend their honor, call Catra out for the spiteful way she addressed them - but common sense reminded her that Eternians had hijacked and ruined everything they couldn’t build themselves, so she stayed quiet.

With a scoff, Catra continued. “Well, The Heart was deactivated and our runestone along with it, so there’s no telling if our magic survived. Even if it did, the people who knew how to use it are long gone.”

“But what if someone was particularly sensitive to the magic? Wouldn’t they feel it anyway?”

Catra laughed again - that light, squeaky laugh of hers. She arched her chest up into it, her neck laid bare, and Adora wanted like she’d never had before. It was a kind of terrifying, generalized want that couldn’t be quenched by any normal means, and the more Adora tried to fix on it, to grasp it, to understand what its object was, the more it slipped away.

“I don’t think that’s your case, Adora. It was shapeshifting magic - allowing us to transform into felines, you know, hence the name Magicats. It changed our physical appearance, maybe heightened

some of our instincts, but - nothing beyond that. So whatever it is you're feeling right now, it's all you."

Adora was still mulling over those words when Catra's foot found hers, knocking against it to trace a line up her shin. It wasn't the gesture itself that undid her; it was the cautious way Catra avoided piercing Adora's skin with her claws, the way she looked at her, careful to register every change on Adora's face. "I hope it's good."

Adora followed the droplets of water running down Catra's collarbones, touching her upper lip. Even the locks of hair that were hanging low were getting wet. Warmth radiated off of her in waves. "It is."

The feeling was there and gone with one last gentle stroke as Catra drew back.

"You had to be born with the ability, anyway," Catra rambled on, like she expected Adora to still focus on that conversation. "It used to be a marker of royal blood. Most people in our family had it, and would usually pass it on to their children even when their partner didn't."

"Mmh." Adora had observed all of Catra's defense mechanisms up close, and come to know them very well. Lashing out was frequent; ranting was new. She let go of the rock ledge to wade closer to her.

"But even before the First Ones came, our family line was so watered down that only few people were still able to transform. It's why we started the whole cluster thing - we figured, why limit our chances to pass down the gift?" She shrugged. "It only kept the magic alive for a little while, until it was taken from us for good, but the cluster system just kind of - stuck, I guess, and it spread outside of royal circles, too."

Adora grew bolder, then, and floated right into Catra's space - close enough to wrap an arm around her waist, but not close

enough to make her feel backed into a corner. Though she'd wanted to touch Catra since first getting into the pool - since Catra had untangled her body from hers that morning - Adora had to admit that her only reason for doing that was a sudden ugly, ugly feeling that reared its head deep in her gut.

She started to ask "Are you-", but paused when she realized where she was going with it. Catra encouraged her to go on with a look, though she couldn't help but stumble through the words anyway. "Are you going to have one, too? A cluster, I mean."

Catra looked hesitant for all of two seconds, in which Adora convinced herself that she would either lash out or avoid the question entirely by spouting another tidbit of Magicat history. The smirk that slowly crossed Catra's lips, though, was enough to make her regret asking.

"Why, did you want me all to yourself?"

"Yes." Adora didn't feel like she should be the one flustered. She thought she'd made her intentions to be part of Catra's life extremely clear, and while she still didn't know in what way, and for how long, this was as good a time as any to start figuring it out. She squeezed Catra's waist, hoping it would give her courage, but then just stuttered: "I mean, I did, but - it's fine if you want to keep yourself open. Or the - relationship, I guess. I just need to know."

Catra's smile dropped - or, it didn't drop, just turned into something else. Something more pensive, maybe, and more fragile. "You have me," she murmured - her fingers drifting over Adora's back, where her scars were, and settling finally around her neck. The scars didn't hurt Adora anymore, but under Catra's hands they begged to be reopened. "You *have* me."

The ugly feeling turned itself over, its edges only just smoothed out. Catra's words only spurred it on, gave it space to grow when they should've squashed it. Adora bent down to kiss the new

freckles on her shoulder, and then tilted Catra's head up to do the same to her lips.

At first, kissing Catra had had the same effect on Adora as a glass of good wine - made her dizzy, fearless, weightless. But once Catra had unlocked the magic within her, it seemed to Adora that her kisses *grounded* her instead. Her mind didn't blissfully shut down when Catra was too close, but rather fixated on the smallest details until Adora's self-control snapped for being spread too thin.

This time, what did it was Catra sighing into her mouth, which had her black out for the space of a heartbeat before being slammed back into her body, painstakingly aware of Catra's tongue trying to trace the outline of her teeth. Adora opened her mouth wider, allowing her easier access, and pulled her closer, her thigh locked in between Catra's legs, fingers digging into Catra's skin hard enough to leave bruises.

Adora had found the cave refreshing, at first, a reprieve from the sweltering heat of the rest of the underground tunnels, but now - she had to periodically push Catra away just so she could breathe and keep her skin from melting off. She might as well be in a freaking sauna.

Catra's hands were still wandering all over her back, head burrowed in Adora's shoulder, where she kept mouthing at. Adora was stroking her hair, occasionally murmuring nonsense into it, but found her hand drawn again and again to where the straps of Catra's top were interlaced.

"Catra," she asked under her breath, only receiving a hum in response. "Do the Magicats know who I am?"

Catra raised her head to smirk at her. "I think Cyrus's reaction to She-Ra was hard to miss."

"No, like - who I am to you."

Catra looked slightly taken aback, like she hadn't considered it herself. She frowned, her eyes narrowing in on her. "What are you

to me?”

“I mean, did you tell them I was an ex best friend, or-”

“I don’t really - talk to them about you. But they have their own ideas, I’m sure.”

That told Adora absolutely nothing, which was a shame. She had to admit she was curious about how their relationship was perceived by outsiders - mostly because other people always seemed to understand more than she did. “I *do* sleep in your bed and kiss you all the time.”

“Hey, there’s a perfectly good room you could use, if you wanted.”

“And you’re royalty.”

“We don’t really consider ourselves that anymore, but sure.”

“Does that make me your mistress?”

Catra’s laughter was sudden, loud, and extremely pitchy at the end. “I don’t think that’s how it works, Adora.” She buried her face back into Adora’s neck, her laughter still vibrating against Adora’s skin. Adora strongly suspected she only did that so Adora wouldn’t see her blush, and her heart clenched tight in her chest.

She dropped a kiss into Catra’s hair, breathing her in, and joined in her laughter. It bore none of the ugly emotional weight of the previous feeling. “Lover, then.”

Adora loved the sound of it, loved the way it rolled off her tongue, though it felt - more vulnerable to say. More tender.

Catra didn’t seem to have strong feelings either way, but she did pause for longer than Adora thought a single word required. “That’s just the old, fancy word for girlfriend.”

A shiver went through Adora’s body. “Yeah.”

She tried to wrap her head around it, around Catra maybe, possibly, becoming her girlfriend. Her feelings towards her hadn't been platonic for a long time, but on the other hand, she couldn't really tell when they'd changed, either. She didn't think they had; she couldn't remember a time when she hadn't wanted to be with Catra. It was the clarity surrounding them that was new.

Again, Catra didn't respond. Adora's own reply had been breathless, and she wasn't sure Catra had even heard her, because she kept pressing kisses against Adora's neck and shoulders like her life depended on it.

That was okay. Adora didn't need an answer right away, and while she was there to talk, getting Catra to open up would require some more time. This, she thought pulling Catra more firmly against her, was a distraction she didn't mind. Her fingers slipped under Catra's straps again, tugging on them.

Someone came running in - one of Catra's siblings, though Adora couldn't remember their name. She sprung away from Catra, wanting to spare her any embarrassment, but it was Catra who held her there, staring her sibling down like this was a major breach of privacy, which, to be fair, it kinda was. Adora might still be getting used to the Magicats' communal living, but even in the Horde private bathrooms were supposed to be… private.

At least Catra's sibling had the decency to look ashamed. "Sorry! I would've knocked if I'd known she was here!"

Catra opened her mouth, clearly wanting to argue further, but Adora nuzzled her face - Catra's skin was still so hot - which seemed to calm her down, or at least keep her from making a scene. Next thing Adora knew, Catra's arms were snaking around her waist, perhaps subtly communicating to her sibling to make it quick. "What do you want, Sam?"

"Scorpia and Entrapta are here," they said, eyes flitting between Adora and Catra. "Should I keep them in the hall while they wait

for you, or do you want to, uh - finish here first and see them once they're settled in?"

Catra sighed in fake annoyance, but Adora caught the first hint of a smile. "No, it's fine. I'll meet them there in a few."

Sam was so eager to leave that, in their haste, they didn't even say goodbye, nor noticed Catra reluctantly escaping Adora's grasp and slowly rising out of the water.

Adora very much did, though. For all that the warmth had felt suffocating only a moment before, the chill of the cave seemed to hit her full force when Catra's body heat left her. Watching Catra step out of the bath and wrap herself in a towel - her perfect form dripping over the floor of the cave, her hands fixing the straps of the bathing suit that were nearly undone - only had her long for when they'd be alone again that night. After the celebrations, and the social talk, when they could be Adora and Catra again. After it all.

Catra would have liked to remember her birthday dinner as some deeply emotional night, wherein reuniting with Scorpia and Entrapta had finally made her understand the true meaning of friendship, and how much power there was in loving people and letting them love you back - so much more than in hatred and revenge. A few years into the future, she would in fact look back and realize that was the case.

For now, however, Catra was about half an hour into one of Entrapta's theories (the third one, so far) about the Heart of Etheria and how she could take apart the First Ones tech to try to safely salvage the magic inside. Everyone had made their point very clear, and very early on in the conversation, that they didn't doubt in her technological skills - it was the "safely" part they took issue with. Entrapta didn't seem to pay them any mind.

“For all intents and purposes, the Heart has been deactivated, yes,” she replied to no one, “but if there’s anything I’ve learnt in my lifelong research, it’s that magic rarely disappears into thin air - it just takes on other forms. Its traces are preserved for thousands of years even in technological artefacts which harness it as their energy source, and when I think about all the power that’s still trapped in the Heart, still looking for a way out-”

“You feel… sad?” Scorpia tried, perhaps just to show she was listening. Catra tried really hard to follow her example - she was trying to be a better friend, damn it - but Adora had kept her from nodding off more than a few times now, gently pinching her arm.

“Sad?” Entrapta marvelled at the notion. “That the First Ones were able to build technology this durable? No way! Learning their secrets would be a huge step forward towards establishing a line of communication that’s compatible with ours.”

“And... freeing the magic?”

“Oh! That too!”

“Can I, uh, do anything to help?” asked Adora, ever the selfless. “I can probably hook you up with some tech expert on Eternia.”

“You would do that?” Entrapta’s eyes sparkled in excitement. No, really. It was like wires had connected right behind her eyeballs. “We could figure out this whole interplanetary communication system thing together!”

“And the magic,” Scorpia reminded her under her breath.

“And the magic!”

“How about you, Scorpia?” Catra cut in, taking that chance to open a discussion they could all participate in. “Any news from the Scorpion Kingdom? You said earlier that you were still rebuilding.”

Scorpia looked happy to answer, gulping down some more of her soup first. It was vegetable soup, which she’d apparently become

accustomed to, despite Catra and Adora still refusing to touch anything green with a ten-foot pole. "Yeah, there's still a lot of work to do, but it's coming along pretty good. And when I think about my ancestors, and how proud they'd be of me rebuilding their kingdom - it spurs me on."

Catra couldn't help but soften at hearing that. It was hard to think of anything at all, with Adora so close to her - their knees knocking together on the same bench, Adora's breath hitting right over her ear - but sometimes, well, she found herself thinking everything would have been so much easier if she'd been able to love Scorpia back, instead. If Catra had allowed herself to be with someone as kind and caring as her, someone untainted by Catra's past, they could've been happy - or *undisturbed* at the very least, which was as close to happiness as Catra was ever going to get.

But Adora - she put the breath in Catra's lungs. Catra burnt herself out for her, and whenever she felt herself getting closer to the wick, to relief, to nothingness, there Adora would be, stoking the flames again.

Even now, her hand rested on Catra's thigh, drawing circles into the skin there when she was supposed to pay attention to Scorpia. She didn't think Adora was doing it consciously, just like Catra hadn't realized when her tail had wrapped around Adora's wrist, keeping her there. Neither of them made any move to change that.

"I'm sorry I couldn't help more," Catra said, trying to focus on the conversation again. "It's my fault - and Hordak's - if the Fright Zone was such a wreck when you got it back."

"No, wildcat, it's okay." What she liked about Scorpia was that she actually meant things like that. "We would be much worse off if Perfuma hadn't offered to help, and you did what you could before you were sent underground. There was a lot of reconstruction to do here, too."

“What do you mean, you were sent underground?” Adora turned to her, the light from the bonfire in the middle of the open mess hall flickering on her face. “Was that after I left?”

Catra shrugged. “Like I said, princess,” she grabbed her glass, still swirling with the first wine of the night after more than an hour, and finally gathered the courage to take a sip, “fancy house arrest. Glimmer just relieved me a few days ago.”

“Oh, yeah, how is she, anyway?” Scorpia cut in before Adora could start questioning why Catra hadn’t told her anything. Catra would have had no answer for her that didn’t require her to acknowledge deep-seated feelings of shame, which was by no means birthday talk, so that was probably good. “I know Perfuma was worried about her.”

Catra groaned. A glance to the side told her she had Adora’s full attention, as well; Entrapta had zoned out of the conversation and was messing with her tracker pad. “That’s sweet of her, honestly, but I don’t think there’s any bad blood between them. Glimmer will get over it, eventually.”

“Why would she have it out for Perfuma? They’re really good friends.”

“Yeah, but -” Catra struggled with words for a while before looking at Adora for help. Was Scorpia’s heart too soft to understand jealousy? “I mean, it’s hard when your ex dates someone else.”

She could see the wheels working in Scorpia’s head, trying to compute everything. Then realization dawned on her suddenly. “Wait, she thinks Bow and Perfuma are together?”

“They’re… not?”

“Oh, no. Perfuma’s his therapist. Suffice to say, he’s not dealing with the break-up well. And… other personal stuff, I guess.”

While Catra was mildly surprised, Adora’s silent reaction particularly stood out to her, since it caused her to take her hands

off Catra entirely. Knowing her, her surprise had to be mixed with concern over her friends' well-being, which was why Catra resolved: "Well, somebody should tell Sparkles that. She's not doing too well, either."

She felt Adora withdraw even more, but before she could ask about it, a familiar, grating voice moved her attention elsewhere. "Is she one of yours?"

Mira stood next to their table, holding Entrapta by one of her pigtails while the smaller girl seemingly analyzed a particularly fluffy piece of her fur. "Can you please keep a closer eye on her? I don't exactly mind her creeping up on guests I don't like, but she is scaring Vee's cluster."

Allegedly Catra's oldest sister, Vee had already been living the married life when she'd met her; as a result, she rarely hung around the palace anymore and had no patience for her younger siblings' shenanigans. Weirdly enough, her two spouses seemed much more accomodating, waving shyly at Catra from the cave entrance. Catra waved back, jaw clenched.

"It was important information I needed," Entrapta retorted. "I've been tracking the Heart of Etheria's magical signature, but first-hand witnesses would've really helped explain some of the discrepancies in my data."

"Alright, Entrapta, then I'll arrange for you to talk with one of our elders in the morning. They'll know better than Vee and Mira," Catra promised, standing up from her seat. "I'll go get some more food for us, okay? And say hello to Vee's cluster."

Mira seemed to approve of the idea and finally put Entrapta down, despite her protests. That was also when Catra foolishly lowered her defenses, because Mira turned her attention onto Adora next. "It's good to see you, Adora. Did you sleep well? I know the heat might take some getting used to."

“Oh, yeah!” Adora piped up, too suddenly for it to feel natural. “I slept just fine, thank you.”

“Really? I brought breakfast up to you this morning, and the bed hadn’t even been touched.”

“Let’s go, Mira,” Catra gritted out, grabbing her arm to drag her away from the others.

Vee’s cluster was not the most numerous by far, meaning it was also among the most tightly knit. While groups that got too large to handle eventually split into couples and triads more often than not, Catra had always admired Vee’s for the time and care put into every individual relationship, even between those not directly romantically involved. As a result, their children (two of them so far, already scurrying around the hall) were growing up with more love and support than they knew what to do with.

After being forcibly hugged by Vee and wished a happy birthday - even though her birthday would only be at midnight - Catra called her nephew and niece over. She held them tight while they pretended not to like it, and even played chase with them for a while, until one of the dads pulled them back, afraid they’d fall and hurt themselves.

That was when one of the parent clusters arrived. It was a cluster of five, built around one of the princes of Half Moon, and even with no proof that this was the cluster she belonged to, Catra had always felt a kinship to them in particular. Maybe it was the prince’s wife, with different-colored eyes just like hers, or the prince himself, who had always been so kind to her. Whatever the reason, she found herself hugging them that much tighter.

It wasn’t the first time in her life she was shown affection, especially after she was taken in by the Magicats, but - she’d always looked at that love from the outside, like she was peeking in on her own happiness instead of reaping its benefits in the moment.

Maybe she didn’t have to be jealous of the kids running around her. Maybe she could be one of them.

She tilted her head up and the prince laid a kiss on her forehead.

And maybe not all love had to turn ugly and possessive and destructive. The way the cluster system still stood strong, even after outliving its usefulness, was proof of that.

She found Double Trouble in the crowd of already seated guests, as she always did when she had a life-altering realization of some kind, because the shapeshifter seemed to smell her crises from a mile away. They’d strutted up to Adora and appeared to be complimenting her dress, but they lifted their head when they felt Catra’s eyes on them and smirked.

Maybe there was a chance for her love, too.

Adora felt the darkness pressing in at the edge of her mind, thoughts swirling around like fine wine filling her to the point of intoxication. She would choke on it soon enough if she didn’t get away from all the people, and the *laughter*. Everyone seemed to be enjoying themselves just fine, even when she hadn’t said a word in the past fifteen minutes. Even Scorpia and Entrapta were barely paying her any mind now that they’d started a heated debate over what color the number 5 was, red or blue - the answer being obviously yellow, though Adora felt too distanced from it all to even suggest it, and they didn’t seem to need her input, anyway. They weren’t the only ones at that.

So Adora gingerly got up, mentioning that she was going to get some fresh air, and left for the cave directly adjacent to the mess hall, much smaller but quieter, too. She could finally hear her own thoughts and string them into sentences. Through some distant hole in the ceiling, she could even see stars.

It was her fault, honestly - leaving for a year and expecting everything to be the same when she came back. She’d tried her

best to keep up with everyone, of course, and sent letters at least every month, but she should have known those dynamics would've been irrevocably changed no matter what she did. She had known that, when she'd made her choice, and it hadn't deterred her one bit - because her friends didn't need her anymore, but her people did. It did nothing to clear her mind.

It was something about Glimmer and Bow opening up to Catra and Perfuma, respectively, before her. About all the princesses knowing about Catra's sentence, because they'd decided it together, and Adora being kept in the dark. About Scorpia and Entrapta and all the other guests happily chatting the night away and barely acknowledging her presence in a way that actually mattered. It was never "Adora, my friend who I haven't seen in a long time". It was always "Adora, the one from another planet. Adora, who we only have to entertain until she leaves again". This kept them from delving too deep in their personal lives, if only because she wouldn't be around enough to be part of them.

And what was she left with that was hers? All her anchors were lost at sea and she was adrift in the storm, her thoughts drowning her and pulling her under and tossing her broken body on the rocks.

Someone found her in the wreckage, as she always did. "Adora?"

Catra stood behind her, her eyes catching the light of the moon. Her claws grasped the lining of her jacket, a few threads coming loose on the pierced fabric underneath. She wasn't smiling, exactly - her worry for Adora was apparent - but she looked… lighter, somehow. Softer. Adora wanted her so much it hurt.

"Are you okay?" Catra stepped closer to her, immediately cradling her face in her hands. It wasn't like her to be so open with her touch anymore - except, apparently, when she felt that Adora needed it. It brought Adora right to her breaking point. "Do you need to get out of here?"

There were hushes and whispers from the other room, which led Catra's gaze up, towards the sky. The light of the moon was projected on the wall of the cave, a narrow and needle-shaped shadow standing out among it to mark the hour. Midnight.

She'd made the right choice, was what Adora always told herself. The sensible choice. If it had come at the cost of her connections, well - it was the price she'd been born to pay, so no one else would have to. But if she could only have *something* for herself, just one thing guaranteed to survive the passage of time, she could bear everything else.

She wanted one thing to keep. She wanted one person.

"Happy birthday," she whispered, pressing her cheek into Catra's hands. "I have a gift for you."

"You do? Where is it?" The mischievous spark in Catra's eyes made Adora's insides twist. "Should we go to your room?"

"Your room," Adora shook her head gently, her voice as low as she could make it. "Your room."

Catra stared at her, hands stilling, trying to figure her out. Her breath on Adora's mouth - Adora could barely smell the wine, but it was there, not intoxicating her but filling her with clarity, instead.

Catra cupped her face more firmly and her lips met Adora's in the briefest of touches, almost coincidental yet firm and resolute. Adora tried to follow her lips, but Catra was already pulling away and wordlessly pulling her along.

The ugly feeling that had been plaguing her since that morning came back full force the second Catra closed the door behind them, but this time, she didn't push it down. She listened to what it asked of her, what it wanted. What *she* wanted.

Despite the sound she made when it happened, it was not Catra pushing her against the door to lean back in. Not yet, anyway.

“Wait, Catra,” she pleaded before her resolve could waver.

Catra got off of her immediately, though puzzlement was written all over her face. “I thought you meant-”

“I did.” It was getting harder and harder to remember why she couldn’t let Catra have her way with her, or why Adora couldn’t just let things between them run their course. She hadn’t had a plan, the first time. She hadn’t put much thought into what she was doing, or what Catra would have liked. She wanted to do that now, in Catra’s own room, so that even after Adora was inevitably gone, Catra would still remember. The thought sent a thrill down her spine. “Let me take care of you.”

Catra’s smile was soft, almost curious. She touched the few hairs that escaped Adora’s ponytail and brushed them away, blowing on them for good measure. Her warm breath hit the side of Adora’s cheek. *Just give in, Adora. It could be so easy.* “It’s my birthday, Adora. I’m pretty sure you have to do what I want.”

“I will,” Adora whispered in the space between them, watching Catra’s mouth fall open at the rebuttal. She echoed in her head, *Everything you want*, and started walking her towards the bed, laying her down gently when Catra’s knees hit the footboard.

Adora pulled back slightly to look at her, spread out on the bed, and almost got the breath knocked out of her. Catra was looking up at her like - like she also wanted to imprint this moment on the back of her mind, to take out and revisit when it was gone. She lay there, hair strewn about on the pillow, a hint of a blush on her cheeks, and whatever attention and affection Adora was planning to lavish on Catra, Catra was already giving back sevenfold.

Logically, she’d always known Catra was beautiful, and Catra never let her forget. But now, if Adora looked at her - mouth still half open in wonder, breathing softly, her chest heaving up and down - she didn’t know *how* she’d given her up before. She didn’t know how she was supposed to do it again now, when all Adora wanted was to keep her right there, in a bed that could’ve

become their own, until Eternia either fell out of the sky or came down to take her back.

There were words stuck inside Adora's throat, and she knew what they were. She just needed Catra - who was showing every sign of being impatient, but still only grabbed Adora's face to kiss the apple of her cheek - to pull them out.

Adora took a page out of Catra's book and cupped her face to kiss every one of her freckles. It was a slow and lazy ordeal, their legs intertwined, and sometimes - sometimes Catra pulled back to whimper something in her ear, or push their lips together, and Adora let her, if only for a few seconds. It was hard to tell Catra no, but she also deserved better than the sloppy make-out sessions Adora had been treating her to. She deserved an Adora who was fully in the moment and committed to taking care of her.

She deserved an Adora who wouldn't leave her, but this was the Adora she got, and she would do whatever it took to make it up to her.

"Catra," she whispered, touching Catra's chin for good measure to pull her away from the patch of skin she was mouthing over, "you know when I told you that - that it was fine for you to have a cluster, if you wanted one?"

Catra nodded, arms wrapping around Adora's back to pull them closer again. "Yeah."

Adora's fingers curled into Catra's hair, her eyes avoiding Catra's. She'd never let it out if she had to look at Catra while doing it and realize how disappointed she was by her, by how selfish Adora was being. "I lied," she confessed, but that didn't seem to be enough. She tried again: "I don't want you to be with anyone else."

She thought Catra's smile would either fall or turn into a smirk in the time she spent waiting for her reply, but it never did. If anything, it only grew larger as they took each other in, and when

it first showed signs of breaking, it was because Catra could barely contain her giddiness. “Okay.”

“Okay?” This was something Adora had struggled with her whole life. Understanding, accepting, and expressing that she didn’t just want Catra, but wanted her *for herself*, had been like shedding her skin - and Catra was just going to give it to her?

She nosed at the curve of Adora’s neck, making her shiver. No - she wasn’t shivering on her own. At first she thought Catra was purring against her, until a squeak punctuated Catra’s silent laughter. “God, Adora, you’re so stupid.”

Adora held her while she laughed some more into her shoulders, feeling worse and worse by the second. Maybe - maybe she was stupid. Didn’t mean pouring her heart out had been easy for her. Didn’t mean it didn’t deserve more than an off-handed acknowledgment.

But Catra’s mouth opened and closed several times, always getting stuck on the beginning of a sentence, and Adora realized this must be hard for her, too. Adora had needed a moment of sudden clear-headedness to suggest what it was she needed to say, but Catra was most likely trying to drag words out of her that had been locked in some hidden away corner of her mind forever, past defense mechanisms she’d relied on her entire life. All for Adora - if she decided Adora was worth it.

Eventually, Catra confessed under her breath and against Adora’s skin: “I think there’s something wrong with me.” Her claws were digging into the back of her shoulder as if clinging to a rock ledge, but both of them were too focused on each other to really notice. “With how I’m built. And I could pin this on you bringing me back wrong, but -” One of her hands slipped down Adora’s chest to rest on Catra’s own heart, as if making sure it was still there and beating regularly. “It’s always been like this. Always been you.”

Oh. “You feel wrong… for liking me?”

Catra shook her head firmly, a little chuckle accompanying her pulling back. No, that couldn't be what she meant. She was peering up at Adora with too much affection, too much care as she stroked Adora's hair down, pulling on her hair tie experimentally. Adora let her pull it off.

"You have the biggest heart of anyone I've ever met. You love everything and everyone. I thought I hated it, but maybe I just envied it. Because mine can only handle so much."

Adora's hair spread out across her shoulder, Catra gently tucking some of it back. "One thing, usually. But it wants it so bad. It screams and begs for me to get it until it feels like it's going to kill me."

Adora's mind was reeling, trying to wrap around Catra's words, what she could be getting at. But her eyes kept flicking down to her lips. She didn't think Catra had ever been this open with her, and it made her want to drink in every word, guess what it could be just by its shape before it even left her mouth. She couldn't keep from tracing them with her thumb. "What happens when you do get it?"

"I don't know," Catra murmured, seemingly entranced by Adora's finger. Her mismatched eyes flickered up to Adora's, her gaze so intense that it stopped Adora in her tracks. "I only ever wanted you."

"Promise?"

It felt like a line they shouldn't tread - they didn't make promises anymore, not when there was no guarantee they would be able to keep them. But still, Catra replied: "Promise."

Adora kissed her, then, and pushed her back on the bed. This felt different. Adora was almost *too* grounded, too centered on Catra's touch, on every sound she could draw out of her. That her hands and lips couldn't be everywhere at once felt like the world's

ultimate punishment, and it wasn't as sweet or as well-deserved as Adora had always expected it to be.

She trapped Catra's legs between her thighs, holding Catra's face in her hands as Catra let herself be kissed, and mouthed over her jaw, the curve of her neck, nipped at her shoulder when Catra needed to break away to breathe. Adora, on the other hand, was overwhelmed by the gnawing need to give Catra every single thing she wanted, just in the way she wanted, and everything else, including remembering to breathe, came after.

There was one thing, though. One thing she could - needed to - do without Catra telling her to.

She leant down over her, blonde hair falling down around them to shut them off from the rest of the world, and kissed right over her heart - over her still clothed chest. Some of the residual magic there flew up to touch Adora's lips, leaving them tingling.

"I love you," Adora whispered into Catra's shirt.

She spent the better part of the night showing her how much.

Adora woke a few hours later in total darkness. A pleasant weariness had settled in her bones, the same kind she felt after a long and hard training session, and the same which usually pulled her down and under all night. She wasn't sure, then, what had woken her up just now.

Her arm tightened around Catra, wrapped around her and snoring softly on Adora's collarbone. She was still there. When they were in the Horde together, and slept in the same bed every night, Adora had gotten used to waking up when she stopped feeling Catra's weight at her feet - usually due to a nightmare, or to Catra's night restlessness - and it had gotten her years to fully get rid of that habit. But Catra was sleeping soundly.

Blinking her sleep away, she reached for Catra's face, pulled back so she could see it better. The fluttering that had taken residence in her chest grew even louder, even quicker through her body's haze. Catra was beautiful, and she'd told her she loved her. Catra hadn't said it back, but then again, she'd been too overcome by what was happening to say anything other than Adora's name, over and over again. Adora had never loved her own name so much as when it came from Catra's mouth - never doubted for a second that Catra loved her as well, that she owned Catra's heart in ways few could understand.

It wasn't just that Adora had literally kept her heart beating when it was so awfully close to stopping; it was that the only reason she'd been able to do so was because Catra owned her, as well. Not just her heart; all of her. All of Adora wanted her, and loved her, and had claimed her. A rush of feeling caught in Adora's throat, and she couldn't help pressing a kiss to Catra's forehead as Catra sighed and relaxed even more in her sleep.

There was a weird sound coming from outside their window. She heard it now, loud and clear like a pulse. She recognized the sound of magic when she heard it, light and whimsical and like an electrical current, but this time warped in a very familiar way. Not a Shadow Weaver way, thankfully - it wasn't dark magic by any means. But she'd only felt it once before in her life, raising the hairs up on her arms, and perhaps Adora would've preferred the evil she knew to this.

Trying not to wake Catra up, she laid her back down on the mattress while she slipped out, grabbing - well. She couldn't just put on her ball gown again - it would have been a dead giveaway to what had happened between them, and besides, Catra had already offered her clothes. She grabbed a random robe that was strewn on a chair, hoped it wasn't too easily recognizable as Catra's, and walked out, closing the door quietly behind her.

It wasn't coming directly from Half Moon. Adora knew without really knowing where her feet were dragging her, because they knew the way, but she was still shocked when the sound grew

louder in the night, its pulse syncing up to Adora's own heart. She saw flashes in the near distance, a burning smell in the air. She was distantly aware of people murmuring all around her as she walked - more of them than should be up in the middle of the night, some of them fleeing.

Surprisingly enough, when the Heart came into view, Entrapta was kneeling beside it, messing with the control panel.

The houses had been rebuilt far enough away from the area that there should have been no need to worry, but the Heart had blasted out on the rock ceiling, so that brittle stone had fallen a little too close for comfort to the town square.

"I've got it!" Entrapta announced, with a lot more enthusiasm than the situation warranted. "It's under control now. We should probably do something about it blasting off in the middle of the night, though."

Until Entrapta opened her mouth, Adora had almost hoped she had been the one to tinker with it and accidentally set it off. You couldn't blame her for thinking it, honestly, and with Entrapta's track record, it wouldn't have been unexpected. Now she felt dread seeping in her skin, along with left-over smoke.

"Why?"

Entrapta looked at her, her eyes very alert. "I feel like it could be dangerous."

"No. Why did it go off? I thought the Heart had been deactivated."

"Oh, it has! I took care of it myself. But unfortunately, the magic trapped inside hasn't disappeared. It must've responded to some kind of external stimulus and overridden the First Ones technology." Entrapta ignored Adora's flabbergasted expression, a cold fist of fear tightening in her gut, and frowned down at her tablet. "It's been giving off a weird magical signature for a while now, but I was hoping it could wait until morning when I talked to the elders."

“You’ve what?”

“I told you over dinner,” Entrapta narrowed her eyes. “And you told me to wait ‘til morning.”

“You didn’t.” Adora had really tried to listen, but in all fairness, she hadn’t understood most of it. “How long has this been going on?”

“Like, three months? Yes, I remember. It was the party for Spinnerella and Netossa’s baby. It was just a weird ping of activity, nothing to fret about, but it let me know the magic was still in there. Nothing like what happened just now - the only other time I picked up on a magical signature like this was that time Catra almost died.” *When you summoned your lost power to save her. The time you convinced yourself you weren’t responsible for destroying, but only for healing, because it was easier to accept.* “No idea what made it go off again. Not to worry, though. I’ll figure it out soon enough!”

Now that the danger seemed to be gone, more and more people were leaving their houses and crowding around them.

If Adora had still been She-Ra, she would have made a grand speech, encouraging everyone to keep their heads up, go back to sleep, and let her take care of everything. Then she’d start lifting blocks, moving them around, trying to single-handedly lead the rebuilding until she almost collapsed and one of her friends had to drag her home.

She would have no friends here, soon enough, and she wasn’t She-Ra anymore. Clearly, holding on to that part of herself, trying to reawaken it when she was supposed to let it go, was how she’d put everyone she loved in danger. People were whispering, and she knew it was about her. They knew what she’d done - probably recognized Catra’s robe, too - and knew she was the reason their kingdom had almost crumbled to dust twice, if it hadn’t been for Entrapta.

She walked back to Catra's chamber in a daze, and found her awake.

"Hey," she whispered, though the whole palace was probably awake by then. Her smile was so soft and unguarded that Adora felt weak in the knees and immediately hated herself for it. "What's with the commotion outside? Did Entrapta blow something up?"

Her hair was still mussed from sleep, her voice rough, and she'd clearly been caught in the middle of putting some clothes on, so that she was wearing her pajama top and her party trousers. She looked gorgeous, and Adora hated herself some more.

"No, Entrapta didn't do anything. It was me."

Catra's ears twitched to attention.

"Everyone's okay, no one got hurt," was what Adora prefaced everything with, which, *good job, Adora, making it look like you're innocent*. "But the Heart went off again. The magic is still active inside, and it's potentially dangerous until we figure out how to stop it."

"Wait, what?" Catra said. "How is that your fault? Are we sure no one got hurt - you should've woken me up right away."

I didn't want you to see what I'd done. "I lost control." And she'd been so careful, so measured. She'd played with fire and wanted her powers back, and now the magic of the land responded to her again, because that was what She-Ra was meant to do. And magic could not be controlled. "Like I lost it at the Heart the first time. When I saved you."

"The Heart fired on its own," Catra said carefully, walking slowly towards Adora. "Shadow Weaver messed with it, remember?"

"Entrapta said the magical signature is the same now as it was then. Is her magic so strong that it causes random explosions a

year after she's been dead, or isn't it more likely that this thing just reacts to me?"

Frowning, Catra reached out to her, but Adora flinched away.

"Hey, we're going to fix this," Catra promised, more softly than Adora thought her capable of. "No one will hold it against you - it's not like you knew. And you said it yourself that no one got hurt."

"They could have. Don't act like people weren't seriously injured last time."

"And they recovered just fine!" Catra reminded her. "I was right there in the infirmary with them, and ultimately, no one was any worse the wear for it. I mean, Half Moon definitely was, but it could've used some renovation anyway. Why it took you burning it down for people to realize, I'll never understand."

"Can you please not make light of that? I literally *just* found out. We're nowhere *near* the time you can make jokes about it."

"Okay, okay, jeez," Catra mumbled, dropping back down on the bed. Adora wrapped her arms around herself to stop from following. "Adora, what's the problem? Now that we know what's wrong, we'll talk to someone who can help you keep your magic in check. Perfuma looks zen enough."

"I *can* keep it in check." It wasn't a lie. Most of the time, she barely felt it - just a busy thrum, sitting comfortably under her skin, an invisible thread connecting her to all others. "Except for when it comes to you."

Catra froze on the spot, only her tail lashing out nervously - which is why, when she tried to play it off, it wasn't too believable. "Okay. I guess I could join you for those mindfulness sessions, if that would help, and - maybe we could take it easy until then."

Adora's reply, when it came, sounded hollow to her own ears. "I would do anything for you. I mean it, Catra -"

"You did. You saved me."

"- and maybe that's the problem."

If Catra was frozen before, Adora could feel the ice coming off of her now. " *I'm* a *problem* ?"

"Not you. My - feelings for you. I don't want anyone to suffer because of what I want."

"Would you rather I had died? Because that's what would have happened, if you hadn't cared enough. Would that have been the morally upstanding choice?"

Adora bit back tears. "You're not listening to me."

"No, *you're* not listening." Adora hadn't heard Catra sound this bitter and disillusioned since their confrontation in the portal. "I would've died for you. I gave everything for you, and didn't ask for anything back - hell, I didn't even think I would have *time* to get anything in return. And now you, what - you regret it?"

"I regret that it came at the expense of so many people's pain, and that it could be even worse in the future." Adora's voice felt all strained and choked up, but she couldn't afford to stop. Letting Catra draw her own conclusions usually led to more harm than good. "You think something's wrong with you? Try again. Because there's this part of me, no matter how small, that will always want to save you first, and think about everyone else second. That wants to just stay with you, here, forever, and leave my wretched planet behind."

Now, *now* there was nothing more to be said. A grave silence fell over the room as Catra took in Adora's words, and seemed to come to the realization that all that was left for her to do was beg - which was something Catra never did.

"Then do it."

Adora stepped closer to her, hoping to provide what little comfort she could. “I’m sorry, Catra-”

“Please.” Catra crawled to her on all fours to clutch her hand, and this time, Adora let her hold it. She felt claws digging into her wrist. “Please, stay with me.”

Adora thought back to the story about the girl with long, magical hair. How she was able to bring back the one she loved without consequences, without realizing the terrible implications of holding the power of life and death in her hands.

But that was a fairytale, after all.

Chapter End Notes

I just realized I never put my Tumblr on here, so you can find me at clacing if you want to follow, talk or ask me questions!
I could probably start sharing snippets and fic playlists and stuff if anyone is interested.
As always, comments are very much appreciated!

Chapter 5

Chapter Summary

It's Adora's birthday and by God I'm getting her laid

Chapter Notes

I AM NOT DEAD. This chapter was just giving me a lot of trouble. I edited the first draft down to the bone and not only was I still terribly unsatisfied with it, but by then the writing had also gotten tired and stale. So I made a second draft, reworked it extensively, STILL wasn't satisfied, let it sit for weeks - until a few days ago I came across a plot bunny I absolutely HAD to include, which made the chapter way too long, which led me to cut the chapter in half (which incidentally solved pacing issues as well) - and here's the result.

That means this chapter and the next follow the same scheme as chapter 3 and 4 - the first half is mostly build-up, with most of the action in the second half. I hadn't planned it like that, but now I've got three 2-parters, each taking place in a different location (chapter 1 and 2 on Etheria, chapter 3 and 4 in Half Moon, chapter 5 and 6 on Eternia), which I really like the symmetry of. The last chapter will be an epilogue.

Even though not a lot happens here, fair warning that this really lives up to the M rating. It's not much more explicit than I usually write but I definitely do imply stuff!! Tons of stuff!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The Pink Cliffs weren’t what Adora had expected.

Sure, she guessed they were pretty enough. A belt of asteroids shining in bright colors, like supernovas waiting to explode,

extending as far into the bottomless, endless void as the eye could see. But what was more remarkable was the history behind them, and the mystery, most of all; Eternia had had thousands of years to explore the farthest reaches of the universe, had adapted to every new planet and kingdom's technology and used them to enrich their own. But to that day, no one had ever managed to travel past the belt without suffering serious damage, at the very least, or getting killed, if an asteroid happened to come upon your route and hit you on the way.

It was the reminder the Cliffs brought with them - the idea that even Eternians were human, that there was a limit to their knowledge and a limit to their endeavours. There was something about the vastness of the universe, the variety of possibilities for what lay beyond, that made it a perfect spot for memories that would last a lifetime, romantic getaways, even proposals - and, she supposed, scientific experimentation as well.

Entrapta could barely keep herself from jumping all over the observatory as she got the last few readings she needed to test the first interplanetary communication system - one that would be ready in no time, thanks to her diligence and to Counselor Magnor's expertise. He'd joined them today to sometimes whisper about astrophysics into Entrapta's ear, but otherwise limited himself to stern glares and a stiff mouth.

He didn't have much sympathy for Eternia's princess, but at least the feeling was mutual.

The other reason she wasn't enjoying her day hovered at the edges of her mind, not pressing enough to cause discomfort but not fleeting enough to be ignored, either. It was a different kind of emptiness than the one she'd felt for her first year of rule, away from everyone she loved and with her and Catra's relationship still frayed; this one came with the knowledge that they could've fixed things - were well on their way to - and she'd been the one to ruin it.

She didn’t regret it - fixing things with one girl wasn’t worth losing a throne that had been entrusted to her. But every time she sent a letter, she made sure Catra knew that she wished things were different. It didn’t help either of them, probably, but she wanted Catra to know Adora hadn’t just taken off and forgotten about her. She never wrote it, but *I still love you* was on her mind all the time.

Catra never replied to any of her letters, their tentative correspondence faded to nothing like it had never even begun.

Entrapta’s tracker pad pinged, and Adora focused on the matters at hand. “Great! Connection is slow but steady. I can probably make it even better by adding a few antennae, if Eternia’s jurisdiction will allow me.”

The Pink Cliffs didn’t used to be under Eternia’s jurisdiction. Not until her ancestors had annexed Umbra, the planet they were standing on, the closest one could get to the Pink Cliffs without tipping over into the void. It used to be full of magic and life, once, more than a backdrop for Christmas postcards or wedding invitations; now it was one more planet for Adora to rule over.

“Sure,” she replied blankly. “I’ll get the papers ready.”

“Then all that’s left is trying to send out a message. Adora, what’s the castle’s tracker number? Hopefully someone will get it and reply, so we can also test speed of reception-”

“I think that won’t be necessary,” Magnor’s steely voice interrupted her, taking out his own tracker pad. He peered down at it, eyes squeezed together behind his glasses to discern the shape of words. “They’re asking for us back at the palace. A foreign delegation has just arrived.”

Adora frowned. “The one from Earth? They’re a week early.”

“I don’t know, Your Highness.” He pronounced her title like he was spitting up poison. “But we’d better not keep them waiting.”

“Adora, can I ask you a question?”

Adora eyed Entrapta curiously as their ship quietly made its way back. The other girl wasn’t looking at her, seemingly too enthralled by the stars outside the window. She hadn’t so much as moved for the entirety of the trip back, and only opened her mouth to express wonder, so this had to be important. “Yes?”

“Why does that guy hate you so much?”

Adora whipped her head back to make sure Magnor wasn’t listening, heart in her throat despite the fact that she was the princess, but found him still manning the ship, too far from them to have possibly heard that.

“I wouldn’t say he *hates* me,” Adora said, in her own defense. She didn’t think she’d done anything to warrant his animosity.

“My data shows he always stands far away from you and doesn’t talk to you until he’s spoken to. If that’s not hatred, could it just be deference to a sovereign?”

“Maybe,” Adora sort of lied. “He doesn’t particularly like me, that’s true. But he respects me enough to do as I say.”

“Is that a normal relationship to have with your subjects?”

It was an honest question, which Adora had trouble giving an honest answer to. “I don’t know. This is my first try. Everyone talks of my parents and even of my brother as incredible people and incredible rulers, but they left me with no directions and I have no idea what I’m doing wrong. I think it might just be the fact that I’m not them, and - that sucks, because that’s the one thing I can’t change. So I’m just trying to do my best.” She eyed Entrapta, who was now staring back at her curiously. “Is that what it’s like for you?”

Entrapta shrugged. “No, most of my subjects are very collaborative. I built them to be.”

“Does that make it better? That it’s not a constant struggle?”

She fully expected Entrapta to confirm it for her - that her robots understood, just as Adora’s counselors understood, and it was all they could count on in a world where things like love and friendship were luxuries they could not afford.

But instead of launching herself in one of her tirades, the older woman just said: “I guess it depends on what you’re struggling with,” and went back to her stars.

The rest of the ride home was silent.

When the ship entered port, she ordered Magnor to follow her directly to the throne room, where the delegation must be waiting. No time to change or refresh, even after the long journey - they had to be professional, even though a little warning beforehand from their incoming guests would have been much appreciated. She didn’t really check how Magnor took the news, but he didn’t groan or mumble under his breath, which she supposed was good. Magnor was one of her oldest counselors, and an absolute workaholic - she liked to think she had his approval on this, at least.

Adora threw open the throne room door, braid all messed up, and stomped on her dress all the way to the head of the delegation that stood facing the throne. “Hi, I’m really sorry to keep you waiting. When we received news of your arrival we were-”

She stopped, really looked at who was standing in front of her. About a dozen people, dressed up to the point of making her feel inadequate, cat ears twitching all at the same time when they picked up her voice.

She was pretty sure there were no Magicats on Earth. She was also pretty sure this wasn’t the Earth delegation after all, since Catra stood at the head of it.

The thing about Catra was that she never did things halfway. Adora had never looked at her and felt indifference, because Catra had ways of calling everyone's attention in the way that benefited her the most. As of right now, it seemed her objective was not only to be taken seriously, as head of her delegation - possibly even an official ambassador, considering how smart Catra was - but also, to target Adora in particular and knock her out cold.

Catra had never been just pretty, or cute, or even handsome - those words weren't big enough for how she presented. *Gorgeous* or *beautiful* had sometimes popped into Adora's head, but now, after six months of only remembering her, she realized how wrong even that was.

In practice, this meant Catra was, for once, not wearing red, but an elaborate black suit lined with intricate golden designs and golden buttons over a golden, untucked, undone shirt, so that her clavicles and the very top of her chest peeked under her collar. Her hair had grown even longer, though Adora couldn't be sure, since she'd put it up in a ponytail that swayed when she tilted her head to the side, smirking.

What it also meant was that, had they not been in public, Adora would have gotten to her knees. She would have grabbed a fistful of Catra's shirt and ridden it up her torso and worshipped her with her mouth. But she couldn't do that anymore; she had forfeited that right.

"Catra," she still couldn't help but whisper, in that reverent way only Catra evoked from her. Then, much more formally, almost snarkily: "A heads up would've been nice."

"You should've expected me, honestly," retorted Catra. Her smirk was still in place, but Adora could tell when she was being playful and when she was being deprecative. This was the latter - it was clear as day that Catra didn't want to be there at all. "You didn't hold up both parts of our bargain."

“What bargain?” Magnor’s voice came from beside her, eying Adora almost murderously. Adora had forgotten he was even here, and she could understand his outrage - though she was the princess, major decisions such as political treaties should still go through council first.

Adora would’ve defended herself, if she’d known what Catra was talking about, and a terrible doubt was starting to eat at her. She didn’t think Catra would refer to their relationship as a *bargain*. She didn’t think Catra would refer to it as a relationship at all - or at least, Adora hoped that would be the case in public.

“I know Entrapta is here to set up a communication system,” Catra pointed out, eyes clearly sweeping the room for Entrapta to back her words. As it turned out, Entrapta had taken an interest in a tall, brown-skinned Magicat, whose fur she was inspecting and who was obviously too nice to tell her to back off. “But we were also promised a way to connect to the Heart.”

Relief flooded her, along with just a tinge of disappointment. She finally noticed that the people around Catra - most of them her siblings, like Mira and Vee, among others she’d never seen before - were all staring Adora down like an enemy. Adora supposed she couldn’t have asked for more than that, since she’d destroyed their home twice.

“She’s working on it,” Adora interceded on Entrapta’s behalf, immediately defensive because Catra would have known this, if she only read her letters. “I gave her access to the royal libraries and had her talk with some of our finest history experts, but the Heart is tricky. As far as we can understand, it was a once-in-a-lifetime project, and without Light Hope-”

“Well, it’s not that the magic can’t be released,” Entrapta finally cut in from the Magicat’s side, tapping away on her tracker pad to inspect some obscure parameters, “it’s that we still haven’t found a way to do it safely. You know, with absolutely no risk of collateral damage.”

“But it can be done,” was what Catra got from it.

“We knew it could be done,” Adora pointed out. “I’ve set it off twice already.”

“Well, then figure out how you did it, and you can do it a third and final time. What’s the issue?”

“What’s the issue?" Adora echoed back, astonished. “I don’t want anyone else to get hurt while I try to get the magic back for you.”

“But you didn’t know what you were doing back then. If you knew, you could trigger a more controlled reaction. We could evacuate Half Moon beforehand.”

It was a terrible idea, and Adora knew better than to tempt fate like that once again - but Catra would never accept that answer, not while she was hurt. Catra would take what she wanted and go out of her way to create as much collateral damage for Adora as possible.

“I don’t appreciate you walking in unannounced and telling me what to do.”

It was only a partial lie - Adora craved the comfort of guidance, especially if it came from Catra. Catra could so much as hold her arms out right now, and Adora would sink into her and suck up every bit of warmth and reassurance she had to offer.

But guidance wasn’t what Catra was here for.

“You wouldn’t want Eternia to be under threat of war, would you?”

Silence fell over the room as everyone scrambled to take that in; the Magicats themselves were surprised by Catra’s taunt, which had to mean she hadn’t discussed that possibility with them first. It made her less likely to follow through.

Needless to say, Adora wasn’t impressed. “Seriously?”

"It's been six months. I'd expected you to have found a solution by now, and you have. You just refuse to act on it."

"Well, it doesn't have to come to *war*," Adora scoffed, a response much less dignified than a potential declaration of war would have warranted - but this was Catra, and war with her was something Adora knew how to handle. "You'd just be sending your people to die, which is exactly what I'm trying to avoid. We have magic on our side, at least."

Unfortunately, Catra also knew Adora. She knew her flaws better than anyone else, and she'd learned a very long time ago to turn them to her advantage.

"Would your people really fight for you, Adora? When they know *you*'re the reason they're fighting? Or would they throw you to the wolves?"

Even in normal circumstances, Adora knew what the answer would be. Historically, Eternia had always been really good at creating conflict, and just as good at washing their hands out of paying the consequences.

But having to pay because their princess misspoke, during a meeting that her council hadn't even been invited to attend - that had to be the greatest affront of all.

Of course, it wasn't Adora's fault that Half Moon had just shown up, but she doubted the rest of Eternia would care.

Magnor grabbed Adora by the wrist with a bruising force that almost got him exiled on the spot. "Your Highness, I insist you let me call upon the rest of the council. They should be here for this."

In the end, his obliviousness was his saving grace. Anyone who didn't know Catra would undoubtedly think her a loose cannon right now, and she couldn't fault him for his fear. Still, it was Catra she addressed with her next words.

"It won't come to that," Adora assured her, simply evading the possibility instead of outright refuting it, "if we agree to work together towards a common solution."

Catra sneered - she always sneered now - in response. "We sure can accomplish more *that* way, don't you agree?"

"Absolutely. As long as it doesn't interfere with any of your *duties*."

"In that case, you can expect us to take our leave gracefully when the time comes."

"Okay," Adora conceded the point, too tired to engage in a battle of wits. Catra seemed to notice that, but instead of getting smug about it as Adora had come to expect from whenever Catra won their arguments, her face dropped a little. "Then I welcome you to Castle Grayskull. We weren't ready for you, but there should be plenty of empty rooms in the left wing. I'll have someone escort you there."

Catra raised an eyebrow. "And then?"

"And then you can get settled in for the night while I arrange for your stay." It wasn't everyday you had to make sure a dozen more people than usual got enough food, or enough servants to go around. It shouldn't have been too much of a problem; Adora just wished she didn't have to do this at the end of a long day because of Catra's vengeful streak. "We'll reconvene in the morning and talk this through."

"Your Highness is too kind," she mocked.

"I am. Now please, consider yourselves dismissed. I have matters to attend to."

Everyone bowed on their way out. Not Catra, though. Catra didn't spare another second looking at Adora before turning around and walking out, hands held behind her back and head held high.

Adora waited until she was completely out of view, just in case she looked back. She never did.

Adora had pictured Catra showing up out of nowhere and slipping into her bed for months to put herself to sleep. Now that she was actually here, on Eternia, the thought of her only kept Adora awake - especially since Catra seemed to have no intention of joining her in her room. Adora had been the one to visit her in Half Moon, because propriety demanded that the princess stay in her room, and that others come to her; needless to say that propriety was the farthest thing from her mind now.

She thought it would count for something, showing Catra that she wasn't ashamed of her, or afraid of anyone seeing them. That was why Catra was mad, right? Because of Adora never making her a priority.

And sure, it's not like Adora could marry her - she pictured how telling Counselor Rodin about it would go, seeing as they'd been trying to find a good political match for her forever; or worse, Selene, the royal dressmaker who'd never convince Catra to wear a dress, and *why was she thinking about this now* - but she could prove she was sorry if only Catra let her, and that she'd only left because of the specific circumstances.

Circumstances that seemed to come up a lot in Adora's life.

She didn't realize where her feet were taking her until she stood directly in front of Catra's chamber, and found two Magicat guards blocking the entrance.

"Hi," she frowned. "Can I talk to her?"

They weren't Catra's siblings, or at least not any that Adora had been introduced to. They stared her down like they really wanted to ask if she was lost. "She doesn't want to be disturbed."

"I'm her best friend," she retorted.

“We know what Scorpia looks like,” laughed the other one, sending her straight into a crisis. “You’ll talk to her in the morning.”

And well, Adora tried to be kind, most of the time, and didn’t like pulling rank unless it was absolutely necessary - like with people disrespecting her authority. She liked to think this was one of those cases.

“I’m the princess,” Adora insisted. “You’re my guests - unannounced, at that. I’d like to see her now.”

They stared at her, and then at each other, for at least five minutes, silently questioning what they should do, and for a second there, Adora thought they wouldn’t budge. Then, just as Adora was starting to wonder if reading each other’s minds was just one more thing Magicats were able to do, they knocked gently on the door, alerting Catra that someone was there to see her.

They didn’t say who it was, but Catra had to have known that no one but Adora would come looking for her at 1 AM, because the door opened and she was let in without much of a fuss.

She found Catra sitting on the bed, arms wrapped tightly around her legs. Adora approached slowly, still unsure of what she was going to do, but giving Catra plenty of time to tell her to step back. She never did.

“You’re here,” Adora whispered, and it was like all the breath in her lungs had left with two simple words.

Catra refused to meet her eyes. “I’m here.”

Eternia had to be a lot colder than Half Moon, because Catra wasn’t in the usual tank top and shorts she wore to bed, but in a black shirt and flannels. It definitely wasn’t the suit she was sporting in the throne room, the one that almost wrought Adora’s end - nor anything that gave Adora easy access to Catra’s skin, as she’d selfishly, secretly hoped. It was just Catra, at her most open

and vulnerable, and that vision smoothed out the edges of her desire, squashed the bud of urgency blooming in her chest - softened the touch of her hands when, overtaken by a simple rush of affection, she leapt on the bed, crawling into Catra's lap, and drew Catra's face to hers.

Perhaps what was even stranger to her was that she felt Catra kissing back. Catra who had to hate her, after everything Adora had done - Catra who'd stopped replying to her letters, who'd showed up at her castle looking like a goddess to taunt her with what she'd lost, who'd refused, for all intents and purposes, to have anything to do with Adora anymore.

And yet Catra was kissing her, hungrily and open-mouthed, trying to stoke the delicious flames Adora had just stamped on in some cruel twist of fate.

Adora tried to guide her back into something slower, something careful - just tasting and remembering, drinking in Catra's soft gasps. She wanted one of those kisses married couples would sometimes share, wishing each other a good night with the certainty they'd see each other in the morning, while Catra was trying to grow an entire tree out of Adora's lungs and choke her to death.

Catra eventually pulled back harshly, and Adora felt the tear like it was happening to her own tissues, in her own heart.

"I missed you," Adora whispered, regardless - as an aside, or as an excuse.

"Don't kiss me like that."

Adora was still so close to her their breaths mingled together. "Like what?"

"Like you love me."

"I *do* love you."

Adora's other hand moved to rest on Catra's waist, and she had no idea where they'd go from there - but Adora imagined laying Catra back on the pillows, leaning over her, peppering her face with kisses for however long Catra let her. She'd whisper *sorry* between every other breath, if Catra took her back. Except -

"That doesn't matter though, does it?"

Adora's hand stopped in mid-air. She tried to gauge Catra's reaction, but her voice had been firm - perentory. No cracks that she could hear.

"Catra, I had to put the good of everyone else above my own."

"Oh, please. You didn't even stay long enough to clean up your mess, and you've withheld a potential solution from us for months. If you're going to kiss me now, at least cut the bullshit."

Adora frowned. "You want me to… kiss you like I *don't* mean it?"

"We did it before."

But they *didn't*, was the thing. Despite her alleged innocence - something Catra had challenged many, many times - Adora knew about drunken hook-ups. Though she couldn't understand them, she knew all about people who only kissed at parties, or with a substantial amount of alcohol in their veins, and then went merrily on with their lives. If she didn't understand any of it, it was because that hadn't been her experience.

"But Catra - I've never *not* meant it."

"For God's sake," Catra groaned, clearly and unfortunately unimpressed by Adora's continuous declarations of love, "can you just shut up? Can you do that for me, at least?"

Part of Adora swore she wouldn't let Catra sully what they'd been through and redefine what they'd had. It didn't matter how hurt Catra was - she had Adora in front of her now, trying to right her wrongs, and she was still turning her down.

But some other part rejoiced. Grappling in the dark, trying to figure out how she could make things turn out for the best, had never really worked for her. People telling her what they needed - what she could do for them - was the closest thing she still had to a sense of purpose.

And Catra, who'd brought She-Ra back for her, who'd made friends with Adora's demons as well as her own - Catra gave her purpose. She'd made Adora reliant on her, reminded her that it was how it would always be, and Adora would have her in whatever way Catra let her.

So she did as she was told. It was always what she was best at.

Catra had only wanted one thing in her life. She'd wondered what would happen to her once she finally got it - if she was going to be appeased, or if she'd empty out just as quickly as she was filled up, like she were a paper cup with holes carved into the sides - and for the longest time, she'd dreaded finding out to the point of dreading any happiness that would come.

She remembered Double Trouble taunting her about it and how frustrated she'd been with her perfectly good life, all because Adora wasn't part of it. How she'd walked a tightrope with her, taking just enough of what she needed but threatening to fall off the deep end at every touch.

Imagine her surprise when she *hadn't* been the one to mess everything up. She'd taken all the right steps - welcomed Adora back into her life, opened herself up to her, started working on herself - and all of that had been drained out of her. No anger, or sadness, or excitement had touched her until she'd seen Adora again in the throne room, and her first, genuine emotion in months had been a deep, black hatred that teetered on the edge of something else entirely.

She'd thought bringing her people along would make her feel safer. Yet hearing Adora go back on her promises again, talk about how she wouldn't sacrifice any more people when she'd easily sacrificed Catra -

Maybe letting Adora reach out to her so soon was a bad idea. Catra got up and tried to go for the door, meaning to throw Adora out - but Adora's fingers were already on her wrist, keeping her in place.

"I'm sorry," Adora murmured under her breath. She was draped in darkness, but Catra could tell her hair was still up, and that she was wearing one of those frilly, lacy nightgowns she'd already found in Adora's luggage in Half Moon. For some reason, it only made her angrier.

But then she had to add: "It's not up to me to discount any options. I just want to make sure you make an informed decision, and - to me, that will always be the one with fewer casualties. But if you hear the other options and think this is still worth a try - then I'll do it, okay?" A brush of her thumb over Catra's skin - light, tracing her veins. "I'll do whatever you want."

Could Adora feel her pulse like that? Catra felt it pound in her ears like a drumbeat.

"Please. Just stay."

The word always acted as a magic spell on Adora's lips, already working to untense Catra's shoulders and unburden her muscles, and a deterrent on Catra's. It had taken her too long to realize that staying meant two different things to them, and longer even to admit that she'd never be able to leave when Adora asked her not to.

Catra respected herself too much to go back on her progress, but she hadn't just taken up this mission - she'd been *entrusted* with it. Right now, that meant finding a way to deal with Adora's presence, if only because her people were at stake.

This time, when Adora kissed her, Catra didn't try to stop her.

She swayed in turn with Adora like she followed her lead on everything else - letting Adora happen to her like an avalanche, cascading down the side of a mountain. There was no point reflecting on it - you didn't stop to think about how much avalanches sucked, or how much you wished they would stop, as they were dragging you down. You just let yourself be taken and hoped you survived it.

Adora's hands ran down Catra's body like they had all the time in the world. Like she was in no rush, like she wasn't whimpering against Adora's lips at the feeling of Adora pressed up against her. Adora dug her fingers into Catra's forearm and Catra gasped into Adora's mouth, thinking finally, *finally* - only for Adora to gently move her back, gently lay her down on the bed, *gently* start kissing the rest of Catra's face.

She tried grabbing Adora's chin, tried deepening her kisses, tried raking her nails down Adora's biceps - but Adora always slowed her down, despite her breathing also getting frantic in Catra's ears.

It was driving Catra crazy.

But it was also interesting. Adora had never been too soft with her - their first kiss like a faucet had been opened, all that repressed emotion flowing in at once and converging onto Catra - and though their last time had been slower, Catra could tell Adora had been trying to make it good for Catra, nonetheless. But there was no real intent to this slowness, unless the intent was to frustrate Catra even more - and not in a good way. It felt indecisive - almost clumsy.

Adora's hand started trembling on her way to Catra's belt, and it dawned on her.

"Adora."

"Yes?"

“Are you scared?”

Catra thanked her night vision for being able to see Adora’s blush. “A little.”

“That you won’t be good?”

“It’s been *months.* ”

There was a heat pulsing between her legs, a tension coiling in her gut just because of Adora touching her. Catra managed to ignore it for a while longer, just so she could gasp out a breathless chuckle against Adora’s lips. “Baby, that’s not just something you forget.”

She expected Adora to freeze entirely, then - she was touching Catra so slowly, it wasn’t going to take a lot. Instead, she shook like all her muscles had decided to give up at once, and collapsed on Catra’s chest, her head nuzzling the curve of Catra’s neck.

The heat sizzled down to a more soothing, enveloping warmth. It was still sweltering - especially where Adora was now pressing kisses, her teeth grazing Catra’s skin just lightly - but it gave Catra room to think. It gave her clarity enough to be willing to wait.

“But if you want,” Catra murmured into her hair, “I can take it from here.”

Morning found them curled up on opposite sides of the bed, like the previous night had never happened - with the exception of Catra’s tail, wrapped around Adora’s leg. That was what had woken Adora up, she thought; the way it flicked and moved from her ankle to her thigh and back again, inching further and further up.

Adora couldn’t help but turn her head back to look. Catra was still on her side, facing the wall, and by the rhythm of her breaths she was either asleep or pretending really hard to be. Catra’s tail was

known to move in her sleep, sometimes - especially when she was in the middle of a dream - and countless times Adora had woken up to Catra's tail under her nose making her sneeze, or tickling her stomach.

This time, though, it made her uncomfortable in a different way. One that heightened the insatisfaction still pooling in her gut, despite how good Catra had made her feel. It was no secret to Catra that Adora could get needy, after - that she'd want to hold Catra close while her heartbeat slowed down, cover her with kisses to make her appreciation clear at a time when words wouldn't work. This cooldown period usually served as a lead-in, or sometimes an outright substitute, to reciprocation, because Adora always took her greatest pleasure in taking care of Catra, no matter the context.

But Catra hadn't wanted Adora to touch her. Adora had taken everything Catra would give, and after a couple short reassurances Catra had just tucked her into bed, the lines of her back harsh as she curled in on herself and away from Adora.

She wondered if Catra regretted what they'd done. If she would pull away again, and not just in public.

She could've lain there for a long while, torturing herself with questions and slowly unraveling the frustrations at the heart of her - but the sun was already up. A glance at the clock told her they weren't late for their morning meeting, not yet - but it would be much harder for her to slip out of Catra's room now.

If they were doing this again - and it was a big "if" - they were going to have to move to Adora's room. Catra was definitely better than her at sneaking out, and there would be no need for guards to stand outside Adora's room when protective spells existed that were far less annoying.

And then there was her private bathroom - oh, Catra would have loved it. It wasn't as good as the baths in Half Moon, but it was richly decorated and had plenty of space and natural sunlight and

- okay, maybe Catra would have hated it. But hey, a shower was a shower. Which reminded her -

"Catra," she called, and Catra's tail froze immediately. Not asleep, then. "I need to get going."

Catra huffed into the sheets, ruffling them. When she spoke, her voice was groggy. "What time is it?"

"Almost nine," Adora said. That caught Catra's attention - one ear flicked up. "We overslept. The meeting's in an hour."

Catra groaned, burying her face in the pillow and bringing one side of it over her head, as if to shut out all the light and the noise. "Get back here, you idiot. People are going to see you."

Adora, thinking she was proving her fearlessness, her lack of shame at showing everyone her relationship with Catra - thinking it was what Catra wanted, asked: "What's wrong with that?"

"With being seen leaving the room of a foreign ambassador who threatened war during negotiations? Lots of things."

She wasn't *wrong*.

"You can shower in my room. We'll leave when everyone's already in the reunion hall."

Adora kept one eye on the clock, her mind already calculating how long she would need to keep either of them from being late. Catra usually took longer than her to get ready. "Fine. I'll go first and make it quick, so you can take all the time you want."

"What's the rush? I have a bathtub *and* a shower." Oh. Adora knew some of the guest bathrooms were doubly furnished, but she hadn't thought one of them was Catra's. She must have chosen the master bedroom for herself, which - well, she'd never liked luxury, but she sure liked living large. "Just pick one, and I'll join you in a minute."

The way she spoke, face still buried into the pillow, didn't leave room for questions or interpretations. She just seemed to find no issue in suggesting that she and Adora bathe together - or, well, in front of each other - and honestly, there shouldn't have been. Catra and Adora had been cramped in the same shower after Horde training for all of their teenage years, and never once had it felt awkward. But now - she imagined Catra's eyes on her, drinking her in, and felt herself burn up already. Catra just wiggled a bit and settled deeper into the covers, unaware of how much it made Adora want to make her writhe - or perhaps knowing it exactly.

But she wasn't following that train of thought.

And so, Adora opened the door to Catra's bathroom.

It was definitely a master bedroom that she'd chosen - one fit for two, maybe three people - because the servants had placed two fresh sets of towels on the counter. Unfortunately, there was still only one toothbrush on the sink - Catra's, flaming red like everything she owned - and it wasn't like Adora could use that, but she also couldn't skip brushing her teeth. There was no telling what Catra had in store for her. Maybe they really would've just showered, and Adora would have had to forget about the leftover tension from the night before - or maybe Catra would have tried to kiss her again.

What if Catra emerged out of the bath, like the goddess that she was, and pushed Adora against the shower wall, only to be repelled by her morning breath? What if Catra then turned back towards the bathtub and lowered herself into the water like one of those ancient monsters Adora read about in her mother's books, and she never wanted to kiss Adora again?

Adora couldn't take that chance. She squeezed some of Catra's toothpaste out on her index finger and brushed her teeth with that, and while it was certainly better than nothing, the strawberry taste that filled her mouth lingered even after washing it off.

She quickly became aware of the next problem. Why was she taking it for granted that she'd take the shower, and Catra would take the bathtub? Sure, Adora tended to gravitate towards quick, efficient, cold showers, and Catra towards larger spaces than a shower cubicle, both out of habit and for her own comfort; but the thought of being naked in front of Catra without even the cover of water froze her on the spot.

Even though they'd watched each other casually a hundred times, even though Adora *wanted* Catra to watch her, she couldn't pull herself together enough to take off her own clothes. If she was this nervous, this distracted while in the shower just because Catra was in the same room, she'd probably slip on the floor and fall on her head and die. Which would solve a lot of her problems, sure, but create just as many for those left behind.

Her panic reached its peak when she heard the door come loose again and Catra walk in, which forced her to make her decision already. Loudly, Adora announced: "Dibs on the bathtub," and hoped it didn't sound too high-pitched for Catra.

If Catra noticed anything was wrong, she made no remark. "Sure. I'll start the water for you, then."

"It's okay," Adora said, but Catra brushed her off, kneeling by the bathtub to open the faucet and leaving Adora to deal with the fact that she was still dressed, and that she'd have to lose her clothes in front of Catra now.

Catra tested the water, seemingly figuring that it was temperature enough for Adora, and stood up, sparing her one single glance before walking to the sink. "I won't look, you know," she threw behind her back.

Adora could've pointed out that there was a mirror right in front of her, that Catra could've looked any time she wanted, but Catra's reflection really was focused dutifully down, too busy washing her hands and her face in the basin.

While Adora waited for the water to fill the tub - a large, circular bathtub, sculpted in stone and in direct view of the shower panes - she observed the oils and perfumes lined up on the edge of the bathtub, picking them up to figure out each one's magical properties - Strength, Relaxation, Healing. She poured them all in the quickly bubbling water, along with just a drop of Allure. Actual love spells were still strictly forbidden on Eternia, and oils labeled this way usually only promoted clear skin and a flowery scent - but one could always hope.

Eventually, when the water was warm enough, she quickly took off her dress, her bra and her underwear, leaving everything in a pile by the foot of the tub. She kept her eyes on Catra the whole time, just to make sure Catra didn't look back. She never did - not even the flash of an eye. Which was fine with Adora! She was glad Catra could respect her boundaries, and that having sex the previous night hadn't made her feel like she was entitled to Adora's body or anything. That would've been so unhealthy, although probably very desirable in the right context. Which definitely wasn't this one.

As soon as she heard the splash that marked Adora finally getting in the water, Catra grabbed a couple products from the sink, brought them with her as she made her way to the shower, placing them in a nice little nook - then promptly lost all of her clothes in front of it.

Adora could have positioned herself the other way, so she wouldn't have to face Catra. But Adora did not even think of tearing her eyes away when it happened. Catra had been so careful with her, perceiving her nerves, but Catra didn't seem to be uncomfortable - and so Adora raked her eyes over her, trying to imprint the details to memory.

She knew that body. She knew everything about it - everything about her. She knew the backs of Catra's thighs and how her knees shook when Adora took her, knew how her back arched under Adora's kisses and how her hair felt all bunched up in Adora's hands. She'd been too afraid the night before, wanted it

too much - wanted it to be perfect at the same time, those desires too incompatible. She didn't care about *perfect* now - she wanted Catra under her, and no amount of rationalizing would make that go away.

She leaned back and heard Catra's voice in her ear again, a memento of the previous night - pictured her kneeling behind her, an arm slung around her neck, whispering, *Did no one take care of you in the past six months?*

It was true in the way Catra had meant it, but also in the more general sense. Adora had consistently refused any offers for help that came her way - from Bow and Glimmer, who Adora had shamelessly lied to about being fine; from her advisors, and Magnor most of all, and even from Entrapta. She'd taken on all of her people's pain, and Catra's people's, too, and refused to weigh anyone else with burdens that were meant for her. But when she had allowed herself some reprieve, it had been with Catra, and that kind of transgression had been so unforgivable that Adora had spent the past six months punishing herself for it.

But *this* had to be the most atrocious part. When Catra had suggested preparing for the day together, she'd pictured something completely different. Catra wasn't even looking at Adora, but she was putting herself on display for her. She showered carelessly, lazily, not giving much thought to what the water hit because it would have driven Adora crazy regardless - but every now and then there was a slight turn of the shoulder, a shift of the chin, as if she'd been about to turn back but changed her mind mid-movement, that seemed to ask *Are you watching?*

Adora was, and the message was clear: she would have to do something about it herself.

"Catra," she called, but her mouth was so dry she was afraid Catra wouldn't hear. The words echoed in the large bathroom anyway, Catra's ears twitching at the sound. "Come here."

Catra froze under the jet, her shoulders rising with a huff. When she finally looked back at Adora, there was a glint in her eye - it reminded Adora of tigers hunting in the wild. “If you want something, Adora,” she said mellowly, more than the situation at hand required, “you need to learn to get it for yourself.”

It didn’t sound like a refusal, but Adora tried to pick apart her words either way, stopping to check if there were any signs of protest on her face. Catra let her look, a smirk set quietly in place, but turned back again.

Adora slowly rose out of the bathtub, doing nothing to stop the sound of water sloshing all over the floor. Let Catra hear. Let Catra tell her to turn back, or let her anticipate all that Adora was going to do to her.

Adora knew exactly what she wanted. By God, she was going to get it.

The steam of the shower flew into her face, enveloped her body as she got in. There was room enough for both her and Catra to stand without touching, but Adora wanted to be where Catra was. Wanted her warmth under her hands - her scent in her nostrils. Wanted to feel the expanse of her body, soft and pliant and burning.

She announced herself with a hand snaking around Catra’s waist, pulling her closer to her chest until their hips fit together. Adora enjoyed Catra’s full-body shiver more than she should have, and eventually had to fight back a shiver of her own when Catra fell back against her, head propped up on Adora’s shoulder - her arm around Adora’s neck.

Adora’s other hand began exploring the hard lines of Catra’s back, feeling how the muscles tensed wherever Adora touched. Fog-eyed, she pressed kisses down her spine, wanting to work out the knots there - for Catra to feel safe and relaxed, even when she had every reason to hate and mistrust Adora instead.

God, she hoped Catra did not hate her. She could bear the entire world hating her if Catra at least continued to love her - even as covertly as when they were on opposite sides of a war, even now that they could be on the brink of another. She prayed for her body to have dredged up every last drop of Allure as she guided Catra out of the spray and against the shower wall to kiss her better.

Catra's lips opened immediately under hers, Adora's tongue barely having to prod. Though Catra always unraveled so slowly, though Adora always had to goad her and exhaust her into truly letting go - the sound she released was heavenly, and it only spurred Adora on until they both stood under the dripping waterspout, wet and shivering and breathless.

The meeting, Adora was going to say, except Catra messily kissed her mouth shut while she tried to close the water.

Adora shut her eyes tight, moans and gasps echoing in her ears, until white hot shame rippled through her.

Chapter End Notes

> Just to be clear here: the plot bunny I was talking about is NOT Allure turning out to be an actual love potion, or anything like that lol I would never do that.
>
> The shower and bathtub scene was something I've wanted to write for a long time. When I was apartment hunting back in September I saw this house (that I DESPERATELY wanted, but that I wasn't picked for) that had a bathroom with a shower and a bathtub facing each other, and all I could think of was that it was a concept you could really have fun with, and here we are.
>
> I can't express how important comments are to me. I would never abandon this story, but once or twice during my writing slump what brought me back was the thought of other

people caring about it, too, and wanting to see how it ended. So if you've read this far, please, tell me what you thought!

Next chapter is already halfway done (and I'm actually satisfied with it so far), so it shouldn't take me too long to get it up. Hopefully by the end of the month!

Chapter 6

Chapter Notes

> *walks in three months late with Starbucks* I really thought I could post another chapter by the end of January, uh.
> In my defense, there was literally only one scene missing, and that's the scene I ended up rewriting about seven times over the last few months, so understand me if this isn't the best thing I've ever written, but I just can't look at it anymore lmao

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The real shame, for Adora, wasn't being paraded in front of Catra's guards, dressed in a tunic of Catra's that barely hid the hickey on Adora's collarbone, knowing they'd listened to them the whole night and subsequent morning.

It was running in the reunion hall for their meeting, two hours later than they were supposed to, and finding her entire council sat in front of the Magicat delegation while Entrapta eagerly discussed one of her theories.

"- not supposed to be too risky, but if one wanted to make sure, a conduit would solve most of our -"

She must've zeroed in on them, because she cut herself off, which alerted everyone else to other presences in the room. As a result, at least twenty pairs of eyes followed her line of sight to the door and looked them up and down - Catra, looking mildly disheveled but dashing as always, and Adora, an absolute mess who might as well have WE'RE HAVING SEX printed on her gigantic forehead.

"What's going on?" Adora asked, as nonchalantly as possible, breaking the stunned silence.

"Adora!" Entrapta chirped, just as nonchalantly. "Thought I would start without you, hope you don't mind -"

“Not you, Entrapta,” Adora said affably, turning to her council. “You. What are *you* doing here?”

“Also my fault!” Entrapta replied.

Rodin’s disapproval was tangible as they flipped their plaited hair back over their shoulder. “Your Highness, Entrapta saw you weren’t coming and thought she’d ask the council about your whereabouts. We obviously had no idea where you could be - nor that there was any meeting to attend - but it was our sworn duty to step in for you, anyway.”

Adora’s eyes found Magnor’s already staring at her. “This was supposed to be a private meeting.”

“These are matters that concern all of Eternia,” Magnor retorted, “and you clearly couldn’t be expected to take care of them, so no, it wasn’t.”

“Well, I’m here now, and I know how to handle this. Thank you, but you don’t need to be here anymore.”

Magnor looked at Rodin. Rodin looked at Zora. Zora looked at Marion, and so on.

“Actually, Adora,” Catra intervened, placatingly, “you should let them stay. My whole delegation’s here - it’s only fair your council is as well.”

Adora didn’t like the idea, but she hated the idea of causing a scene now even more, and besides, maybe Catra had a point. “You’ve already been informed of everything that’s going on?”

“I told them, yes,” Vee, the oldest of Catra’s sisters, said. The lines of her face were unreadable, at least to Adora. “Figured you were off doing something important.”

Catra didn’t grace her with an answer, but she quickly cleared her throat when Mira started chuckling under her breath, and moved to take her seat. “You were talking about a conduit?”

“So, releasing the magic as it is would be too dangerous,” Entrapta recapped, nodding to Catra and Adora in turn, “as the Heart is unpredictable. No amount of control over the runestone itself would guarantee the discharge to be safe. However, if someone were to take on the magic and then release it, controlling that power would be up to them.”

“Let me guess,” Catra waved the rest of the discussion away, sitting astray against the chair’s back. “The only one who could do it is Adora.”

“Actually, Adora, I’m not even sure *you* could do it. This is still entirely hypothetical, and I have no idea of the effect it would have on you. I just assumed, you know - because the power calls to you. Maybe it just wants to connect.”

“Or maybe it’s the opposite, and Adora keeps setting it off because it wants to escape her reach.”

Entrapta scratched her head, considering. “Yes, I guess that’s also an option.”

“Great. So how do we know?”

“We don’t!” Entrapta concluded merrily. “I could run a few tests on Adora, but there’s really no telling how the magic imprisoned in the Heart will react to her. I know Adora’s powers are meant to complement those of the other princesses, but I can’t assume the Heart’s magic hasn’t become more aggressive overtime. The only way we can know is trial by fire.”

Catra scoffed. “Well, we’re not doing that.”

Several heads turned to Catra. It wasn’t Mira or Vee who spoke next, but the Magicat whose fur Entrapta had been overly fond of - Prince Javi, if Adora wasn’t mistaken. Catra wouldn’t have listened to her sisters, but Javi - there was something about him and how he touched Catra’s shoulder that seemed to calm Catra down. Even now, she softened before he even said a word. “Darling, none of us want any harm to come to Adora, but our

first option would have endangered many more lives. Maybe we should put them both aside until we know they're truly safe."

That was interesting. Not only how much Catra valued the prince's advice, but how despite what Catra made it sound like, not everyone in her ranks was as impatient as her to get things done whatever the cost.

"There would be no danger," Catra said, "if we evacuated Half Moon beforehand. That's different than not knowing what's going to happen to Adora at all."

"Aww," Adora couldn't help but coo, "I knew you liked me."

It was good the Heart's power was still under lock, because Catra looked like she was ready to tap into it and burn Adora to a crisp. "Look, I really don't want your people to take it out on us if you die."

"Joke's on you. My people will reward you for accomplishing what they never could and peace will finally reign over the universe."

Catra released a scoff, which Adora recognized as a way to choke back sudden, undignified laughter. As if taunting her, a lock of Catra's hair fell over her blue eye, and it was torture for Adora not to reach out. "Maybe you should take one for the team, then."

"That's what I've been *telling* you."

Her counselors looked like they were plotting the quickest, easiest way to joust Adora off the throne.

But Adora paid them no notice. She could stop hoping for Catra's love; she would give it all up if she and Catra could keep laughing together just like this, uncaring of others and of the years between them.

There was a longing starting from somewhere deep within her. It drew her gaze to Catra's and kept it there, remembering a time where she didn't have to look away.

But for all that Catra claimed to hate her, Adora now knew Catra at least didn't want her to *die* - which wasn't much, but it was a start nonetheless.

Catra had barely closed the door to her room - the door she'd slammed closed for her own peace of mind, hoping it was finally time for her to settle in for the day - when her guards knocked on it to deliver a message.

Apparently, Princess Adora requested her presence in her chambers, which sure was a conspicuous way to word a booty call. If the entire Magicat delegation and council of Eternia didn't already know that the two of them were hooking up, they would know now for sure.

("Sister," Mira had said to her before going back to her own room, "you know that we love and support you, no matter what you do."

"I don't support this," Vee had muttered.

"But we do think you might be going too far with the diplomacy thing," Mira had agreed, "and it could hurt our chances in the long run."

"Not to mention our credibility. If you're not capable of keeping your hands off your ex for long enough to take this seriously, maybe you shouldn't have led this mission in the first place.")

This was a bad idea. It hadn't even been in Catra's plans - she'd planned to give Adora the cold shoulder entirely, have her crawl back to her, maybe give her a taste of her own medicine, but she'd gotten lost somewhere in between. Now she'd given Adora power over her again and she'd have to reset boundaries, lest she make a fool of herself. She didn't want Adora to take too many liberties too soon, like nothing ever happened.

That was what she should've said as soon as she opened Adora's door, except Adora dragged her in by the wrist, her smile

monstrously large.

"You *wanted* to make us late."

"I don't know what you're talking about," Catra grunted.

Adora backed her towards the bed, though she didn't throw her on it and start passionately making out with her like Catra had expected. She almost would have preferred it, because Adora laid her gently down instead before climbing over her, which was a thousand times more dangerous.

"I reminded you we had a meeting, and you didn't care. You went for round two, even though it would have made us late."

"Listen, you were the one who assaulted me in the shower," - a pretty weak excuse as it went - "and I don't remember you saying no."

Adora's smile softened around the edges, her hands brushing over the sides of Catra's face. The base of Catra's ponytail was digging into the mattress. "Is it really a secret that I would rather be with you than do almost anything else?"

"In my experience? Yes."

Just kiss me, you idiot, Catra wished. *I don't want to think.*

But Adora hesitated for longer than Catra was willing to wait, and just when Catra realized she could be the one to reach up and call an end to the conversation, Adora rolled off on her back to one side of the bed.

She also sighed, which was a prelude to *more* conversation. "I'm sorry. I know I messed up. I guess I'm not as good at it as I thought."

"Good at what? Caring?"

If Adora had to try, had to work at it even, was it really worth it? Catra didn't know how to *stop* caring. It had haunted her her whole life.

"I've been trying to understand," Adora whispered, looking at nothing - at the ceiling, perhaps, "what I felt for you, and how to handle it. How to deal with it when there's this whole planet that requires my help."

Catra decided to look at the ceiling too, though there was nothing to really focus on. Just white paint and white walls in a room that had as much personality as their Horde bunk. "There will always be some planet."

"That doesn't mean I don't want you," Adora said. "I told you - if it had been up to me, I would have let everyone burn but you and I. Do you know how terrifying that is? How terrible it made me feel?"

Catra thought about the portal - about together at the end of the world. *Terrible*, she'd said. "I might have an idea."

"It was so much," Adora continued, undeterred. "I'd been trying to define it for a long time, and I thought *love* came pretty close. But you took my words away. Just - absolutely blew them out of the park."

"Are you going somewhere with this?" Catra groaned, trying to suppress what Adora had just said, the realization that *That's what love feels like to me, too*.

"I was scared. And I thought going back to more familiar ground would help, but it didn't. It just made me miss you." There was a bitterness to her next words, an undertone of anger that Adora clearly hadn't expected to come out. "I wrote letters to you. A lot of them. You never replied."

"I didn't want to talk to you," Catra simply said. She'd kept all the letters, though; maybe she'd read them someday. "I knew they would just be empty words."

Adora turned her head at that. “How can you say that, if you haven’t even opened them?”

“Look, Adora.” Catra sat up in bed, her eyes flitting around the room. It wasn’t hard finding what she was looking for and grabbing it when it was the one thing on Adora’s nightstand, the rest of her books neatly stacked in a pile on the floor. She didn’t even have a bookshelf. “I’m gonna be frank - these things are rotting your brain.”

"Wh - *books* ?” Adora scrambled to Catra’s side of the bed, trying to wrestle the book away from her. "You should read some, you know. Might be good for you.”

“Still harboring that superiority complex, I see. Can’t say I’m surprised.” Catra rolled out of bed and to her feet, holding the book out of Adora’s reach. “I read tons, Adora. Half Moon has one of the biggest libraries on Etheria.”

Adora blushed faintly - hopefully out of embarrassment. “Well, then what’s your problem with romance? I read what I like.”

“The problem isn’t romance.” And to demonstrate that, Catra opened the book on a random page, cleared her throat, and read: “ *How I am loved by you! How you weigh upon me, how you heave me and crush me, how you besiege me and feed me* - That’s what you sound like all the time. Just a bunch of pretty, empty words.”

When Adora moved to stand, Catra expected her to reach for the book again, but was struck instead by her lack of action - the kind of hollow feeling that came from missing a step under your feet. “That’s what you think? That I don’t really care about you?”

Catra shrugged. Adora’s voice was so thin - it only got like that when she was really hurt. It didn’t make her feel as good as she’d thought. “I think you can embellish your *love* all you want, but that means nothing if that’s all the effort you put into it.”

"You're wrong," Adora said. "And I'm going to prove it to you, okay? I know how to fix this."

"Which is how," Catra asked, boredly, rhetorically.

Instead of replying, Adora finally, *finally*, cupped Catra's face in her hands and brushed her lips with hers. A brush was how it started, Catra almost pulling back to remind Adora that they didn't do this, that this would fix nothing - but it quickly evolved into something rougher and clumsier as Adora traced the inside of Catra's mouth. And then - *oh* - Adora picked her up like she weighed nothing, fingers probably leaving deep bruises on Catra's thighs. Her lips never left Catra's as she carried her to the only other piece of furniture in the royal chambers - a large, terribly old-fashioned armchair that they sank in nonetheless, wrapped in each other's bodies and noises and hands. Catra was holding Adora by the hair; it wasn't tied in her usual ponytail, blonde locks twisted instead into a tight braid that she longed to unravel.

But before she could, Adora whispered, in the space between their lips: "Marry me."

It was a feverish whisper, something that could have come from any dream Catra had had since she was six.

It gave Catra pause. Her brain struggled to catch up, replaying those two words over and over again, then promptly gave up and shut down.

"What the hell?" was her reply.

"I know it's insane," Adora said, keeping on kissing Catra's cheeks, and her nose, her forehead, "but that's how certain I am that I love you, okay? And that I want to be with you. I can't think of anything more binding than that to make you believe me. I mean, think of it, our people will be at peace too -"

"The reason we're not at peace is that *your* people took our runestone," Catra reminded her slowly, as if she was speaking to a child - or maybe as if she herself were a child again, relearning

how to form logical thought. “So that’s one way to save your ass and throw *me* under the bus.”

“That has nothing to do with it,” Adora protested. “The wedding would come later. I wouldn’t so much as think of it until the Heart is yours again.”

“But you’re thinking of it now.” Catra’s head was still trying to wrap around it. She blinked up at Adora, gently pushing her back until she was on her feet again and Catra could sit up. She felt all the color draining from her face. “God, Adora - you couldn’t even be with me for two nights in a row, and now you want to get married? You can’t just solve everything with a wedding. Not after all that went wrong between us.”

“You wanted proof,” Adora said, looking down at her, “and I’m giving you proof. I don’t know what else to do.”

“I didn’t want you to be my absentee girlfriend,” Catra said, “and I sure as hell don’t want you to be my absentee wife. I don’t need your promises, your fantasies, your - childish ideas of how things should be. I need you to put in the actual work, or leave me alone.”

“I don’t know how to do that, Catra,” Adora repeated, more firmly now. “I don’t know how I can be with you the way you want me to - the way *I* want to - when the rest of the universe could suffer for it.”

“And you think choosing to be unhappy will only affect you?” Catra shook her head, disbelieving - that Catra had been through hell and back to get to where she needed to be, and through it all, Adora had learned nothing. “You idiot. Me being miserable almost broke the world.”

Catra was just going with the flow of conversation now, having gained too much momentum to stop being angry, but something about Adora’s train of thought was honestly, and truly, heartbreaking. It made Catra want to lock herself in a room for

the rest of her life and cry over lost years, lost potential, little girls made to grow up too fast.

"I hate to be the one to tell you this, Adora, but She-Ra is gone. Your parents are gone. There is no higher power telling you how things are supposed to be, yet you still tear yourself to pieces over nothing."

To her surprise, Adora actually looked struck by those words. Catra would've slapped anyone who dared speak to her that way; she wouldn't have faulted Adora if she'd decided that's what she deserved.

"Wow. Please, Catra, tell me how you really feel."

Though her voice was stiff, Catra could hear no bitterness. When Adora said please, it sounded like an actual request. *Tell me what I'm doing wrong. Tell me how to fix it.*

So Catra motioned for her to sit down on the bed, because if they were doing this, then they would be there a while.

"When I threatened war," Catra started, calmly enough, "did you not wonder why I was so sure my people had my back? Why yours seem to hate you instead? You told me about it so often, and I never realized - I should have seen it coming, really, but I thought all Eternians were just like that. And then your council almost wasn't at today's reunion, even though my whole delegation was, and sure, the two of us almost didn't make it either, but - Adora, do you ever *talk* to your people? Do you ever listen to them? Not to what you think they want, but what they *actually* want?"

Adora blinked, confused. "They think I'm an unfit ruler, and that me being She-Ra, or my parents' daughter, doesn't make me qualified. What they want is to see me gone."

"They want you to make an effort," Catra corrected her, "and so do I. So do Bow and Glimmer, by the way - you're not talking to them anymore. They know something's wrong."

" *They*'re not talking to me," was Adora's witty reply.

How much easier it was, to wallow in self-pity rather than guilt. Catra would know.

It was the familiarity that pushed her forward, off the chair and onto her knees in front of Adora, like she would to comfort a kid. Except Adora was still taller than her, even sitting down, and her hand was in Catra's hair now, gently tilting her face up.

"Because you're pulling away. For the sake of some greater good that only you can see. I mean, so what if your council wants to overthrow you? You'd be happier, Adora. You deserve to be happy."

Adora had this look in her eyes, like happiness was an entirely new concept to her. Something she thought existed in books only, that she couldn't wait to experience for herself.

"I'd be happiest with you."

Catra closed her eyes, taking in her words. "Me too," she whispered, turning her face into Adora's hand - feeling the lines of her palm, her calluses. "But not like this. I can't do this anymore."

Adora could've promised her it would've been different this time - but Catra wouldn't have wanted to hear it, and besides, it would probably be a lie.

Half moons were obviously very sacred for Magicats. As far as Catra knew, they were tied to old fertility rites - half moons occurring twice a month and providing double the occasion for kingdom wide celebrations and conceptions. The hope of producing newborns with the gift faded over time along with Half Moon's magic, but the tradition had continued under a different form.

Since the first half moon of the month was coming, and the Magicats were by now hard at work trying to get their runestone and their magic back, Catra found it fitting to reprise that tradition here on Eternia. She insisted it would be an enormous show of good faith on Adora's part, and would go a long way in preventing future problems between their kingdoms.

She told Adora everything over breakfast - told her about the festival's significance, the food specialties, what a typical celebration usually entailed. She hadn't come in wanting to discuss the subject, but she'd soon found it was either that or roll around in bed with Adora for the whole morning - and that was something she was trying to quit. She had more important stuff to think about than trying to make Adora love her.

Not least of all, how to make herself *leave* her.

"How did you not know about any of this?" Catra asked, midway through her explanation. "I know we were underground for centuries, and that the planet was cut off from the rest of the universe, but - there have to be some historical records. Did your council tell you nothing about it?"

Adora cleared her throat awkwardly. Catra was not-so-subtly trying to encourage her to reach out to them more and more often, and Adora was starting to catch up. "My council represents the people of Eternia. What you're looking for is an ambassador - and no, interplanetary exchanges are still very rare and far in between. Plus, when you got cut off from the rest of the universe, we also got cut off from you."

"Well, that sounds stupid. Prime almost won because everyone kept to themselves until the very end instead of establishing a common front. I know you've been translating and spreading cultural works from all over the galaxy, but not much of Magicat culture has been written down - and we can't possibly be the only ones."

She could push this a bit further. Giving Adora some people to fill in for Catra soon would be beneficial to both of them.

"I'm telling you, you need ambassadors. I've got a few people in mind for Half Moon already."

Surprisingly, Adora looked like she was holding back laughter. "Is one of them Mira?"

"God, yes, please. Take her and get her out of my sight."

At that, Adora chuckled for real, and Catra found herself almost cracking a smile in return. This was dangerous - Adora had forfeited the right to play around with her or her family. This was slipping back into old habits far too easily, and she never wanted to stop doing it.

"You know what I think would send a really strong message?"

Catra sipped warily at her coffee. "What?"

"If we went to the ball together."

She sighed, already picturing the rest of the conversation. "What does *together* mean, in this case?"

"What it means in any case. Just, showing up together, arm on arm. Looking good. I thought it would be nice."

Catra eyed her. She was trying to pick up any facetiousness, any second meaning behind her words. Though Adora never schemed, per se - she was too innocent for that - hiding behind that naivety was usually exactly what got her what she wanted. But she could find none of that now. "It *would* be nice."

Adora smiled back at her, but it didn't last long. Something was troubling her - something was always troubling her - and watching it creep up on her was a little like watching the sun die.

“As far as unity in the face of Prime goes - I never apologized for leaving you on his ship. I'd been trying to rescue Glimmer all along, but I never even asked myself where you were.”

“That’s a recurring motif, I think,” Catra muttered under her breath. If Adora had had ears like her own, they would have folded down in response, but as it was, Adora just looked really miserable and really guilty. Catra swatted it away. “It’s fine, Adora. We were enemies. I deserved you cutting me off.”

“You didn’t deserve me leaving you behind again and again,” Adora insisted. “You were my best friend, if nothing else. I should have acted more like it.”

This was a little less easy for Catra to refute. Adora had been sorry for leaving many times, but she always had some sort of excuse at the ready - *I’m sorry it hurt you, but I had to do it; I’m sorry I left, but someone needed me more.* That didn’t seem to be the case now. Adora acknowledging that she’d had her own faults in their relationship, and that those faults weren’t circumstantial, weren’t just the result of outside forces at play - that was all Catra had needed to hear for years.

She was making it hard on herself just listening to Adora now, but she couldn’t help but drink in her words, letting them wreak havoc in her chest. “Yeah, well. I could have done better too.”

“I don’t know if we’ll ever finish making it up to each other,” Adora said, “and given how much we’ve hurt each other, maybe we never will. But I think we owe it to each other to try.”

Tell her. Tell her right now.

Catra couldn’t. For once, it was all going so well between them. She didn’t want to ruin it.

“Okay.”

Tomorrow. She’d tell her tomorrow, or the day after.

But Adora never gave her the chance.

The party was organized in no time, thanks to Catra choosing to focus on event planning rather than the way Adora looked when she laughed, but Adora's enthusiasm for it was a nice surprise. Catra had half expected to have to do all the work, and that Adora would simply be there to nod along, but she actually came up with some ideas of her own, wanting to adapt Half Moon's more specific traditions to the Eternian environment - suggesting little modifications to show unity between their kingdoms, but always asking Catra about how to keep the celebrations true to their roots. Quiet determination shone through in the way she spoke and in the undiscriminated way she lent Catra her attention.

Getting dressed together in Adora's room was purely accidental. Catra simply had none of Adora's defense mechanisms and self-deceptions, and could fully admit that she'd shown up on Adora's door not so much because she needed a second opinion, but because she liked having Adora's attention to herself and wanted to show off for her. She'd intentionally chosen Adora's colors to make an impression, but she hadn't imagined the white and gold would render her this speechless, and she definitely didn't expect Adora to ask her help picking out something to wear.

In the end, she zipped Adora up in a golden gown - a curious and absolutely random choice on Catra's part that resulted in them matching - and her fingers lingered on Adora's skin until the ballroom opened up in front of them.

"Ah, there she is," Catra loudly announced to be heard over the traditional music a particularly enthusiastic Magicat was playing in the corner.

Adora felt her tugging on her arm, leading her towards the buffet table where Mira was picking out something to eat. She was surrounded by other Magicats Adora was starting to recognize,

but that wasn't the most surprising thing. Rather, it was the fact that they were happily conversing with her council.

Adora wished she had more time to take in such a historic moment of unity - and without her even having to do anything - but Catra was already shoving a wine flute into her hands, encouraging her to take a sip.

"That's a future Half Moon ambassador right there, isn't that right, Adora?"

"Catra and I talked," Adora explained to Mira's befuzzled face, "and she brought up some of her concerns to me, like the fact that we should be paying more attention to interplanetary relationships. I can't do much now, but I can hopefully set up a meeting with other leaders once our communication system is done and set up a diplomatic web. She said you'd be perfect for the role."

"Catra told you something nice," Mira said, munching slowly, "about me?"

"Don't make a big deal out of it," Catra huffed. "You're extremely smart and capable when you aren't pestering me."

"Aw, sis, I'm touched. Who's going to teach you about Magicat history to keep you from making a fool of yourself when I'm gone?"

"Also, Prince Javi," she continued, refusing to acknowledge the rest of the words out of Mira's mouth. "He's slightly more old-fashioned, but kind and reliable."

Javi, on Mira's right, clearly resented being called old-fashioned, but didn't speak up about it, which only confirmed Catra's claim. "It's a pleasure to officially meet you, your Highness."

Adora would have liked to reciprocate, but as she looked at that old, kind face she remembered Catra's deference to him, and something else slipped out of her lips: "Catra cares about you."

When he smiled, Adora realized the laughter lines around his eyes and mouth made him look older than he must've been. "Is that such a surprise?"

Maybe, to Adora, it was. Maybe Adora had just never known Catra to care about anyone but her, and she'd been too busy with her own stuff to realize that a new, improved Catra stood in her place now, and that she didn't want to go back to how they used to be.

"What about us, your Highness?" Magnor inquired, looking uncharacteristically jovial in a way only Magicat punch could reduce people to. "Who would you choose to represent Eternia?"

She had to say, having a conversation that could almost seem based on mutual respect with the Eternian council was rare. "This only came up today, Magnor, so I don't really know yet," she admitted, truthfully. "I think Rodin would be a good fit, wouldn't they? As far as interplanetary relations go."

Adora expected him to pout, or bring up his extensive expertise - but he just nodded, and even playfully shoved Rodin's shoulder, who smiled in return. Adora had never seen Rodin smile. "Oh, yeah, that's true."

"May I also suggest that our next biggest priority should be teaching the younger generation, as well?" Rodin proposed. "You've done a good job of gathering texts from all over the galaxy, your Highness, but they'll still need a guide."

"Of course," Adora nodded, not believing her own ears. "When I'm not dealing with so much stuff, I'm going to take care of it."

"Or you could let *me* take care of it," Rodin pointed out. "That's why you have us, after all."

It was such a simple concept, yet Adora had never thought of it that way. She'd always seen her council as an obstacle, a hostile force - and they could be, sometimes, but now she was wondering if she'd been the hostile one in the first place, refusing

to listen and let herself be helped. Preventing anything like Prime from arising ever again - maybe it started here.

“That sounds like an excellent idea, Rodin.”

And then Magnor said something about the poor children who won’t know who they’re dealing with, and Javi laughed along, and Adora turned to Catra as the conversation went on.

“We’ve never really danced, have we? Not without ulterior motives, I mean.”

“Such as sabotage and seduction?”

“Yeah,” Adora laughed, drinking some more. The punch was definitely too strong for her tastes, but it was fruity enough that most people wouldn’t notice. In fact, the low drumbeats were already encouraging Eternians and Magicats alike to get rowdy on the dance floor. “I’d really like that.”

“Me too,” Catra said, clearing her throat when her voice came out too strangled.

Both their glasses were abandoned on a nearby table as she and Adora joined the dances. Adora couldn’t help but glance back at the group around the buffet as they went.

“See? There is nothing our punch can’t fix.”

“I don’t think it was the punch, Catra,” Adora said, awed, guiding them into a slow start. She carefully lay one hand on Catra’s hip to bring her closer, the other entwined with Catra’s. “That was you. You’re incredible.”

Catra pulled a tight smile. “I did nothing.”

“You did more than I would have thought to do.”

“No, Adora, I really did nothing. I organized the party, but I didn’t force my people to make friends with yours or anything. I guess

while you and I were - showering, the other day, they took matters into their own hands."

Adora's head was spinning at the incredible notion that the world hadn't stopped turning the one time she'd been selfish and shut it out. If anything, that had been just what she needed to make things better. "I guess they did."

"It's like a wound, you know?" Catra's hand, the one still holding Adora's, trailed up her arm to rest where it met her shoulder. Adora thought the way Catra's fingers brushed the top of her spine, claws just barely grazing the skin there, had to be deliberate. "You can treat it as aggressively as you want, but ultimately, what you really need is to let it rest."

Adora was only vaguely aware of the buzz of alcohol in her blood. She felt perfectly light-headed even without it, and so, so relaxed. After long days and harsh meetings, she usually wanted nothing more than to crawl into Catra's bed, fall asleep stroking the curve of her waist and forget about the rest of the world, only to be forcibly reminded that she wasn't allowed anymore. If she thought about it too hard now, her heart would break.

"Maybe some take longer to heal than others."

Maybe if they'd had more of this in the Horde, things would have worked out better for them. Maybe they wouldn't have latched onto each other at the expense of everything else, would have been better for each other.

But because they hadn't known anything else, that was what Adora clung to - the same broken mechanism, the same old clock fixed on the same wretched hour.

Maybe if they weren't different people now, they could keep doing this dance for a long time still. But Adora felt lighter on her feet and so much older than her years, and she'd wasted too much time already.

"How about you, as an ambassador?" she suggested, though not as slyly as she'd imagined it. "I mean, you're clearly good at it. You could stay here. With me."

Catra looked at her for so long, Adora forgot she was waiting for an answer. In her mind, Catra had already said yes, because of course she would, and she'd probably be impressed Adora was taking actionable steps to work on their relationship. Then she lay her head on Adora's chest like she wanted to hide from her, and muttered: "I'm going back to Half Moon, Adora."

Needless to say, that broke the spell alright. Adora froze in the middle of the ballroom, causing a nearby couple to collide into them. "When?"

"A few days from now, I guess. There's no reason for me to stick around longer than that, since we're nowhere close to figuring the Heart out. I'm going to officially appoint some of my people to oversee this entire thing, and then just go where I'm needed."

I need you, she wanted to scream. She was tired of pretending she didn't. "What happened to the whole *making an effort* thing? Did you just decide it was pointless?"

"Adora, I would have had to leave eventually. What does it matter if it's now or later?"

"It matters because you keep expecting me to put everything on the line for you, something you're clearly not willing to do yourself."

Catra leaned back and looked at her like she'd been slapped. Adora knew she was making a scene, but she'd learned today the world wouldn't fall if she decided to be selfish for once, and she was going to take full advantage of that. "I don't expect you to do anything for me -"

"For myself, then. That's what you were gonna say, right? You know what would really make me happy - if you stopped torturing me like this to protect your stupid pride and told me what you

want me to do right out. I'm sorry I didn't know better - I've hurt you so many times. But I'm listening now, Catra. I mean, what do you think I've been trying to do for the past week? You wanted everyone to sit down and talk - then stop being a coward and talk."

Catra squared her up and down. "You won't like what I have to say."

"Doesn't matter. You don't get to back out of this - communication goes both ways." Adora said. "What will make you believe that I'm serious about this? About you?"

Catra's mouth opened and quickly closed again. Her pupils widened just slightly as a thought was birthed and died around the same time. When she spoke again, it was into Adora's ear - her body wrapped around hers as if to hide her from view.

"I want you to give it all up," she whispered, so low Adora could barely hear her over the blood rush, the deafening sound her magic made bubbling up inside her body. "Your kingdom, your crown, and your destiny. And I'd like to say that I want you to do it for yourself, because you hate it - but I want you to do it for me. Because you always give so much of yourself away, and if you're going to waste it, then I want you to waste it on me."

Her voice broke off there. She had to clear her throat, though when she spoke again, it was only a low rasp.

"So you see - that's why I couldn't tell you."

She pushed past Adora to the end of the ballroom, stopping only by the buffet table to grab an entire bottle of wine, and everyone's eyes followed her on the way out.

Adora found Entrapta looking over the balustrade at the dancing people and was surprised to see she'd actually made an effort to somewhat dress up. She was wearing suspenders over pants as

always, but it was a nice fabric - something like tweed, if she had to hazard a guess - and the plaid pattern really made the outfit.

Entrapta was making an effort, even when she shouldn't have had to. And still, she was spending the whole night here, tapping distractedly on her tracker pad.

The older woman had always been comfortable being on her own, and Adora had always told herself that perhaps Entrapta just liked it that way - that love and friendship were circumstantial to her work, just fun little side adventures on the way to something bigger.

Most of Adora's life had been like that, too, except that something bigger had never come. She'd waited for some destiny to be bestowed upon her at the expense of everything else, and when it had, she'd only ended up a wheel in some centuries-old machinery. Part of her thought she still was.

On Beast Island, she'd promised Entrapta they'd never leave her behind again, and there were several other people she'd promised to take care of. Maybe it was time to make good on that.

"Entrapta?"

"Adora!" she squealed, not taking her eyes off the screen. "Did you need something?"

Shame filled her chest to bursting. "Yes," she said hesitantly, "but I was wondering why you were up here alone."

"Oh, the music downstairs is too loud. I can't focus on my experiment. See, I'm thinking of opening a private channel in the interplanetary communication system for purely diplomatic purposes, so that an event such as this one wouldn't cause interference in the general channels every time -"

"That's a really good idea, Entrapta. Do you want me to test it out for you? Magnor's telling a group of Magicats outside about pre-She-Ra Eternian legends - thought you might be interested."

Entrapta was, in fact, interested. She pushed the tracker pad into Adora's hands, rambling about how excited she was to have an assistant again, and zoomed past her immediately, stopping only long enough to tell her how to operate the tech on the way out.

Glimmer picked up on the fourth ring - just when Adora was about to hang up - and when she showed on screen in all her ruffled-hair glory, Adora was suddenly reminded that it was the middle of the night on Etheria, their moon already risen and high in the sky. "Adora?"

"I'm sorry! Did I wake you?"

Glimmer made a humming noise low in her chest. "It's okay, Adora. I wasn't asleep."

"Are you sure? You seem… tired."

"Nope! All good. Could run a marathon right now."

Adora squinted at the screen. It was too dark to be sure, but there was no mistaking the red cheeks, the signs of exertion on Glimmer's face. "Honestly, you look like you already have."

There was a choked laugh on the other line, which Glimmer uselessly tried to suppress. Adora froze. "Is Bow there with you?"

"What? Noo."

"'Cause that sounded a lot like Bow."

His face popped up next to Glimmer's, easy and familiar. "Hi, Adora!"

"Were you two - oh God."

"Don't think too hard about it," Glimmer huffed, blush only getting deeper. "Please?"

“I wasn’t gonna say anything.” Adora replied, choking different exclamations of surprise back down. “I just - *guys*, you’re together again?”

“We’re not, like, *together* together, but - we’re starting to figure things out. I guess we’ll see how it goes from there.”

Bow pressed a kiss to Glimmer’s shoulder, and it took Adora everything she had not to squeal about it. *These are your best friends. Don’t make it weird.* But a deep-seated joy had settled in her chest, and she couldn’t possibly contain her grin. “So I guess news got to you, uh.”

“It was all a misunderstanding,” Bow murmured, a soft smile playing on his lips. “I never wanted Perfuma. I was just waiting for Glimmer to take me back.”

“Oh, shut it,” Glimmer said, sniffling loudly. “Adora doesn’t want to hear this, right, Adora? You did call, so I guess that means Entrapta’s communication system finally works?”

“Just testing one of its features, but yes, we’ve made a lot of progress. That’s not why I’m calling.”

Bow grabbed Glimmer’s tracker pad and brought it closer to himself. He had his serious face on, the one that left no room for small talk. “What is it?”

Adora sighed, because who else could it be? Who had it been, from the very beginning? “It’s Catra. I’m not sure how much you know about what’s going on between us -”

“What, that you’re sleeping together?”

“That, and also -”

“That you’ve been in love with each other since you were like, six?”

Adora frowned. “I don’t know if that’s true -”

“It is,” Glimmer announced triumphantly. “Catra has told us plenty, and we’ve figured out the rest on our own. Go on.”

Adora shouldn’t be too surprised. About Catra airing out their business, definitely - but Catra and Glimmer had connected on Prime’s ship, and some emotional vulnerability had to have been in order. That she had shared bits and pieces of their lives with Adora’s group, kept Adora alive in their minds even when Adora couldn’t be bothered to - the idea that there had always been something tying the four of them together, the people Adora loved most in the world, let her know everything was gonna be okay; that this, too, was a kind of permanence.

“I don’t want her to leave,” she confessed, terribly, under her breath. “But I can’t do what she asks of me. I’m usually good at it, but this time-”

“What is it?”

“I think she wants me to leave with her. Like, for good.”

“Leave Eternia?” Glimmer gaped. “How are you even meant to do that?”

Bow agreed with her. “Honestly, Adora, as far as ultimatums go, that sounds kind of manipulative.”

“No, but she didn’t even *want* to tell me. I had to drag it out of her. She knew it’d be too much for me to accept, so she wasn’t even gonna try.”

“Of course it’s too much, Adora. She can’t possibly expect you to uproot your entire life to be with her. You’re not the one in the wrong here.”

“But what if I’m tired, Glimmer?” she exploded. “What if I’m tired of always doing the right thing? What if I *want* to leave with her, and not because she’s asking me, but because she’s finally given me the right excuse -”

“Adora, slow down,” Bow said, at the same time Glimmer asked, “What are you talking about?”

“I *hate* it here, Glimmer. I honestly, truly hate it, and I want to be home again. Don’t I deserve to be happy too, after everything?”

“Of course you do, Adora -”

“Why is it always me, then? Why does it *always* have to be me?”

Glimmer and Bow were quiet, and for an awful moment Adora was afraid they didn’t know either. That they were going to tell her it was just the way things worked, and so she wasn’t allowed Catra - she wasn’t allowed anything she could keep.

But then Bow spoke up. “Because you *want* it to be you. You take care of people.”

“Yes, well. Maybe I’d like for someone to take care of me, too. Is that really so bad?”

She was twenty-four, Adora thought. Twenty-four, and no one in her life had ever held her hand and told her it was going to be okay, or taken a burden off her shoulders so she wouldn’t have to. The one person who had was still stuck in a portal, and Adora would have to carry that guilt her whole life. Even the other princesses, constantly saying they had Adora’s back, didn’t matter in the long run - because like everything else, the end of the world had come down to her and Catra, and Catra had been the one to almost die for her, and Adora had only repaid her by leaving again.

Didn’t she owe it to Catra - no, to herself - to try harder, to give herself a chance to love and be loved? Was an affair on the sidelines of yet another conflict really the best she could aspire to?

“And you think that person could be Catra?”

“I love her,” she whispered into the tracker pad, unsure if the sound could even be picked up among the other noises of the

ballroom. “I’ve never *not* loved her.”

“And I get that, Adora. But there has to be a better way - one that doesn’t mess you up further. I haven’t gotten back together with Bow because I decided to stop being the queen of Bright Moon. I did it because I loved him, and I would try to keep him in my life no matter what. I didn’t have to give anything up, because I knew he’d make everything bearable.”

“You broke up because he was taking up too much of your time,” Adora said, and Bow recoiled, wincing. “No, sorry, Bow, I mean - you couldn’t be a good queen and follow your heart’s desires, right? That’s why you told me to give up on Catra. Why are things different now?”

“I don’t know,” Glimmer admitted. “But Adora - I’m not going to leave him again. I’m not going to leave my people, either, or give them less than they deserve - but I’m not negotiating on Bow.” Something told Adora Glimmer wasn’t really talking to her. “And he’s not negotiating on me either. Whatever comes, we’re going to face it together, work through it together - and that’s all the difference.”

Adora watched as Bow and Glimmer stared into each other’s eyes like she wasn’t even there, Bow’s grip getting tighter on Glimmer’s arm. She couldn’t help but wonder if she was somewhat responsible for this, too - as she was responsible for everything, good or bad, that happened in this godforsaken universe - for their desperation to hold on to each other. She’d left them alone, and while they’d understood, she hadn’t been the best friend to them. But for once, she didn’t want to punish herself; her gaze softened as Glimmer buried her head into Bow’s neck, an ache starting right in her chest.

“I miss you guys so much.”

Bow turned her head to her again, and Adora was wrong - they hadn’t forgotten about her. She could feel all the love they had for

her, a warmth reaching out to envelop her through the screen. “We miss you too, Adora.”

“I’m going to visit soon, okay?” she said. She’d had no plans until that very moment, but she was going to make them. “After we sort the Heart out. Or maybe you could come visit me. I bet soon enough, Entrapta’s going to find a way to make your magic work here, too, so you could just pop in for afternoon tea and be gone again before sunset.”

Glimmer laughed in the light, high sound of a hundred crystal bells. “We’d like that.”

“I’ll talk to her about it, then.” She had no idea if it was feasible, but they still hadn’t found a single thing Entrapta couldn’t do. Except, maybe, fix the Heart. But that wasn’t fair to her - she was doing the best she could, and knowing her, she was probably already halfway to figuring out a magical range enhancer without Adora even needing to ask.

“I love you.”

She closed the call like that and held the tracker pad to her chest, imagining it was her best friends. The words had never been enough before, but sometimes they just had to do.

Catra’s door cracked open, letting the light from the hallway into the dark room, and of course, Adora slipped into it.

“Can I come in?”

It was ridiculous to even ask. Catra had known Adora would show up, eventually, if even just to reject her for good. If Catra had wanted to do something about it, she could have put up more of a struggle - could have asked Mira or Vee to sleep in her room, could have warned her guards not to let Adora in - but she hadn’t. She’d stayed on the carpet in front of the fire, arms curled up around her legs, waiting for Adora to come to her, because it was

too hard, sleeping alone, and just as hard to sleep with people who weren't Adora.

Catra lifted the bottle up to her mouth again. "It's your castle."

"It's your chambers," Adora quipped back, taking that as an invitation to walk in and stand awkwardly in the middle of the room. "Can we talk? Or are you -"

She rolled her eyes, pointedly taking a large chug and swallowing. "Just buzzed. Our tolerance is much higher, and besides, this tastes horrible."

"Wh- horrible?"

Catra managed to crack a smile, which apparently encouraged Adora to tiptoe over to the carpet and take a seat next to her. She extended the bottle to Adora, inviting her to drink and see for herself, and Adora latched onto it immediately, excitable as a little kid. Catra winced in sympathy.

"Do you remember on Prime's ship, that little feast he threw on the first night you were there?"

Adora blinked, seemingly finding nothing wrong with the drink. "With the green stuff?"

"That sort of - green slime he made us drink, yeah," Catra snorted, stumbling on her words just slightly. "I personally think this is even worse."

"This is the best we could do for you on short notice," Adora huffed. "I followed the recipe you gave me."

"We didn't bring our brewers, okay? I'll hook you up with them when I'm back home. Now give me that."

"Why do you want it, if it's so disgusting?"

Catra knocked the bottle back, rolling her eyes. "'Cause if I know where this is heading, I'm probably gonna need it."

Adora swallowed, clearly taken aback. "Catra -"

"Look, I'm sorry," she sighed. "What I asked of you was fucked up."

Adora's gaze was steady and gentle. "I made you tell me, didn't I?"

"Doesn't matter. I still thought of it."

"I thought of saying yes," she said, which had Catra whip her head around in disbelief. Adora only shrugged. "Such a common, lovelorn act. You'd have no choice but to believe me."

Catra scoffed out a laugh. "That really doesn't make it better, Adora."

But she didn't pull back when Adora sneaked her arms around her waist and pulled her against her chest - she leaned into it helplessly, wishing she could voice how good Adora felt to her, how safe. Catra refused to meet her eyes - she wasn't going to be questioned, or ridiculed - but her silence must have been a good enough response for Adora.

"Why do you think we can't stay away from each other?" Adora wondered out loud. "Like, ever since we were kids. I can't stop thinking about it."

"I don't know. I guess -" Catra sighed, shaking her head to clear it. This was too complicated a question to give an answer to when it was this late and they were still passing a bottle around, but Catra had asked herself the same thing too many times not to even address it. "Because we became people together. Sometimes I think if I'd never met you, or if I'd met you only a few years later, I would have become an entirely different person - but I didn't, and so there will always be some fundamental part of me that was influenced into being by you. No matter how far I stray

from it, that's a part of me that can't be removed. Does that make sense?"

Adora was quiet for a few beats. "Would you have preferred it, if you'd never met me at all? If we didn't need each other as much?"

"Do you remember how we met, Adora?"

Adora sounded surprised. "Do you?"

"Of course. You gave me my name, you know."

Her eyes widened in realization. "I think you gave me mine."

"I did more than that. I remember how closed off you were - never speaking to anyone, never approaching anyone first. Even at three years old, you were so obsessed about living up to Shadow Weaver's expectations. If it had just been about proximity, you could have latched onto any of the people in the Horde for survival, but you waited for me. That has to count for something." She shrugged. "It used to haunt me, this idea that in another world we could have been different. But then again, it's likely we'd just have different names and be dead."

Adora relaxed against her, sighing. "I really am sorry about Half Moon, Catra. I shouldn't have run, but I was too scared. I thought I was protecting you - all of you."

"I know. I wish -" She let her words hang in the air. "I wish you weren't made to feel like others were incapable of protecting themselves."

"I know you can take care of yourself," Adora whispered. "I *want* to do it for you. Not because Shadow Weaver convinced me it was my responsibility, or because Light Hope convinced me it was destiny. We didn't choose the way we were brought up, and I'd change that if I could, but being together - that was all good. I wouldn't give it up for the world."

"Me neither."

Adora sighed, relief turning sour. "Then what do we do, Catra?"

"I don't - I don't know."

Adora was starting to nod off on Catra, her blabbering rendered almost incomprehensible by both sleepiness and tipsiness.

Catra didn't feel like shaking her off. She wanted to keep Adora right there, let her fall asleep with Catra in her arms and pretend they could always have this, because this sounded a lot like goodbye.

And then Adora made it worse. She threaded her fingers through Catra's hair, set the locks aside, and pressed kisses to the nape of her neck.

Catra hated herself for flinching, thinking it would make Adora stop. Her arms loosened slightly around Catra, but when Catra melted back into her, Adora sighed and resumed her ministrations immediately. Her kisses were firm and enthusiastic, getting wetter and wetter and edging on the side of Catra's neck, the underside of Catra's jaw, but always coming back to her nape like it was something to worship.

Catra was starting to think Adora had somehow fallen asleep with her lips on her, moving on their own accord as they got sloppier and sloppier, but then Adora whispered something that Catra almost missed.

"I want to touch you," she said, trailing a finger along her jaw. "You haven't let me touch you in so long."

Catra might've been a good liar, probably among the best - but saying no to this would have killed her. She'd opened herself up to this the moment Adora walked into her room, and she wasn't going to let Adora leave without taking everything she could from her one last time.

“Then touch me.”

She murmured it under her breath, almost hoping Adora wouldn’t hear. She obviously did, a quick intake of breath behind her being the main indicator; sex, and anything coming right before and right after, was the only time Adora would give her her full attention.

She definitely hadn’t expected Catra to say yes, though, because now she was hesitating, fingers not moving from where they currently rested. Catra couldn’t blame her - she’d been the one to give her an ultimatum less than two hours before - but she needed to take her mind off of things soon, so Catra caught Adora’s hand in hers and brought it down, down, over her chest and further down her body.

“Are you sure -”

“Please.” Catra turned into her arms, not letting go of her hand, and found Adora wide-eyed, her soft mouth gaping open. God, Catra needed to feel it again, needed to taste the alcohol on her tongue. “Please, touch me.”

Adora nodded, and Catra felt like she could finally breathe. Maybe Adora had seen it in her eyes, how Catra needed this more than she did. This, at least, was something they both wanted.

She immediately opened her mouth under the push of Catra’s lips, letting her take whatever she wished. Even Adora’s hand on Catra’s body was being guided by Catra’s own, led to touch where Catra needed it most - which was everywhere. It was so frustrating, to have to be bound to a single spot at a time when Catra wanted to feel all of Adora against her, and around her, and inside her, and she only grew more and more agitated under her skin when this simple touching seemed to give her no relief, until she eventually pulled back and started trying to take her clothes off.

She'd only just untucked her shirt when Adora's hand flew to the hem, tugging at it, her sweet voice on the verge of breaking. "Can I -"

Catra nodded, immediately handing the reins over to her. Sometimes, when they were kids, they would help dress each other up in the morning, especially when Catra was still too small and afraid to do it herself. This was a little like that, except when Adora lifted Catra's shirt over her head one of her hands lingered on Catra's torso, stroking down the patch under her belly where Catra was softest. The shirt was discarded - not just thrown away like Catra might've done, but handled with care, like Adora handled everything - and right away her other hand curled at the back of Catra's neck and pushed their lips together again.

It wasn't like any of the other times they'' kissed. They'd gone slow before, when they thought they had all the time in the world for it and could afford the luxury.

Now Adora kissed longingly, which was to say, she kissed slow and deep and languid despite knowing they didn't.

She kissed Catra like reaching out to her across the universe, like a wordless scream. Catra gasped at the feeling of Adora against her naked skin, even through the gauzy fabric of her dress; her head was thrown back in invitation, neck exposed in surrender, mouth open in prayer as Adora prodded it with her tongue. She left firm, wet kisses all over Catra's jaw and chin for longer than Catra could stand before finally latching on to the skin underneath - and when she bit roughly at it, in such contrast to how she'd handled her so far, Catra wanted to beg for more just as much as she wanted her to stop. She was already too overwhelmed by feeling Adora against her half-naked body, how her hands and mouth and tongue always seemed to just know what Catra needed when the rest of her didn't.

"Adora," she was saying, over and over again. "Adora."

"I'm here."

“Adora,” she sighed again, feeling Adora nuzzle into her neck and lick at the newly forming bruise to soothe the throbbing, moving downwards right after.

She thought for a second that Adora was purring, though she realized soon enough she was actually laughing, low and quiet. “Are you sure you’re not drunk?”

Catra could see where the worry, thinly veiled by the mock question, came from - she wasn’t usually this vocal, but it usually wasn’t the last time she would feel Adora’s lips on her like this. No self-respecting person would willingly keep up a relationship like that, no matter if it was all she would ever get from Adora. She kept telling herself that, though it never got any easier - especially with Adora cupping her face and mouthing all over her body, Catra only thinking *God, I’m going to miss this.*

She kept stroking and kissing, her teeth sometimes digging into Catra’s skin, giving her pinpricks of pain to focus on - but it all just washed over her, physical pain melting into emotional pain, bleeding through the cracks Adora was carving into her like stone.

She couldn’t do this - couldn’t bear it. Adora speaking to her like that was going to break her, and the way she cradled her face like it was something precious - “Catra? Are you okay?”

Adora sounded panicked, and it wasn’t until her thumbs went to wipe away Catra’s tears that Catra realized she was crying. “Did I do something wrong?” she asked, and she leapt off of Catra without waiting for an answer.

Catra reached out to keep her there, claws digging into Adora’s knuckles. She wanted Adora terribly; she wanted her as far away as possible. Adora looked down at her quizzically, waiting for her to make up her mind.

“Hey. Where did you go?” Adora whispered into the curve of her jaw, nuzzling it repeatedly as she let Catra trail her hand downwards to where she wanted it, ghosting over her bare chest

and the taut lines of her stomach and down still. Her other hand grasped Catra's chin, not hard enough to hurt but enough to get Catra's attention, and tilted it up towards her, just watching as Catra gaped and keened. Her still wet fingers swiped down Catra's bottom lip, letting her taste her own salt. "Baby, come back to me."

Adora finally slipped under her waistband and Catra's distressed noises melted into sighs of relief, climbing higher and higher as Adora touched her. Her eyes fluttered open, fighting the onslaught of pleasure that was making her hazed out, making her head swim. They struggled to focus on Adora, staring right through her and then at nothing at all.

"There she is," Adora smiled, marking the praise with a kiss to her lower belly. "Tell me what you want. I'll do anything."

Stay, something inside her screamed. *Not here in this castle. Just in this room, with me. Break it away from the rest of the universe and let's stay here for a little while.*

All the emphasis Adora put on wanting. Catra couldn't even lie, because she wasn't blind to what she wanted. Adora, on the other hand - if she'd asked Adora what she wanted, she wouldn't even understand the question.

None of her subtleties would cut it with Adora, and she couldn't expect Adora to give her anything Catra wasn't willing to give herself. If she wanted Adora to hear her she'd have to speak clearly, and God - if this was going up in flames anyway, she might as well be the one to drop the match.

"I love you."

Adora froze in her tracks, immediately pulling back her fingers, too. Catra couldn't possibly have said that. Had she ever said that to Adora, even? Adora couldn't recall. It was far more likely she had drunk a little too much and was hearing things now, or maybe

it had just slipped out of Catra's mouth and Catra would much rather Adora not acknowledge it at all.

She looked down at Catra, waiting to be given any indication at all on how to proceed, and Catra stared back, not backing down - more tears dripping down her cheeks and chin. "I love you, okay? And I know you think you love me too, and that it wasn't fair to ask you to give everything up just to prove it to me. I just wish -" she growled, clearly frustrated at whatever her line of thinking was here, and let the sentence drop.

Catra had always been so composed in her presence - so careless. Even when she'd begged Adora to stay, in Half Moon, Adora hadn't seen her break under the pressure. Now, Adora leaned closer, as if to kiss her, and Catra's breath hitched like she'd been stabbed in the chest.

Adora had had no time to prepare for this, and she wasn't even entirely sure of what else she should say - all she'd wanted to do after closing the call had been to go look for Catra and deliver a mature, heartwarming speech that had her swooning, but the details had always been a bit fuzzy, and she'd never had to account for Catra confessing her love in the middle of it.

She pressed circles in the soft skin of Catra's hips, on the insides of her thighs, Catra's fluttering eyelashes the last thing she saw before resuming her mission to kiss Catra all over - kiss her into speechlessness, into breathlessness. She wanted Catra to give herself to her, for Catra's claws to sink into her back as her body shook, for her name to be the only thing on Catra's mind and tongue so she wouldn't even *think* about leaving her again. Catra loved her, and now Adora wanted, wanted, *wanted*.

"What do you want?" she asked again, her lips moving up to brush Catra's again. The simple gesture made her sigh into Adora's mouth. "Tell me. If I can give it to you, I will."

Catra released a groan, probably wanting to protest, but even that seemed to be too much for her at the time - Adora just cupped

the side of her face, swept a hand down her cheek, and wiped away her frown. Catra didn't usually lose herself that quick, but she also usually kept any emotions that weren't sadness and anger at bay. Whenever Adora managed to drown them out, she felt more powerful than any god - more powerful than she'd ever been as She-Ra.

Not saving the world, ruling Eternia, or any of her surface level achievements - making Catra feel good was the greatest miracle she was allowed to perform. And she might not know how to tell her that, or how to make her believe it, but she knew how to give her what she needed.

Catra stilled, and Adora lowered her arms to allow her to slip out of the embrace, if she needed. But Catra just stayed pressed against Adora's chest, quiet and unmoving, until Adora felt her clawed hand slipping under her hem and her head pulling back.

Catra's eyes opened, resolve clear in her face though it didn't reach her voice.

"Take off your dress," Catra decided. "I'm gonna take care of you tonight."

Adora shuddered above her, but that was all the reply Catra seemed to need, because she got up and yanked Adora up with her - pressed Adora up against the nearest wall, Catra draped over her, a knee between Adora's legs - and started kissing her.

Adora barely registered Catra tugging at the end of her dress, pulling it up slowly, but she felt her hands on her burning skin. Her mind drifted in and out, catching on to one sensation at a time, letting it build up until it ate her up from the inside.

It had to be the adrenaline crash. Adora usually cherished Catra's kisses and touches, could spend hours on those alone - but right now Adora couldn't think of anything but the bed two feet away from them, and despite her dropping hints - those being her legs

clenched tightly around Catra's waist - Catra seemed determined to ignore them and take her time.

It was a special kind of hell, being only steps away from where she really wanted to be, with no certainty she'd ever get there.

"Is that all?" Adora whispered between their lips. "Is that how you want it to end?"

Catra growled down her neck and throat, which did things to Adora that she refused to acknowledge. "God, can you stop being dramatic for one second and let me give you what you deserve, for once -"

"What I *deserve* is for you to tell me you won't walk away on me after this."

Catra was getting ready to scoff - probably because this was a really hypocritical request on Adora's part, but also, Adora liked to think, because she hadn't been able to put up this much of a fight once Adora touched her. Adora didn't melt - Adora had her mind on the objective at all times, and right now, that happened to be Catra.

"And look, I know I've been guilty of that in the past. I don't have all the answers - I barely have any of them, actually - but I want us to figure it out together. Whatever my life looks like, I want you to be in it, and I'm gonna fight everyday to make that a reality. That's not a promise - that's how it's going to be on my end, no matter what you decide. No matter if you want us to be together, or you only want to be friends, or you just want us to see each other at Princess Prom every ten years."

Catra's eyes had kept widening the longer Adora spoke, and by the end of it, her shoulders dropped in defeat. She was angry, but none of it seemed directed at Adora. "I was never going to do that, you idiot. I couldn't." Then more softly, and more importantly: "I don't want to."

She was still giving no indication as to what she'd do in the near future, but Adora suspected she didn't know, either, and she didn't want to push her. At least now, if Catra decided to leave, Adora knew she'd come back, which was more than she could've hoped for only two hours before.

"Then go. If you need space, or if they need you elsewhere, I'll be waiting for you. But if you want to stay - I'm yours."

"Adora," Catra winced, going back in to catch her mouth again, "don't say that, please."

Adora bit back a laugh. The euphoria starting to travel through her body already, just from Catra's lips, was making her light-headed. "You don't believe me? That's okay, I have a lot of time to prove you wrong. A lifetime, in fact."

She tried to say more - about how much she loved her, how she'd marry her one day; how Eternia didn't have her, and if they wanted her, they'd have to learn to share her - but she must have whimpered something inarticulate instead, because Catra hummed against her, tongues of fire licking into her, and she finally felt herself being picked up.

When Adora pictured them in the future, it wasn't on Eternia or Half Moon, and if it was any other place on Etheria, she didn't know it yet. But as she was laid down on the bed and her hands ran up and down Catra's body, hot and soft, she tried to project them there through sheer force of will, tried to imprint the same image in Catra's mind.

She felt it when it happened, the ebb and flow of her magic only resurfacing because Catra drew it out of her - the quick consumption, the burning point, the sudden relief.

"Catra," Adora panted out, but she felt a smile teasing the edges of her lips. "I know what to do with the Heart."

Chapter End Notes

The quote Catra takes from Adora's book, which also gives the fic its title, is from The Book Of Promethea by Hélène Cixous. Don't ask me why a copy of that would survive to make its way onto Adora's desk. I do not know.
Only one chapter left! I'm going to focus on my Big Bang fic until mid May, so I'm gonna pick this up again after that :)

Find me at @clacing on Tumblr and @catchradora on Twitter!

ALSO, because I always forget, have a link to the playlist for this fic!

Chapter 7

Chapter Notes

> I know it's been more than a year, but this story finally has a conclusion! I started writing this story in 2019, back when I thought it would be just a one shot - and then it only grew longer and longer, and I realized it might become too ambitious a project for me, but I still fully intended to see it to the very end - and after three years, I am! This is still one of the fics I care most intensely about and it feels unreal that it's finally done. I'm going to miss it.
>
> If you've waited this long, thank you so much, and I hope the wait was worth it.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora’s magic buzzed through her like a dragonfly. Its wings batted at her furiously, as if trying to take flight inside her and break out of her skin.

She imagined wrapping her hands around it, gently pushing it back into her chest. She found, to her surprise, that they shared a heartbeat - she and the dragonfly, and the two of them with everything that lived and breathed around them.

Adora looked up to the source of it, the pulsing warmth in front of her. Its surface reflected light from the torches that had been almost ritually lined up along the cave walls, recreating the uniquely unpleasant experience of being blinded by a spotlight while a faceless audience stared on the other side.

She subconsciously looked for Double Trouble, no doubt smirking somewhere in the crowd, wanting to ask *How do you do this all the time, public ceremonies on Eternia were bad enough,* but she must’ve looked more startled than she’d wanted to, ‘cause a hand breached the darkness to lay on Adora’s shoulder.

“You okay?” Catra asked. She sounded so concerned, her eyes squinting at Adora in the bright light. Without even waiting for an answer, she turned around and called out to someone: “Dude, can you put out a torch or two? You’re killing the mood here.”

The light dimmed almost immediately, and it was only now that Adora noticed the worried lines of her face. She would have done *anything* to get rid of them; she’d already hurt Catra so much, and Catra had hurt her back, and they would’ve kept running in circles around each other until someone put an end to it.

“You sure you want to do this?” Catra’s voice came again, probably thinking Adora was having second thoughts. “You don't have to.”

She absolutely *did*, was the thing. But for once, it didn’t bother her. Catra’s hand was now smoothing out the wrinkles on Adora’s dress jacket, and Adora looked at her and felt nothing but peace.

“I'm sure,” she said, and found she wasn’t lying.

She’d always asked herself who she would be without a destiny to fulfill, and if she could bear to outlive her usefulness. If she could stand looking at herself and seeing fractures where someone else's design used to keep her together. Today, she finally got to find out.

Say goodbye, the Heart’s glow was telling her - one last pull on her heartstrings, a parting touch.

Goodbye, Adora said, and she took Catra into her arms and kissed her.

It was a kiss that started at the hands; which was to say, Adora traced all the spaces between Catra’s fingers and all the lines of her palm, watching her fist slowly disclose like a flower bud to the light before their lips even touched. She smoothed out all of Catra’s creases and worries, nervous energy meeting quiet resolve until Catra gripped her fingers back. She seemed to want to say *I’m ready* and *Take whatever you need,* because when the thumb

that wasn't caressing Catra's hand brushed over her lips, they parted without resistance, her eyelids fluttering as if under the weight of dreams.

Adora closed her eyes too; they were unneeded. Even if she and Catra weren't so close already, even if she couldn't feel Catra's breath fanning over her face, she would find her in the dark. She could trace the outline of her with no fingers, because Catra's magic - not the Magicat powers that still lay dormant, but the one at the heart of her, the baseline of her - called to her own. Their lips met, and their magics recognized each other like old friends, which would keep being the case even when She-Ra was gone.

She felt the height of her power, the kind that had already led to the Heart firing, and would lead to it once more; but she also felt the stability of it, fed by purposefulness and nurtured by Catra's closeness. This was a power that longed to escape her reach, and all she had to do was free it. When she did - when she gave up control over it - it would call to the magic that was still locked up tight within the Heart, and then it would be up to Catra to absorb and stabilize it.

She took a deep breath and let go.

The door opened and shut behind her, cutting off all the noise from downstairs again, and a pair of arms were immediately around her middle.

"Found you." She felt Catra's smile pressed against her cheek, and then a kiss that lingered on Adora's skin long after Catra pulled away. "Hero of the hour."

"*Me*?" Adora scoffed. "Everyone out there is talking about you."

"Mmh. And is that why you're hiding?"

Adora wasn't *hiding*, thank you very much - and if she'd wanted to hide, she liked to think she would have chosen a much less

conspicuous place than *Catra's room*. "I just needed a break. Party got too loud."

"What, the music? Or the…"

"The music," Adora confirmed. "I can't feel the magic anymore."

Catra was quiet for a while, just taking in her words. Adora could tell she didn't know what to say to that, so she just dipped down and kissed Adora's shoulder.

"I'm sorry."

Adora's head dropped to the side to give Catra better access. She hummed, and Catra followed the sound, latching on to her throat. *That*, Adora still felt.

"Make it up to me, then."

"Now?" Catra chuckled - but her lips moved upwards, to her chin and jaw. "In the middle of a party in *our* honor?"

"Mmh. It's tradition." Her breath was growing fainter, heavier. Catra seemed all too happy to comply with her requests, kissing like it *hadn't* only been two hours since their last one. Maybe living their lives in overly controlled environments, both on the military *and* on the royal end, meant the thrill of secret intimacy would never quite go away; or maybe the quickly approaching goodbye was starving them already, even with nourishment still regularly reaching their mouths.

The situation was probably worse on Catra. She hadn't been privy to all of Adora's thoughts in the past week or so, hadn't read the letters she'd exchanged nor witnessed any of her reunions with the council - what Adora was planning took time, and a lot of daring and inquiring, and getting Catra's hopes up from the get-go probably wouldn't have done either of them any favors in the long run. But even though there was still a lot to be done, her design was getting clearer and clearer. She could almost touch it; maybe this was when she could finally hope to speak it.

Catra climbed on the bed with her, moving so that she sat in Adora's lap now instead of hovering behind her, and asked first. The joking tone hadn't disappeared completely, but there was a sadness to her now that Adora had grown all too used to seeing on her face. "When do you leave?"

Adora swallowed the last of her fear. "That depends on you."

There it was again - that smile. Adora would have given up her magic a thousand times over for it. "I'm honored, Adora, but if it were up to me I'd just keep you here forever, and none of us would ever get anything done again."

"Well, what if we didn't have to be on two different planets? What if we didn't have to be on *any* planet *at all*?"

Catra's head tilted to the side. "I'm not sure that's how physics works."

"What I'm saying is, there's a lot to be done all over the universe. Interplanetary communications to be tested, diplomatic relationships to be established, not to mention my brother might still be out there somewhere - *you* made me realize all of that, and you were right. But it's gonna be such a long project, and we're going to need someone to oversee it. Maybe multiple people."

"Okay. What are you getting at?"

"I *hate* ruling. I hate sitting around in a room all day, I hate the paperwork, I hate the power plays. I never wanted any of it. I just wanted to help, and they told me this was the way, but - maybe it's not the only one."

"Of course it's not." Her hands reached up to cup Adora's face. "You're the princess, Adora - one of the most powerful people in the *universe*. What's all that power worth if you can't even make things better for yourself?"

Some bright, flowery feeling fluttered in her chest. “So you’ll come with me?”

Catra asked “Come where?”, which *wasn’t a no*, and that was all Adora needed to latch on to keep going.

“Everywhere. I want to take charge of the operation, and I want you to be with me. Your people need someone to represent them all over the galaxy too - I can’t imagine anyone better than you.”

Catra’s smile was skewed. “That’s a little unfair. I’ve only been with the Magicats for less than two years, and there are far more experienced people than me out there. Wouldn’t want anyone to think you favor me.”

“Oh, you mean someone still has doubts?” She’d have thought if there still were any, they would have been vanquished when their kiss freed the magic locked in the Heart of Etheria. After all she and Catra did for them, surely they wouldn’t resent them *that.*

Catra pretended to get mad at the idea, but eventually turned deadly serious when Adora pressed her forehead to hers and doubled down on her proposal. “Take whoever you want with you. Whoever you think is fit for the job. As long as you and I stay together.”

Catra’s frown only deepened. Adora decided she needed to take a step back - she didn’t want to scare her off. “If you want to, that is.”

She couldn’t understand why Catra *wouldn’t* want to. It was the only solution that would work out in both of their favors, and she seriously doubted the two of them could find anything better. It seemed so silly, to dare Adora to prove that she actually cared about their relationship, have her decide to uproot her entire life, and then turn her down in the end.

But Catra would be uprooting her entire life, too - a life that, unlike Adora, she was finally happy with. It wasn’t a decision she could expect Catra to make lightly.

“Can I think about it?” she asked, barely louder than a whisper - like she was afraid her hesitation might be taken as rejection.

Adora looked at her, ran her fingers through Catra’s hair until Catra closed her eyes in bliss, fully relaxed again. “Of course. Take all the time you need.” She cleared her throat. “There’s still so much to be done on Eternia, and it’ll be a while before I can get everything settled - a few months, at least. So there’s no rush. I just ask - that if you know right now this is not something you want, you tell me, so I can gear myself up for a goodbye. Because once I leave, I-I don’t know when I’ll be back here.”

Catra squinted up at her. “That’s really what you want? Regardless of what I choose?”

“I’d love it if you came along.” She touched her forehead to Catra’s, breathing her in. Catra drowsily ran her hands down the side of her face. “But only if it’s what’s right for you. Because I think it’s what’s right for me.”

She felt Catra nodding, brushing her thumb over her cheek. “Then it’s not a no,” she murmured. “I do need to think about it, but - I’m proud of you, nonetheless.”

Adora wasn’t expecting to get choked up at something so simple. Catra hadn’t even given her a definite answer, but she’d told her she was *proud* of her - wasn’t that enough? Wasn’t this secretly what she wanted to hear, all along?

She wouldn’t outright *cry* in front of her, not over this - but it did take her a while for her to be able to speak again.

“I’m gonna stay for one more week, alright? And it’s fine if you don’t have an answer by then - you can still reach out to me anytime. But I do want to spend as much time as I can with you, in case the answer turns out to be no.”

Catra smiled. “That’s fair.” She got up from the bed, never letting go of Adora’s hand, and never taking her eyes off her, either.

“Come on, let’s go back. It would be rude for us not to dance at the party in our honor, you know. Downright unforgivable.”

The days went by quickly, and Adora spent all of them in Catra’s company.

Adora barely ever was away from her for more than an hour at a time, to everyone’s dismay - how quickly they’d forgotten about the kiss that freed the magic still trapped in the Heart, and gone right back into annoying sibling mode - but Adora secretly cherished that too. She hoped Catra would stay around for a long while, and that also meant dealing with her friends, her family and her people. It felt good for their relationship to finally be acknowledged at all - this was no longer just a thing in Adora’s head, or some dirty secret between the two of them that they had to keep away from everyone else - it was out there in the open, something for people to comment upon and roll their eyes at and tease about. Adora had never felt more consequential.

It was even more surprising, to Adora, to learn so much about Catra in such a short amount of time. After being together their whole lives, she could’ve sworn there was nothing about Catra that she didn’t already know - but then she learned about how she liked her coffee, and that overtime she’d turned into a much heavier sleeper ‘cause her nerves stopped being on high alert all the time, and that there were still people calling her “Catra of Barf Moon” because of an unfortunate incident in her first few weeks as a leader. She learned about her favorite flowers, and her favorite foods, and how she liked to be kissed when they didn’t have to rush.

Catra hadn’t changed in the years apart, but she’d come into her own, discovered new sides of her character that it was now up to Adora to unveil, bit by bit. All she wished for was that she could keep doing it forever, but only if Catra wanted to - and that was honestly still unclear. The day of her departure inched closer and

closer, and Catra hadn't brought up Adora's plan of traveling together once - not to accept it, and not to shoot it down.

Catra had found herself here; most importantly, she'd found her family, and she'd known peace for the first time in her life. She'd thought it a no-brainer, at first, that Catra would say yes, but it was only now that she could see the bigger picture that she understood just how much she was asking Catra to give up.

So she wouldn't push her. She'd waited most of her life for her and Catra to be on the same page - she could wait longer. It wasn't a matter of *if*, but of *when*. Until then, they'd just have to follow their separate courses.

Adora still clung to her a bit tighter every night, hoping she wouldn't notice.

Adora didn't wake Catra up on the day she was meant to leave. She disentangled her body from hers quietly, tip-toed over to where she'd left her shoes, and got dressed in silence. They'd refused to say goodbye the night before, because it would have meant deciding it *was* a goodbye, and so there was no point trying again in the morning.

"This is stupid," Catra had pointed out when Adora had started to get teary-eyed. "It's not like you're *dying*. You're not even actually leaving on any missions for a while yet."

"I know, I *know*." But she *was* leaving Half Moon, not knowing when she'd see Catra again. No one could blame her for being a bit sniffly.

"And I haven't made my choice yet. So worry about getting your affairs in order for now, okay?"

Adora would. She'd already sent a letter to the council explaining her decisions, asking them to come up with a plan together to ensure a safe redistribution of power, and to start training select

court members to be able to join her on diplomatic missions. Then they'd have to start reaching out to other planets, planning meetings, consolidating alliances and trade routes - but for now, she preferred to focus on the few simple things she was still allowed, like getting Catra's breakfast up to her to wake up to and kissing her forehead for one last time.

Her ship was waiting for her above ground, in the dim early morning light, so Adora wouldn't be blinded after days spent in the dark. No one followed her - she hadn't wanted an entourage - but Mira had insisted she take some food for the trip, and all of Catra's siblings had already hugged her goodbye the night before.

So, Adora was alone. She opened the doors to the ship and stepped in, dragging her suitcase behind her. She'd need to change into something warmer for the space travel before pressurized air started to fill the cabin and the temperature dropped like crazy, so she went straight into the dressing room to gear up.

When she came back out, she headed for the front of the ship, where the commands were - and stopped.

Something had shifted in the air, like space was being filled differently - like some small rearrangement of matter had occurred, some breath drawn that shouldn't have been taken. She felt a tug at the mouth of her stomach, where her magic used to be, and she realized.

"Hey, Adora."

She turned around.

Catra was casually leaning back against the entrance to the commands room, her arms crossed on her chest and a smirk on her face that was too shy to come off as convincing.

Adora could never *not* be glad to see Catra, but she wasn't ready to do this now. She'd thought they'd mutually agreed to skip over this part. "What are you doing here?"

Catra pushed off the doorstep and stepped - no, *sprinted* through the room in complete silence until she got to where Adora was standing, and Adora froze as Catra grabbed her face, her lips stopping inches from hers.

"I'm coming with you," she said - then closed the distance between them.

She kissed Adora with the knowledge of having all the time in the world in front of them. She kissed her deeply, intently, unapologetically - taking her time because she could, because there was no chance of the next kiss being the last, and no one watching. She kissed her like a luxury they could finally afford, and Adora gladly let her.

"What - *now*?" Adora muttered when she broke the kiss off to breathe, before Catra latched onto her again.

"On your mission. I'm coming with you."

Adora tried to keep Catra's head still so she could kiss her properly, but she was shaking too badly. She missed her lips and landed by a non-specific point near the jaw. "Are you sure?"

Catra didn't reply, didn't even nod; she just kept kissing her and kissing her and not letting her go, until both of them were giggling so much that the sound filled every nook and crevice of the ship and their teeth clacked together again and again, and Adora was allowed to rest her head on Catra's shoulder instead.

This was a years-long commitment, and Catra was willing to stand by her through it. She was willing to be part of it, to be with her always like they were for the last week. They wouldn't have to make the most of every single moment to make up for all the months they wouldn't spend together.

They could make it. If they wanted to, they could finally, finally make it.

The wedding started in less than thirty minutes, and Adora was nowhere to be found.

Despite her beginnings, traveling as a galactically recognized official for five years had come with a long list of responsibilities - first among them, to show up on time so as not to blow your chances of making yourself heard. As a result, Catra had come to dislike being late, and the embarrassment that came from it, almost as much as she disliked not knowing where Adora was. As soon as they'd touched ground, the night before, Glimmer had snatched her up, started talking her ear off about table arrangements and wedding dresses and bouquets of flowers, and forbade Catra from following them.

Catra had found it absolutely ridiculous - she knew it was tradition to separate the bride and groom the night before getting married, but she'd never heard of that applying to their *guests* - but she was getting way too old to keep letting Glimmer get under her skin.

She would, however, be pissed if she didn't give Adora back soon. It had been twelve hours; Catra *missed* her. Most importantly, she didn't want to miss the wedding - there was a long list of events one could, and very likely should, be fashionably late to, and the wedding of the Queen of Bright Moon, who was also one of your best friends, wasn't one of them.

That's when Adora threw open the door and swept through the room like a summer storm.

"*I'm sorry*," she said, immediately starting to take off her clothes from the night before. Catra found her little skips into place as she

tried to free herself of her pants way too cute for her own good. "Glimmer has been going through something."

Catra smiled amiably up at her from where she lay back on a pillow. "Yeah, no shit. Did she puke?"

"What, from the party or from like, nerves?"

"Either."

Adora shuddered - perhaps at the memory, or perhaps because of the chill. She was down to her undergarments now. "Yeah."

"Damn. Wish I'd been there."

"You *really* don't. Trust me." But Catra caught the shadow of a smile, so it couldn't have been that bad. "Had better luck with Bow?"

"He's a sad drunk. I *hate* sad drunks."

"I know, baby."

"Halfway through the night, he started crying 'cause he missed Glimmer too much. Sea Hawk and I had to strap him down to a chair."

"Well, I don't think those two have spent more than a few hours apart since they made up. That must have been excruciating."

"Gee. I wonder who that reminds me of."

She stared straight at Adora, waiting for her to get it, and nearly had her breath taken away.

Adora had finally emerged from the bridesmaid dress Glimmer had laid out for her on the bed, and she looked *radiant*. Adora had always looked gorgeous in white - Catra would know - and while the dress wasn't *entirely* white, hidden under a transparent, gold-leaning coating of glitter, this was no exception. It helped that,

while she was taken hostage, Glimmer had made sure Adora had at least her hair and make-up done to save them time - even uncharacteristically curling Adora's hair, so that long blonde waves framed her face for once - but it was her eyes that gave Catra pause, the soft look they held that was reserved for Catra only.

Catra *loved* her. They'd both fought to get to the point where they could be in the same room like this, talk to each other with this level of ease. They'd spent way too much time away from each other because of pride, and weakness, and misguided ideas of self-sufficiency - and now that they'd made the conscious decision to make their life paths cross again, Catra wasn't throwing away another minute. If Glimmer and Bow wanted to spend the eve of their wedding in separate rooms and with separate people for the sake of tradition, that was *their* problem; Catra resented having to be part of it.

Adora always was much nicer than her. "Maybe that's why they picked us for the task."

With one last smile thrown over her shoulder, she offered her arm to Catra, and Catra grabbed it, fixing the cape around her shoulder with her other hand.

They walked through the Bright Moon corridors together, coming across a few more late-comers. They saw a little girl furiously batting her tiny wings and Spinnerella and Netossa running after her, begging her to come down so they could go sit already; they saw Bright Moon guards getting ready to leave their posts and join the others in the throne room; they even caught a glimpse of Entrapta from the vents overhead, presumably also making her way there through less conventional means.

"Wanna know what I think?" Catra asked, seemingly out of nowhere. "About why they asked us?"

Adora knocked their shoulders together. "Let's hear it."

“I think Sparkles was afraid that if she left us alone for too long, the whole wedding blues would get to us, and then one of us would propose at her wedding and ruin her special day.”

Adora unfortunately burst out laughing right when they crossed the entrance to the throne room, which resulted in the last few rows of sitting guests turning to look at them. Catra and Adora both raised her hands in apology *and* salutation - with particular regard to Bow, looking perfectly dapper and very nervous at the altar.

“Honestly? I bet that’s it,” Adora whispered back. “Can’t wait to see their faces when we tell them tomorrow.”

They walked down the aisle to get to Bow, to the spot where they’d wait for Glimmer to come in. It was all very familiar to Catra, but familiar in the way seeing kids in public could be when you didn’t have any of your own. She and Adora had had an aisle, but no people to fill it - it had been too far away from everyone they loved, too sudden for them to be able to do anything about it. Once it was decided, they hadn’t wanted to wait any longer.

Catra had just gotten used to calling Adora her girlfriend, loudly and publicly - and then one day, the word just hadn’t felt like enough anymore. After sidestepping Adora’s proposals, implicit and explicit alike, for years, the ball had been undeniably in Catra’s court - so on their trip to the Pink Cliffs to celebrate their fifth anniversary, Catra had gotten down on one knee and presented her with a ring.

If Catra brushed Adora’s finger, she could still feel the bump where the ring usually was - and if she looked closely, she could see the patch of skin that was slightly less tan on the second knuckle. But no one had noticed so far, and they planned to keep it that way.

“Let them have their day,” Catra agreed. “We’re going to have a lot to talk about.”

The music started playing behind them, signaling Glimmer's arrival, and everyone, including them, scurried off to their designated places.

But there was a moment, right before they split - Adora to the left of the altar, Catra next to Bow on the right - where Adora tightened her grip on Catra's arm, and pressed a kiss to Catra's covered shoulder like she wanted to sear a mark into her skin through her clothes.

The truth is this: my love for you is the only empire I will ever build.
When it falls, as all empires do, my career in empire building will be over.
I will retreat to an island. I will dabble in the vacation-hut industry.
I will skulk about the private libraries and public parks.
I will fold the clean clothes. I will wash the dishes.
I will never again dream of having the whole world.

- Mindy Nettifee, This is the Nonsense of Love

Chapter End Notes

Quote at the end is the quote that inspired the entire fic.

Find me on Tumblr and Twitter and check out the fic's playlist!

End Notes

Throwback to when I projected all of my emotional issues onto Adora, spent MONTHS worrying she would come across as too OOC, only for the graphic novel to confirm that I was right all along

This fic will most likely have between 3 and 5 chapters. 5 would be ideal but I'm a very slow writer who can't handle that kind of commitment. That said, I care about this fic a lot so if I leave it unfinished you have permission to come beat me up

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!